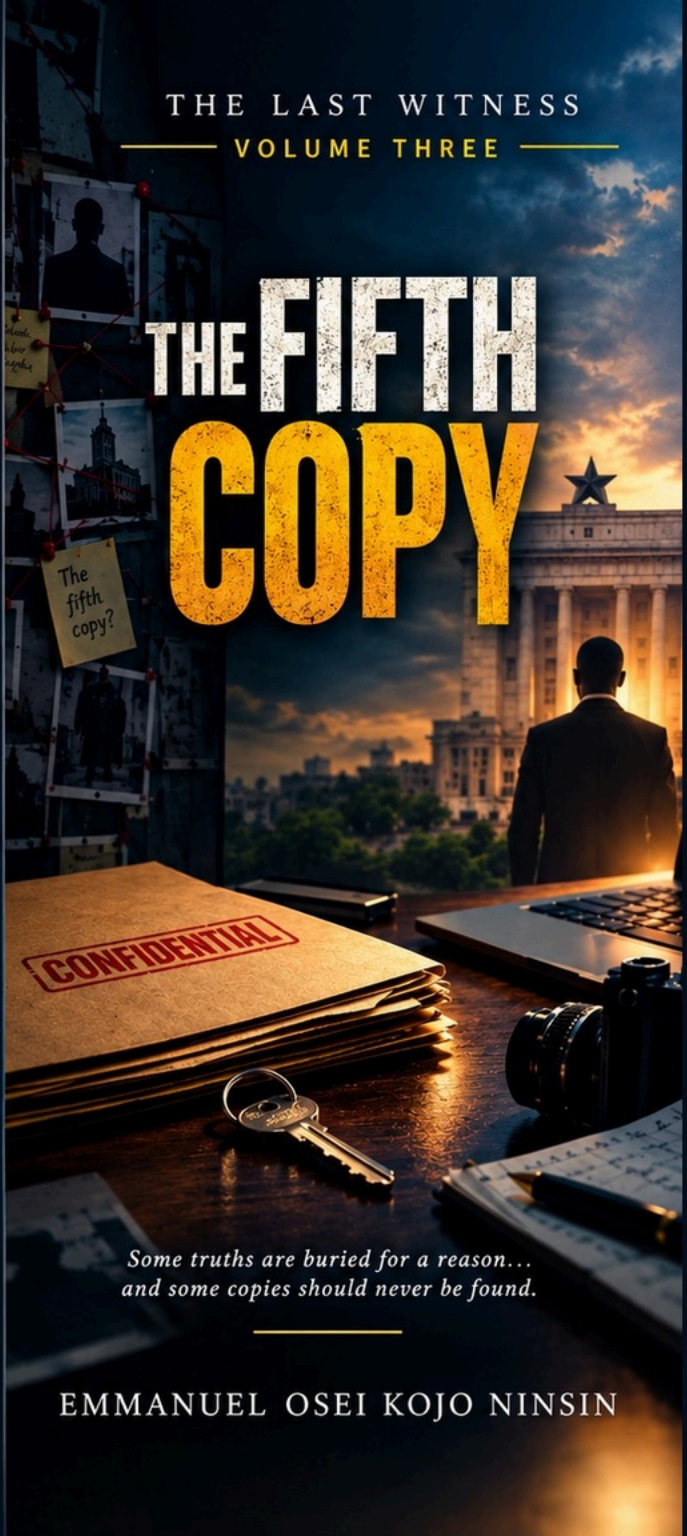

THE LAST WITNESS
VOLUME THREE
THE FIFTH COPY
The fifth copy?
CONFIDENTIAL
Some truths are buried for a reason…
and some copies should never be found.
EMMANUEL OSEI KOJO NINSIN

THE LAST WITNESS

VOLUME THREE

Emmanuel Osei Kojo Ninsin

DEDICATION

This book is dedicated to all young people who dare to dream, work hard, and believe in a better tomorrow.

To every person who keeps seeking truth, even when silence would be easier, and to those who believe that justice must be guided by courage, patience, and evidence.

May your dreams never be limited by your circumstances.

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PART ONE — THE RECORD THAT WAS NEVER FILED

CHAPTER ONE — THE COPY THAT WAS NEVER FILED

The envelope reached the records office on a Tuesday morning. A messenger signed the delivery book and left before anyone thought to ask why the address was handwritten.

It looked ordinary: brown paper, two folds, tape across the flap. There was no wax seal, warning label, or official crest. Only the reference number in the upper-right corner stood out. It belonged to a series the archive catalogue said had ended years earlier.

By ten o’clock, the envelope lay inside a clear evidence sleeve on Detective Superintendent Kwame Badu’s desk. Mabel Owusu stood opposite him with her notebook open. Neither touched the sleeve.

Rain had crossed the city before dawn, streaking the registry windows and shining across the courtyard. By the time Badu arrived, the morning queue had formed: clerks carrying folders, visitors clutching letters, and a courier balancing a cardboard box against his hip. Business continued around the sealed envelope. If the item mattered, its arrival had given the building no warning.

“Who received it first?” Badu asked.

“The registry clerk,” the archivist said. “She logged it at eight forty-six. The messenger signed the book but gave no name beyond the one on the delivery slip.”

“And the slip?”

“Inside the sleeve. We photographed it before moving anything.”

Badu studied the envelope through the plastic. The reference number seemed familiar, though not like a name he knew. He had seen it on three documents that disagreed: a transfer entry, a catalogue card, and a dispatch record whose final character might be B or 8.

“What does the sender claim?” Mabel asked.

“The covering note calls it a fifth copy of the supplementary schedule.” The archivist paused. “It also says the original was never destroyed.”

Efua Mensah had spent years distinguishing a missing record from one that had merely been moved. People often treated the terms as interchangeable, especially when angry. A missing record invited suspicion; a relocated one demanded patience. She had not called the schedule missing until the dispatch trail failed to locate it. Even then, her notes said “not located.” The phrase was less satisfying, but more accurate.

“Who wrote that description?” Badu asked, indicating the words fifth copy.

“The covering note. Not the registry clerk.”

“Then the log must record it as the sender’s claim, not the item’s established identity.” Badu turned to the evidence officer. “Use that wording.”

The room seemed to tighten around the distinction. The schedule had begun as a possibility, become a trail through a dispatch ledger, and ended as a question no surviving document could answer. Now someone claimed to have a copy. A discovery like that could make an investigation outrun its evidence.

Badu left the envelope unopened. “Who has handled it since delivery?”

“The registry clerk, Efua, and the evidence officer who sealed it. All three are listed. CCTV covers the counter, but not the public corridor.”

“Preserve the footage. Obtain the original delivery book, not a photocopy. Have the clerk give her own account before anyone tells her what the note claims.”

Mabel recorded the instructions. “If it really is the schedule, it could tell us what happened to the fifth child.”

“It could,” Badu said. “It could also be a later reconstruction, an inaccurate copy, or a deliberate fabrication. We don’t yet know what we have.”

Efua folded her hands. “The reference number is genuine.”

She sounded cautious, not triumphant. She had seen a correct detail become the foundation of a false

conclusion. She took a small notebook from her bag and divided the number into two columns: characters that were clear and those that remained uncertain.

“The catalogue card gives the final character as B,” she said. “The dispatch ledger could read B or 8. The transfer entry has been overwritten. I’ve seen clerks make each kind of mistake, and later clerks copy those mistakes faithfully.”

“Can the original ledger settle it?” Badu asked.

“It may help. The ink, pen pressure, sequence of entries, and surrounding numbers could tell us something. But an original can still be wrong. ‘Original’ means it is the earliest surviving version we have, not that it is accurate.”

Mabel glanced at the notebook. “You have a way of making every answer open another door.”

“That is what records do,” Efua said. “They are not witnesses who remember everything. They are objects made by people, under rules, with whatever knowledge and motives those people had at the time.”

Badu asked Efua to keep the notebook as working notes and to add nothing to the official register until the team had photographed the relevant entries. He wanted the archive’s procedures documented separately from the police examination. If the work were challenged later, no one should have to guess which observations belonged to which process.

“A genuine number can be copied onto a false document,” Badu said. “A genuine document can also be described incorrectly. We need to establish the paper’s history before deciding what it means.”

He instructed the evidence officer to record the sleeve’s condition and photograph every side of the envelope. They would open it under controlled conditions, with each step witnessed and logged. If the contents proved relevant, every page would be numbered and examined without marking the original. A document examiner could assess the paper, ink, typeface, and signs of reproduction; none of those tests alone would identify the sender.

Mabel watched the evidence officer prepare the table. Since the first register entry surfaced, she had learned that a document could matter and still prove too little. A record might preserve a fact while concealing the circumstances around it. A blank space could mean removal, a separate filing system, or a catalogue error. It was tempting to turn uncertainty into a story, though uncertainty was harder to explain to readers.

She had no intention of making that mistake again.

The evidence room had no windows. A stainless-steel table stood beneath overhead lights that flattened every shadow. A wall clock ticked above the cabinet for sealed exhibits. Sergeant Lartey, the evidence officer, read the seal number aloud while another officer recorded it. They photographed the envelope

beside a scale and reference card, then documented its folds, tape, stains, and handwritten number. Badu watched without directing them. He wanted a record of what the officers actually did, not a polished account reconstructed later.

“If the sender handled this without gloves, can we get a useful print?” Mabel asked quietly.

“Possibly, possibly not,” Lartey replied. “Paper absorbs oils, and later handling can complicate the results. We won’t promise anything before the laboratory examines it.”

Badu added that the envelope should be tested only after the examiner had considered what could be learned without consuming or damaging the material. They would preserve the option of further examination instead of rushing toward the most dramatic test.

Inside were a single sheet and a thin carbon copy folded behind it. The covering note was brief, typed, and unsigned. It said the enclosed page had been copied from a supplementary schedule associated with the confidential review. It gave no date for the copying and named no one responsible. At the bottom, someone had added a sentence in blue ink:

THE FIFTH COPY WAS MADE FOR THE PERSON WHO WAS NOT SUPPOSED TO KNOW.

The archivist leaned forward but kept her hands at her sides. The sentence struck Mabel as a threat, though it might have been written to produce exactly that effect.

Badu read it twice. “Record the wording exactly. Do not interpret it in the evidence log.”

The next sheet contained a table of typed entries. Some lines were faint; one had been struck through and retyped. A column heading gave a review date from the period under investigation. Another column contained abbreviated codes. No full name appeared beside the fifth line. Instead, a short horizontal mark pointed to an attachment that was missing.

Mabel wanted to ask whether the mark indicated that a name had been deliberately removed. She held back until the document examiner had seen the page.

“Can we compare it with the register?” she asked.

“After the initial examination and imaging,” Badu said. “The comparison should be documented. We must not handle the original more than necessary.”

The archivist studied the copy through the clear sleeve. “Its format resembles the schedules used by the department.”

“Resembles,” Badu repeated, gently. “That is useful. It isn’t authentication.”

Before the envelope was opened, Badu asked everyone present to state their role for the record. Efua said she had not seen the item until the clerk logged it. Lartey

confirmed that he had received the sealed sleeve from the registry and had not opened it. Mabel identified herself as a journalist assisting with the inquiry, not as a custodian of the exhibit. The distinctions sounded formal, but they could matter if anyone later challenged the handling of the page.

The seal was cut without damaging the original flap. Each step was photographed. The covering note, sheet, and carbon copy were separated only after their positions had been documented. Lartey assigned temporary exhibit labels and placed each item in a separate protective sleeve. The original envelope was retained; it was not discarded as mere packaging.

A second officer arrived with the registry footage on an encrypted drive and a signed record of its export. The footage showed the clerk accepting an envelope from a man whose face was partly obscured by a reflection in the counter glass. He wore a pale shirt and carried no visible bag. The timestamp placed the delivery at 8:43, three minutes before the entry in the registry book. The difference might have reflected the clerk’s routine, but Badu asked for it to be recorded and checked rather than dismissed.

Before leaving, the messenger paused and turned his head toward the corridor leading to the archive rooms. Then he walked out of view. That movement could not establish that he knew the building or had been watching anyone. It was simply what the recording showed.

“Can we identify him?” Mabel asked.

“We can ask building security to review the entrance cameras and preserve any footage that still exists,” Badu said. “We can also trace the delivery route. A reflection and a guess won’t identify a person.”

The registry clerk, Adomaa, gave her statement in a small interview room beside the public counter. She seemed irritated by the attention rather than frightened. A queue had formed while she was away from her desk, and she kept glancing at the door as if she could hear the unanswered questions waiting outside.

“I checked the address, stamped the book, and placed the envelope in the incoming tray,” she said. “That is the usual procedure.”

“Did the messenger say what was inside?” Badu asked.

“No. He asked whether the records office was still receiving deliveries at that counter. I told him yes.”

“Did he ask for a particular officer?”

“No.” She paused. “He did look at the sign behind me. I thought he was checking that he had the right office.”

“Did he seem to know you?”

“I cannot say. He did not call me by name.”

Badu let the silence stand. He had learned that an interviewer who rushed to fill every pause could give a witness the shape of an answer. Adomaa added that

the messenger had carried a folded receipt, though she could not remember whether he kept it or left it on the counter. The delivery book and footage might clarify the detail; her memory alone could not.

When the statement was read back to her, Adomaa corrected one phrase. First she had said the man “left immediately”; now she said he “left after a short pause.” Badu preserved both the original wording and the correction. The difference was slight, but small differences could grow when repeated by people who wanted a clean story.

That evening, Badu asked the building’s security supervisor to explain the camera system to the team. The supervisor acknowledged that the corridor camera had been offline twice that month and that the entrance camera overwrote footage after a limited retention period. He could not guarantee that a useful image of the messenger still existed. Badu requested the maintenance log, retention policy, and a written statement identifying which cameras had been working at the time. The system’s limitations might invite suspicion, but they did not establish tampering; they had to be documented first.

Mabel wrote in her notebook’s margin: “What survives is not always what mattered; what fails to survive is not automatically stolen.” She underlined the sentence once and closed the notebook. She did not want it to become a slogan that excused poor recordkeeping. It

was a reminder to ask what each fact could actually support.

That afternoon, Daniel Sarpong arrived with his adviser after being told that a new document might relate to the records under review. Before showing him a certified image of the table, Badu explained what the team knew—and what it did not. Daniel read the image slowly. He spent little time on the blank fifth line; his attention settled on the reference number.

“I have seen that number before,” he said.

Mabel waited. Badu did not prompt him.

“Not on a document. On an envelope my mother kept with old school papers. I remember the number because it was written on the back, and she told me never to throw it away. I can’t say whether it was the same number or whether my memory is accurate.”

“Do you still have the envelope?” Badu asked.

“I may. I would need to look through the papers. I will not bring anything in without telling my adviser.”

“That is the right approach,” Badu said. “If you find it, don’t mark it, clean it, or rearrange anything inside. Contact us, and we’ll explain how to document it.”

Daniel looked again at the image. “Does this prove there were five children?”

“No,” Badu said. “It suggests that a document described as a schedule may have contained a fifth line. We still have to establish whether the copy is authentic, what the line meant, and whether it connects to the other records.”

“And if it is real?”

“Then it may give us another piece of the history. It will not answer every question by itself.”

Daniel returned the image to the table. He seemed disappointed, though not surprised. “I’m tired of papers that promise to tell me who I was.”

Daniel’s adviser, Ms. Serwaa Boateng, had asked that the meeting remain within the subjects Daniel wished to discuss. She had also requested that he see a copy, not the original. Badu had agreed. Daniel had spent too long being treated as though his personal history belonged to whichever office held a file. The inquiry needed his cooperation, but it did not give investigators ownership of his past.

“If you find the envelope,” Ms. Boateng said, “we should document where it was kept and who has had access to it. We shouldn’t assume it’s connected just because the number looks familiar.”

Daniel nodded. “I can tell you what I remember. I cannot promise the paper will say what I hope it says.”

“That is enough for now,” Badu replied. “We need a careful account, not a convenient one.”

“This paper can’t decide who you are,” Mabel said. “At most, it can help us understand what people recorded and what they did with those records.”

For the first time since entering the room, Daniel looked directly at her. “Then make sure you find out who made the copy.”

After Daniel left, Badu added the request to the case plan. The team would examine the document, trace its delivery, compare the reference number with the original catalogue and dispatch records, and search for any surviving envelope or correspondence linked to Daniel’s family. Each task would have a named officer and a recorded outcome. No one was to leap from resemblance to conclusion.

At dusk, Mabel reviewed the typed note again. The line about someone who was not supposed to know invited a question: who had been excluded from the truth, and who had decided that the exclusion was necessary? The note might have come from a witness, or from someone trying to steer the team toward a chosen suspect. Until the sender was identified, the sentence could not serve as an explanation.

She was closing her notebook when the evidence officer returned with one final observation from the initial visual examination. The sheet appeared to have been produced on a modern printer rather than on the typewriter used for several surviving departmental schedules. That did not make its contents false: a

legitimate copy could have been reproduced decades later. It did, however, give the examiner another question to test.

Badu read the observation and nodded. “Good. That gives us a question we can test.”

The document examiner, Dr. Kusi, joined them by video later that afternoon. He did not try to identify a printer from a single visual feature. Instead, he requested high-resolution images, the sheet’s dimensions, its paper weight if that could be measured without damage, and known comparison documents from the same department and period.

“I can describe what the page is consistent with,” he said. “I may be able to rule out some production methods. But I cannot turn a visual impression into a date. Nor can I identify who typed or printed it unless the evidence supports that conclusion.”

Mabel had expected a more decisive answer from the laboratory. She recognised her disappointment and wrote it in the margin—not as a fact about the case, but as a reminder that impatience could easily masquerade as intuition.

“Could someone have copied an authentic schedule years later?” she asked.

“Certainly. Someone could also have made a false page using details copied from authentic records. A genuine page might have been reprinted for a legitimate reason, too. Those are competing possibilities.

Examination can narrow them, but the document's history matters as much as the technology."

When the call ended, Badu instructed the team to obtain comparison material through formal channels. No one was to carry an original file out of the archive simply because it might prove useful. A documented request, a logged transfer, and a named custodian took longer than an informal favour, but they protected the investigation and the people whose records were being examined.

Mabel looked again at the fifth line. It contained no name, only a mark and a reference to a missing attachment. The line had survived in this copy, but how—and why—remained unknown. If the document was genuine, it might preserve an omission. If it was false, it might have been designed to make them believe the omission mattered.

Back at the newsroom, Mabel drafted a paragraph describing the document as an alleged copy. Her editor circled *alleged* and asked whether it sounded evasive. She explained that the document had not been authenticated and that the sender's description proved nothing. "If we call it the fifth copy today," she said, "tomorrow we may have to explain why we turned a claim into a fact." He left the wording unchanged, though he asked her to keep pursuing the story.

Either way, the next step was the same: follow the record back to its source.

At the newsroom, Mabel's editor, Kojo Frimpong, read the draft without speaking. He had learned not to interrupt her first pass. She had learned that his silence usually meant he was testing how much of a story could stand without the writer beside it to explain.

"You have a document described as a fifth copy," he said at last. "You have an empty line. You have an anonymous message. What do you actually know?"

"That the envelope was delivered, logged, sealed, and opened under observation. That the page contains an unnamed fifth line and refers to an attachment we haven't located. That the document hasn't been authenticated."

"And what can we publish?"

"That investigators are examining an unverified document and tracing its provenance. Not that a fifth child has been found. Not that anyone destroyed a file. Not that the judge's murder has been explained."

Kojo tapped the draft. "That is accurate. It may also be frustrating to readers."

"Readers deserve to know the difference between a lead and a conclusion."

He considered the headline, then removed "The Missing Child's Secret File." "This one would have brought clicks," he said. "It would also have claimed more than we can prove."

Mabel did not thank him. They both knew restraint was not a favour to her; it was part of the work. She changed the headline to say that investigators were examining an alleged archival copy. The story would be shorter and less dramatic—and harder to misuse as proof of a claim it did not support.

Before sending it for legal review, she added a final sentence: the document's significance, if any, would depend on authentication and comparison with independent records. It was not a sentence designed to make anyone gasp. She kept it anyway.

At 7:18 p.m., a message arrived on the secure case phone from an unregistered number. It contained no greeting and no explanation.

You have the copy now. Do not ask who made it. Ask who ordered five.

Badu saved the message, logged the time, and ordered a metadata preservation request. Mabel copied the sentence into her notebook without adding a theory beside it.

She recorded the message's arrival separately from the document itself. The secure phone was photographed, the message preserved, and the number flagged for lawful follow-up. No one replied. Badu warned the team not to send a challenge or invitation that might alert the sender to their investigative steps. If another

message arrived, they would handle it as potential evidence, not as a conversation to win.

Outside, the city moved through evening traffic, carrying people home beneath a sky darkening over the coast. In the office, the envelope sat sealed in its evidence sleeve: ordinary brown paper wrapped around a question that had grown more dangerous, but no closer to an answer.

The Delivery Book

The following afternoon, Badu returned to the records office with a specific request: he wanted to examine the delivery book for the week the envelope arrived. He did not ask staff to identify the messenger from memory. He requested the original entry, the page before it, and the page after it. An isolated line could not show whether the book had been altered or whether an ordinary practice explained the handwriting.

The clerk retrieved the book from a locked drawer and placed it on a foam support. Its binding had loosened at the spine, and several pages had been repaired with clear tape. The delivery entry was there, but the handwriting changed halfway through the line. The signature had been made with a different pen, and the time had been written above the ruled space instead of inside it. Badu had the details photographed. None, by itself, proved deception.

“We often had two people working the counter,” the clerk said. “One wrote the incoming item; the other signed for the messenger if the first person had stepped away.”

He then asked whether the book recorded the messenger’s identity elsewhere. The clerk showed him the daily courier sheet, which listed a service name but no individual driver. The service had since changed contractors. A receipt from the same week carried a

similarly handwritten address, but it concerned an unrelated file and bore a different reference number.

Badu compared the entries carefully, keeping resemblance separate from identity. The handwriting on the envelope might belong to a staff member, a messenger, or someone outside the office. The time that appeared to have been altered might reflect a correction, a late entry, or an irregularity requiring further checks. He requested a statement from the clerk and a certified scan of the relevant pages.

As Badu was leaving, the clerk mentioned that messengers sometimes waited near the public counter while staff checked addresses. An old camera covered the waiting area, but its footage-retention period had long since expired. Badu recorded that fact—not as a lost answer, but as a limit on what could now be established.

Outside, afternoon traffic surged around the building in waves. Badu paused beneath the awning and looked at the photocopy in his folder. The envelope had entered the office through an ordinary procedure that now seemed riddled with gaps. He reminded himself that a gap was not evidence of a hidden hand. It marked the point where the next question had to begin.

The Delivery Book: Second Examination

By noon, Badu had examined the delivery book three times. The first inspection had been quick, the second

suspicious, and the third methodical enough to make the records clerk fold his arms. Badu did not mind. Impatience could make a minor discrepancy look like a revelation when it was only a minor discrepancy.

“You are looking at the same line,” the clerk said.

“I’m looking at the spaces around it.” Badu placed a ruler beneath the entry. The messenger’s signature sat neatly inside the box, but the time had been written close to its border. The address was in another hand. None of this proved anything. It did suggest, however, that the book recorded two separate acts: someone had prepared the delivery information, and someone else had acknowledged receipt.

The clerk explained that couriers sometimes arrived with labels already filled in, particularly when a department expected a packet. Badu asked whether a label might have been prepared the day before. It could, the clerk said. Was that usual? “Usual” depended on who was sending the packet and how much trouble they thought it might contain.

Badu requested a certified copy of the relevant page and a note describing the book’s storage history. He did not ask the clerk to interpret the handwriting. He had no wish to turn an ordinary employee into an unwilling witness for a conclusion he had not reached.

Outside, traffic moved in bursts. Badu placed the copy in a separate folder and wrote two questions on its cover: Who prepared the address? Who instructed the

messenger? He underlined neither. The delivery book had not solved the mystery. It had shown only that the envelope’s journey began before the messenger signed for it.

The Space Beside the Number

After lunch, Badu returned to the margin with a magnifier and a sheet of tracing paper. The mark beside the number looked darker than the surrounding ink, but age, pressure, and the angle of the scan could all create that impression. He recorded what he saw without calling it a correction.

A records assistant named Nartey watched from the opposite side of the table. He had worked in the archive long enough to know that a question about a number could become a question about a person before the day ended.

“If a figure is changed, can you tell who changed it?” Badu asked.

“Sometimes. If the hand is clear. If the original is available. If the person wrote enough examples elsewhere.” Nartey pointed at the photocopy. “Not from this alone.”

The answer was less satisfying than certainty, but more useful. Badu asked Nartey to identify comparable entries from the same period without selecting only those that supported a theory. Nartey brought a ledger of routine transfers, postponed returns, and several entries in which the same clerk

had crossed out a number and rewritten it. The marks varied. Badu's copy could not yet be matched confidently to any of them.

As he prepared to leave, Badu noted the reference numbers of the comparison entries and asked that the original ledger remain in its usual place until a formal examination could be arranged. The mark might be deliberate, accidental, or distorted by the copying process. Its value lay in the question it raised, not in the answer he wanted it to provide.

The Delivery Book: Esi Tetteh's Correction

The registry clerk, Esi Tetteh, asked to correct one detail before Badu closed the interview. She had initially said the messenger stood at the counter for less than a minute. After thinking about the queue behind him, she realised he might have waited while another clerk searched for a stamp. She could not be certain, and she did not want that uncertainty to vanish simply because the first version sounded tidier.

Badu thanked her for revisiting the detail. He asked her to sketch the counter as she remembered it, including the delivery book's position and the public queue. Esi marked a narrow strip of floor beside the window where someone could wait without blocking the next customer. It was not a reconstruction of the messenger's movements, she stressed, only a sketch of the room's layout.

Mabel watched Badu make two separate entries: what Esi had seen and what she inferred from the layout. That distinction seemed minor until they compared it with the first report, which had compressed observation and inference into a single sentence. The original note would remain unchanged; a dated supplement would record the clarification.

Outside the interview room, a clerk asked whether the envelope was connected to the judge's murder. Badu refused to discuss the investigation in the corridor, but the question stayed with him. People were already linking the records inquiry to the murder because both were difficult to explain and some of the same names appeared in each. Back at his desk, he added a reminder to the briefing: resemblance was a reason to investigate a possible connection, not evidence that one existed.

The Second Account Book

Badu returned to the registry before the public counter opened, while the building still had the unsettled quiet of a place not yet required to explain itself. He had requested the second account book because the first recorded deliveries, not the movement of packets after receipt. That separation was essential. An envelope could arrive through an honest process and disappear during routine handling; it could also be recorded incorrectly without anyone intending a crime. Before considering extraordinary

possibilities, he wanted to understand the ordinary procedures that had existed at the time.

The assistant in charge, Nartey, brought a slim volume from a cabinet and laid it on a support. Its pages tracked transfers between the public counter, internal tray, and records room. Some entries were in blue ink, others in black, and one column had been ruled by hand after the printed form ran out. Staff sometimes improvised when a form no longer matched the work, Nartey explained. He sounded weary, like someone long accustomed to being blamed for the limits of old systems.

“Can you identify who made this entry?” Badu asked, pointing to a time written beside the reference number. Nartey studied it. “Not from this alone. The handwriting resembles two people’s, and the date falls near a staff rotation. If you ask me to choose one, I’d be guessing.” Badu recorded the answer exactly. Sometimes the most useful witness was the one willing to disappoint him.

Adomaa, the counter clerk, was called back and shown only the relevant page—not the anonymous message or the theories gathering around it. She remembered a busy afternoon. A supervisor had asked her to clear the incoming tray before lunch, and a messenger had waited while another clerk searched for a stamp. She could not say whether she or someone else had moved the envelope in question. Her uncertainty did not

contradict the delivery book; it described what the book had failed to record.

He also asked the archive to identify other packets processed during the same shift. Three had complete movement records, two had gaps, and one had been entered in the wrong column. The comparison made the disputed entry less unusual than the team had hoped. It also showed that the route might be reconstructed if enough independent records survived. Badu requested copies of the neighbouring entries and ordered that the originals remain untouched until a formal examination could be arranged.

Mabel waited beneath the awning, her notebook closed against the humid air. “Anything decisive?” she asked. “No,” Badu said. “Something better than decisive: a clearer account of what we don’t know.” He explained that the envelope might have followed at least three routes after reaching the counter. Until they established which route applied, no one could claim it had been deliberately diverted. Mabel recorded the possible routes, not a suspect’s name. The case had gained work, not certainty, and both understood the difference.

The Counter After Closing

After the public counter closed, Badu returned with Esi Tetteh’s sketch and asked permission to inspect the room from the position she had marked. The registry

supervisor agreed, provided they did not move any active files. Without the queue, the room seemed smaller, and the delivery book’s former position less distinctive than it had in Esi’s memory. A visitor could stand near the counter and see the outgoing tray, but not the label on every folder inside it.

Esi came from the records room carrying the current book. She showed Badu how staff entered the time of receipt, then added their initials after checking the destination line. During busy periods, a clerk might slip a sheet beneath the book to stop it sliding while the next person signed. It was an ordinary habit, not a formal procedure, and no one had documented it. Badu asked her to demonstrate with no disputed document involved.

Mabel watched the demonstration and noticed that a sheet used as a weight would be hidden from anyone standing in the queue. That did not mean the old envelope had been placed there, much less that someone had used the position to conceal it. It meant only that ordinary work created a blind angle at the counter. She recorded the observation separately from the conclusion she was tempted to draw.

At the end of the visit, Badu asked the supervisor whether any old desk plans had survived. The supervisor promised to check the maintenance files, but warned that a plan might show the room’s layout without revealing how staff actually used it. Badu accepted the limitation. They had learned something

about the counter, but the delivery route still admitted several explanations. Outside, an evening queue had already formed at another office, where the same small gestures—passing paper from one hand to another—continued unnoticed.

CHAPTER TWO — THE NUMBER IN THE MARGIN

The next morning, Badu arrived before the archive opened. He had slept badly, though not because of the message itself. Anonymous messages were common in cases involving powerful people. What troubled him was the wording: not who had made the copy, but who had ordered five. It separated the person who preserved a record from the person who first requested it. The distinction might matter. It might also be bait.

He wrote both possibilities on the whiteboard and underlined neither.

Mabel arrived carrying two notebooks and a paper cup of tea. “I checked the public catalogue from the period,” she said. “The reference number appears in a batch of records transferred from the old administrative building. The catalogue describes four attachments, not five.”

“Does the dispatch book agree?”

“Not yet. The digital index has a gap across three months. The paper index is stored off-site, and the archive manager has requested access.”

Badu nodded. “Good. We need the source record, not just a catalogue that may have copied another catalogue.”

They met the archive manager in a small room behind the reading hall. She kept her keys clipped to a narrow belt and corrected anyone who called the archive a storeroom. Records, she explained, were not merely kept; they were transferred, classified, indexed, recalled, and sometimes re-described. A missing entry might indicate deliberate removal. It might also mean that a transfer had been recorded under another series or that an attachment had been filed separately.

The archive manager introduced herself as Mrs. Agyeman, then corrected Badu when he reached for the chair nearest the register. “That one is for the book,” she said. “You may sit there once we have finished.” There was no sharpness in her voice, only the tired precision of someone who had spent years explaining that paper could be damaged by impatience as easily as by water or fire.

Mabel watched the manager prepare the table: first a clean support board, then a sheet for recording the register’s condition, then gloves for the few steps that required them. The ritual seemed slow beside the urgency of the murder inquiry. Yet it was the first stage that made Mabel feel they were doing more than chasing a rumour. The book had a location, a

condition, and a history of custody. If it was to speak, they had to preserve the circumstances in which it did.

“How often do old entries get corrected?” Badu asked.

“Often enough,” Mrs. Agyeman replied. “A department changes its name. A file is moved. Someone discovers that a box was indexed under the wrong subject. Some corrections are routine; others need an audit trail. The question is not whether a record changed. The question is who changed it, under what authority, and whether the change was recorded.”

“And if the trail is missing?” Mabel asked.

“Then the trail is missing. That is a fact. The reason is a separate question.” Mrs. Agyeman glanced at the closed register. “People often arrive here wanting the second answer before they have properly established the first.”

“You’re saying the gap may be administrative,” Mabel said.

“I’m saying we should find out before we call it anything else.”

The manager placed the transfer register on a padded support. The relevant page showed a sequence of reference numbers in blue-black ink. The disputed number sat between two entries, its final character overwritten. A thin line crossed the original mark. Beneath it, visible only from an

angle, was a shape that might have been the top of an eight or the loop of a capital B.

“Can you tell which it was?” Badu asked.

“Not from this view. We would need a specialist to examine it under suitable light. We should not try to lift or alter the ink.”

Mabel leaned forward, then stopped when the manager raised a hand. “No closer,” the manager said. “The page is fragile.”

Badu thanked her and asked for a formal record of the inspection, including the page number, the condition of the register, who had been present, and the exact time the book was brought out and returned. The manager agreed. She also agreed to preserve the surrounding pages, because a single altered character could not be understood without the entries before and after it.

The disputed number also appeared in the dispatch register, followed by the code “S-4.” A later index described S-4 as a schedule. In the margin, a handwritten note read, “supplementary—separate enclosure.” None of the entries identified a recipient.

“Four attachments in the catalogue,” Mabel said, “and a separate enclosure in the dispatch book.”

“That is a discrepancy,” Badu replied. “Not yet a fifth copy.”

Mrs. Agyeman turned the register slightly so the three of them could read the same line without leaning over the binding. The code was written in a narrow hand. A faint stroke beneath the S might have been part of the letter or a mark from the page opposite. Beside it, the word “separate” had been added in a different ink.

“Can you date the addition?” Badu asked.

“Not reliably by looking at it. Ink colour can suggest a difference, but it cannot tell us a date on its own. Paper, pressure, pen type, and the sequence of entries may all help. A specialist can assess it, but even then the conclusion may be limited.”

Mabel copied the phrase exactly, including the dash before “separate enclosure.” She resisted writing “missing fifth copy” beside it. The phrase was already beginning to feel inevitable, and inevitability was dangerous in an investigation. The register said neither “fifth” nor “missing.” It recorded a separate enclosure in the language of the office. That was enough to justify a search, but not enough to settle what they were looking for.

He instructed the manager to preserve the page and the surrounding entries, not merely the line with S-4. If the writing had been altered, the neighbouring entries might reveal whether the alteration followed a consistent practice. If it had not, they could still establish the register’s normal format and show how

much weight the team could reasonably give the disputed mark.

“You are asking us to preserve an entire section for one code,” Mrs. Agyeman said.

“I’m asking that we don’t isolate a line and lose the context that explains it,” Badu answered. “We can narrow the review after we understand the record.”

“But it gives us a path.”

“Yes. We ask who created the index, when the description changed, and whether the separate enclosure was recorded elsewhere.”

By late morning, the archive manager had located an old cross-reference card filed under a different subject heading. The card was small, yellowed at the edges, and written in a hand that did not match the main register. It referred to the same batch but pointed to a different storage location: a cabinet number that no longer appeared on the current floor plan.

The manager frowned. “That cabinet was removed when the lower rooms were renovated. I’ll need to check the relocation list.”

“Was the contents list retained?” Badu asked.

“It should have been. Whether it was retained with the cabinet file or with the renovation records is another matter.”

Mabel wrote down the cabinet number. The reference in the anonymous copy had seemed a dead end the night before. Now it connected to a paper trail with several branches. None led directly to a person, but each offered a question they could test or rule out.

At noon, Daniel called. He had searched the box of school papers he remembered from the previous day. He had found an envelope, he said, but he did not want to describe it over the phone. He would bring it to the station with his adviser the next morning, provided the investigators explained how it would be handled.

“Tell him not to remove anything from the envelope,” Badu said after ending the call. “If the papers are in a particular order, photograph them in place before they are separated. We should document the box as he found it, not as we wish it had been.”

Mabel looked up from her notes. “If the number matches, it could corroborate the reference.”

A match could support a link, but it would not establish where the anonymous copy came from or whether its contents were accurate. The envelope might have been labelled later. Every part would need to be tested.

A second development came that afternoon. The security team had identified a possible route taken by the messenger: a side entrance shared by the registry building and a nearby administrative office. The camera had recorded several people entering during the relevant period, but the images were poor. One person carried a flat parcel under an arm. The clothing resembled the messenger's, though not closely enough to identify the person.

The security supervisor offered to circulate still images to staff. Badu declined until the team had reviewed the legal and procedural basis for doing so. An informal identification exercise could contaminate memories, and staff might begin to see the person they expected to see.

The security supervisor, a broad-shouldered man named Koomson, looked disappointed. He had expected a quick circulation of the image to produce a name by lunchtime. "The staff know one another," he said. "Someone will recognise the person."

"They may," Badu said. "But if we show them a still first, we may also change what they remember. A person who recalls a delivery bag could later become certain of a face they never properly saw. I don't want a confident answer that began with our photograph."

The security supervisor folded his arms. "Then what can I tell my officers?"

“Preserve the original footage. Make a record of who has accessed it. Give us the camera’s clock settings and any maintenance logs. We need to know whether the time stamp is reliable and whether the camera’s field of view changed. Then take independent accounts from the people on duty, without showing them the image.”

The security supervisor’s expression shifted from impatience to concentration. He called for the camera maintenance book and a list of staff assigned to the entrance. One officer remembered a person carrying a flat envelope; another remembered only that someone had held the door for a visitor. Neither account identified the messenger. The descriptions were entered separately, with their differences preserved rather than smoothed into a single story.

Mabel found the procedure frustrating and reassuring at once. The case was surrounded by people who wanted the mystery to resolve into a single villain and a single hidden act. The camera could easily have become a shortcut: a blurry face, a guessed name, a public accusation. Instead, it became another object with limitations that had to be written down.

“We can ask for independent recollections from the staff who were on duty,” he said. “Separately, and before showing anyone an image. Record what each person actually remembers.”

Mabel understood the caution, but the pace of the case irritated her. Each promising clue seemed to open three new corridors, and each corridor ended in another file. She had built her career on finding the detail that powerful people hoped would be overlooked. Yet she knew how easily persistence could become certainty, and certainty could turn a witness into a headline before the facts were ready.

She asked Badu whether he thought someone was deliberately feeding them fragments.

“It is possible,” he said. “The anonymous note is designed to make us feel that we are close to a revelation. That is exactly why we must be slow. Whoever sent it may know more than we do. They may also know less, or want us to believe something that is not true.”

Near closing time, the archive manager called with the relocation list. The old cabinet had not been destroyed. Its contents had been transferred to a temporary records room during renovation, then distributed across two series when the building reopened. The relocation list included a bundle labelled “S-4: supplementary schedules,” but the box number beside it had been crossed out and replaced with a newer number. The new number pointed to a storage shelf that had since been cleared.

“Cleared how?” Badu asked over the phone.

“The database says the shelf was reviewed during a retention exercise. It does not say whether the bundle was transferred, returned to a department, or authorised for disposal. I’m checking the disposal certificates.”

When the call ended, Badu added a new task to the case plan: locate the retention file and establish whether any disposal was authorised, documented, and witnessed. The crossed-out box number did not, on its own, suggest a cover-up. It gave them a reason to inspect the record explaining the change.

Mabel stayed behind after the others left. She copied the reference number from the transfer register into her notebook, then wrote the number again beneath it, leaving a space between the two. The original might have been an eight. It might have been a B. The anonymous copy used an eight. The cross-reference card used a B. One small mark had become a fork in the trail.

She returned to the reading hall and asked Mrs. Agyeman whether the archive kept a record of search requests that had failed. The manager brought out a bound log, its columns ruled in faded green. It listed the date, the requester, the description supplied, the series checked, and the result. Several entries used the words “not located.” None said “destroyed.”

“Why keep a record of failure?” Mabel asked.

“Because a failed search is still part of the history,” the manager said. “If someone asks again in five years, we need to know what was checked. Otherwise they may repeat the same search and mistake the repetition for a new finding.”

One entry from the renovation period referred to a “supplementary bundle, destination to be confirmed.” The requester field was blank, but the entry had a date and initials. A second entry two weeks later stated that the destination had been confirmed verbally. There was no name of the person who gave the confirmation, and no attached note.

Mabel noted the log reference and requested a certified extract through the proper channel. The discovery was modest, less dramatic than the photograph on her phone, but it offered what the anonymous image could not: a source the archive could identify, preserve, and explain. The blank requester field might be an ordinary omission, and the verbal confirmation might have been routine. Together, they gave the team a specific record to test.

When she told Badu, he asked her not to describe the log as proof that the bundle had been diverted. “It shows a search problem and a weakly documented confirmation,” he said. “That is worth pursuing. It is not the same as proving that anyone moved it for a dishonest reason.”

“You make every sentence smaller,” Mabel said.

“I make it no larger than the evidence.”

She almost argued, then looked again at the entry. The blank space seemed to invite a story. She knew how quickly a gap could be mistaken for a motive when a journalist was tired, a detective was under pressure, and the public wanted a name. She wrote the exact wording instead and underlined the word “verbally.”

Her phone vibrated. A text from an unlisted number appeared on the screen. She did not open it immediately. She called Badu, read him the sender information, and waited while he instructed her to preserve the message and avoid replying. Only then did she open it.

The message contained a photograph of a narrow page from a handwritten ledger. Most of the writing was outside the frame. One line was visible, underlined twice:

S-4 — five requested; four returned.

No date. No signature. No indication of which office had kept the ledger.

Mabel sent the image to the secure case channel and did not forward it anywhere else. The photograph might be authentic, altered, or taken from an unrelated book. Its framing made it impossible to judge the page as a whole. But if the line belonged to the same chain of records, it changed the question. The missing item might not have been a copy at all.

It might have been an enclosure that never returned.

Badu called within a minute. “Do not publish it. Do not ask the sender for more. We will preserve the original message and see whether the image can be traced.”

“The wording says five were requested and four returned.”

“Yes,” he said. “And until we know what “five” counts, we have only a sentence.”

Mabel looked at the two reference numbers in her notebook. A schedule, a copy, an enclosure, a returned bundle: each phrase suggested a different history. The fifth line might refer to a child, a document, a witness, or something as ordinary as a form. The case had trained them to hear the same number everywhere. Their task now was to find out whether the records were truly connected—or whether someone was using that number to make unrelated facts look like one story.

She closed the notebook and placed it in her bag. The next morning, Daniel would bring the envelope. The archive would search the retention file. The security team would preserve the entrance footage. And a specialist would examine the overwritten character without damaging the register.

For the first time since the anonymous copy arrived, the investigation had a set of concrete steps that did not depend on trusting the sender. It was not a breakthrough. It was a method.

In the secure case room, Badu added the new photograph to the evidence list under a provisional description: “Unverified image of ledger entry, source unknown.” Beneath that, he typed a single instruction for the team:

Establish what was requested. Establish what was returned. Do not assume they were people.

The Ledger Room After Closing

The registry building was almost empty when Badu returned with the authorisation letter. The day staff had gone, leaving the corridors to the security lights and the soft hum of the ventilation system. His visit was authorised and limited: the registry supervisor had approved a second inspection of the retention shelves, with a records officer present. The team had to complete it within the hours that officer was available.

Mrs Tetteh met them at the security desk with a ring of keys and a folder containing the approval. She checked Badu's identification, checked Mabel's visitor pass, and wrote both names in a bound log. The ritual seemed excessive for a room full of paper, but Badu had learned that a procedure mattered most when everyone was tired enough to resent it.

"You asked for the shelves listed under the old retention code," Tetteh said. "Those shelves were moved twice. The labels may not match the catalogue."

"We will record the labels as we find them," Badu replied. "We won't correct anything in place."

A records officer identified in the work log by the surname Mensah brought a trolley and laid a clean sheet across its top. The team photographed the shelf labels before moving a single box. Each carton was given a temporary number. Tetteh read the catalogue description aloud while Mensah checked the physical

label. When the two differed, they paused and recorded the discrepancy instead of choosing the version that seemed more likely.

The first four boxes held ordinary retention material: duplicate circulars, expired supply requests, and bundles of correspondence whose subjects had little connection to the investigation. The fifth box was empty except for a strip of adhesive on its base and a card that read “relocated.” There was no date and no destination. The records officer said the card could have been attached during either move.

“Can we identify who moved it?” Mabel asked.

“Not from the card,” Tetteh said. “The movement sheet should have travelled with the box. If it did, we have not found it yet.”

Badu did not allow the word yet to become a promise. He asked for the shelf to be photographed again, the empty carton to be measured, and the card to be placed in a protective sleeve. The absence was now documented, but it was still only an absence.

At the far end of the room, the records officer found a bundle whose label had been written over. The older ink showed through as a faint line, but neither the code nor the date could be read without specialist imaging. Tetteh remembered that the shelf had once held mixed administrative returns. She could not say whether the bundle had been there before the reorganisation.

Mabel watched the team work and thought about how a mystery looked from outside: one missing box, one altered label, one dark corridor. Inside the process, every object produced several ordinary explanations and a list of questions that had to be answered before anyone could call it suspicious.

When they finished, Badu signed the inspection record. Tetteh signed beneath him, then the records officer, each acknowledging only the work they had personally witnessed. No one signed that the missing box had contained the fifth copy. No one signed that it had been removed deliberately.

Outside, rain had begun to stipple the pavement. Mabel asked whether the empty carton mattered.

“It matters because it is part of the shelf history,” Badu said. “It does not yet matter in the way the sender wants us to believe.”

She wrote that down. This was becoming the case’s quiet discipline: every clue had to be allowed to exist before it was allowed to mean anything.

The Clerk Who Remembered the Queue

Badu returned to the records office after lunch, when the public counter had grown quiet and the clerks were beginning to stack the forms they had processed that morning. He had asked for the duty supervisor, but the woman who came out was not the supervisor whose name appeared on the current rota. She introduced herself as Lydia Nartey, a senior clerk who

had worked in the building long enough to remember when the catalogue was kept on cards and a request could remain unanswered for weeks without anyone calling it a delay.

“I heard you are asking about a number in the margin,” she said. She did not sit until Badu invited her to. “I may be able to tell you how numbers were used. I cannot tell you what happened to a file I never handled.”

That distinction pleased him. “Start with the ordinary procedure.”

Lydia explained that a request could carry several numbers during its life. The first belonged to the office making the request. Another was assigned when the archive received it. A third might be added if the item was sent to a temporary desk or returned for correction. Staff sometimes wrote the receiving number beside the original reference because the forms had too little space. Later clerks, unfamiliar with the practice, could mistake the second number for a quantity or a sequence of copies.

“So five might not mean five copies?” Badu asked.

“It might. It might also be a shelf, a desk, a batch, a page, or the fifth action in a process. You cannot choose the meaning because it fits the question you already have.”

Badu recorded the sentence almost word for word. He asked whether staff ever used “return” to mean

something other than a document physically coming back. Lydia said the term appeared in acknowledgement forms, monthly summaries, and lists of outstanding work. It could mean an answer to a request, a packet sent back for correction, or a count submitted to a supervisor. Context mattered; it was often the first thing lost when a page was copied without the pages before and after it.

She remembered a period when a temporary unit had been established to clear a backlog. Its staff borrowed the habits of the main registry but not always its forms. Some used abbreviated desk codes. Others wrote the name of a destination where the form expected a signature. The arrangement had been legal, she said, but untidy. When the unit closed, the surviving paperwork was scattered among several boxes.

“Do you remember the committee?” Badu asked.

Lydia considered the question. “I remember the pressure. Not the decisions. People came to the counter asking for things they had been told should exist. We were expected to find them quickly, even when the catalogue had not caught up with the moves. A person could be impatient without being corrupt. A clerk could make a mistake without being part of a plan.”

“Did anyone ask you to change a number?”

“Not that I can swear to. I remember being told to use the latest index, even when the old card looked more

complete. That was an instruction about procedure. Whether it concealed anything is a different question.”

Before he left, Badu asked if she would put her recollection in a signed statement. Lydia agreed, but insisted on reading every line. She corrected one date, crossed out the phrase “missing register,” and replaced it with “register not located during the search.” The change seemed small. It was also the first time that day someone had made the language of uncertainty more exact instead of less.

When Badu returned to his office, the margin number remained unexplained. Yet the list of possible meanings had widened. He wrote a new heading on the board: ORDINARY ADMINISTRATIVE USES. Under it he placed the words batch, desk, page, action, and copy. He did not erase copy. He simply refused to let it stand alone.

Daniel’s Family Papers

Daniel brought the family folder to Mabel’s office in a plain envelope and asked that they work through it one document at a time. The papers had been kept by different relatives, and several had been folded into the backs of exercise books. A baptism card, a school receipt, and a letter about a transfer all referred to him, but they did not use the same name or date in the same way.

Mabel laid down a clean sheet for each item and wrote its source, current holder, and known history. Daniel

recognised the hand that had written a note on the school receipt, but he could not say when it had been added. His aunt had kept the receipt in a sewing tin; another relative remembered seeing it on a shelf before the family moved. Neither memory established whether the note was original.

The letter about the transfer was the most frustrating. Its language suggested that a decision had already been made, but the signature at the bottom was incomplete. Daniel wanted to know who had decided. Mabel reminded him that the letter could identify a decision without identifying the person who initiated it. They marked the question for follow-up rather than treating the signature as a clue that had already been solved.

When the papers were returned, Daniel counted them twice. He had expected the exercise to produce an answer. Instead, it had given him a more reliable list of questions and a record of which relative might help with each one. The process did not erase the hurt of discovering that official records could disagree about a person. It did, however, prevent the investigation from turning his family's uncertainty into a story that no one could later correct.

The Call That Wasn't a Tip

Badu waited until the office had settled into its late-morning rhythm before calling the number written on the back of the photocopy. He did not use his personal

phone. He asked the duty officer to record the time, the number dialled, and the fact that the call was an attempt to verify contact information, not to question a suspect. The line rang six times before a woman answered.

“Good morning. I’m trying to confirm whether this number belongs to someone who once worked with the Judicial Records Review Committee,” he said. “I’m not asking you to discuss any confidential record.”

There was a pause, then the sound of a door closing somewhere behind her. “Who gave you this number?”

“I can explain the document it appeared on. I can’t tell you that the document is accurate.”

“Then you don’t know who you’re calling.”

“That is why I’m calling.”

She gave a short, humourless laugh. “You people always say that. You arrive with a paper and want a person to make the paper true.”

Badu let the sentence stand. He had heard versions of it from clerks, witnesses, and people who had learned to survive offices where a signature could become a burden long after the signer had forgotten the meeting.

“I’m not asking you to authenticate it over the telephone,” he said. “If you’re willing, I can send a formal request explaining the scope of the inquiry.”

“Send it to the office, not to me.”

“Which office?”

She hesitated. “The old one no longer exists. The successor unit may have the forwarding record.”

“Can you give me the successor unit’s name?”

“No. You can find it in the public directory.”

The call ended without a name, an admission, or useful confirmation. Badu recorded the limits carefully. The woman might have recognised the paper, feared being drawn into a matter she barely remembered, or simply disliked the police. None of those possibilities amounted to evidence.

He wrote one sentence beneath the call log: *A refusal to speak is not proof of knowledge.* Then he sent the formal request through the proper channel.

The Retention Clock

The retention room’s wall clock was seven minutes slow. Badu noticed when the clerk opening the cabinet wrote the time on a retrieval sheet and the electronic access log showed a different minute. The discrepancy was easy to dismiss, but important enough to document.

“The clock has been like that for months,” the clerk said. “We use the computer for official time.”

“Then why write the wall-clock time?”

The clerk looked at the sheet as if seeing it for the first time. “Habit.”

Badu did not treat the answer as suspicious. Habits survived in offices long after the systems that created them had changed. He asked whether the retrieval sheet was completed before or after the cabinet was opened. The clerk said it depended on the person. That meant the sheet could establish that a retrieval had been recorded, but not necessarily the exact sequence of every action.

They compared the entries with the electronic log. Two times overlapped; one did not. The mismatch might reflect a delayed entry, a faulty clock, or a separate visit. Badu arranged for the log to be preserved and requested an account from a second staff member. As they left, he saw that the archive’s weakness was not simply missing paper. It was the assumption that every routine had been followed in exactly the same way by every person, every day.

Daniel's Boundary

Daniel chose the meeting place himself: a modest room at his adviser's office, away from the archive, the newsroom, and the neighbourhood where old acquaintances might recognise him. He arrived with a brown folder held flat against his chest. He had not brought the family envelope. Instead, he had written a list of what he remembered about it and another list of what he had learned later. The separation was deliberate. For years, those two kinds of knowledge had sat together in his mind until he could no longer tell which memory had arrived first.

Ms. Serwaa Boateng read the lists before Badu did. She asked Daniel to explain the difference between remembering his mother keeping an envelope and remembering her telling him never to throw it away. He considered the question. "I can picture the drawer," he said. "I can hear her voice saying something like that. But I cannot swear the words were exactly those." His honesty seemed to cost him more than a confident answer would have. Badu thanked him and asked permission to preserve the lists as his account, not as proof of the document's contents.

Daniel described the room where his mother kept school certificates, old receipts, and papers she considered too important to discard. He remembered that the envelope had been folded at one corner. He could not remember the address, the date, or whether the number had been written by his mother. When

asked whether the envelope might have belonged to someone else in the family, he said it was possible. The possibility irritated him, but he did not withdraw it. Badu noticed the irritation and refused to treat it as evidence of concealment.

“If I find it, will you tell me what it means?” Daniel asked. “We will tell you what we can establish,” Badu replied. “If it does not answer the question, we will say that too.” Daniel looked down at the folder. “People have used records to tell me who I am. Then, when the records disagree, they say I should wait.” “Waiting is not fair,” Mabel said, “but guessing would not be fair either.” He accepted neither answer, but he left the lists with them.

After the meeting, Badu wrote a request for a voluntary search plan. Daniel would examine the papers in their existing storage place, record the order in which he found them, and contact the team before moving any item that appeared relevant. No one would enter his family home without permission or treat the absence of an envelope as proof that it had never existed. The plan was careful and slow. It also gave Daniel control over a part of the investigation that had too often proceeded around him.

That evening, Daniel opened the cupboard where he kept his own documents and found a school certificate he had not looked at in years. The paper was ordinary, its corners soft from handling. He did not suddenly remember the envelope. Instead, he wrote down the

date printed on the certificate and compared it with his list. A small gap appeared in the sequence of his schooling, a period when his mother had moved papers from one house to another. He added the gap as a question, then shut the cupboard. For once, he had resisted turning a blank space into a story.

The Family Folder at the Kitchen Table

Daniel returned to his aunt’s house with a list of the family papers they had not yet examined. She had cleared a space at the kitchen table, moving a bowl of fruit and a stack of unpaid utility bills to make room for the folders. The domestic setting made the investigation feel less like a case file and more like a family argument that had been postponed for years. Daniel told her he did not want her to fill gaps merely because he had asked a question.

She brought out a school photograph, two receipts, and a folded note tucked inside a hymnbook. The photograph showed a group of students in front of a building whose name had been painted over in a later renovation. Daniel recognised his younger self only after she pointed to the boy standing at the edge. He had remembered being in the centre of the group. The photograph did not correct his memory so much as reveal how confidently he had arranged it around himself.

The note carried a date but no signature. His aunt believed it had come from a teacher; Daniel thought

it might have been written by a relative who had gone to the school on his behalf. Neither could explain the faint pencil mark at the top. They agreed to photograph both sides and keep the original in its sleeve. The decision was small, but it changed the tone of the afternoon: they were no longer trying to make each object answer the whole story.

Before Daniel left, his aunt asked whether the police believed the family had hidden something. He told her that Badu had not accused them of anything. She seemed relieved, then embarrassed by the relief. Daniel understood that every request for a document could sound like suspicion when the family had already spent years wondering what had happened. He promised to return with the next question only when he could explain why it mattered, and she asked him to keep that promise even if the investigation became urgent.

The Copy That Arrived Without a Cover

The archive assistant called shortly before noon to report a loose set of photocopies found inside a folder marked for routine disposal. She had not opened the folder until the scheduled review, and she had not removed anything from it. Badu asked her to photograph the folder as it lay, then list the pages in their current order. The papers were ordinary circulars from different years, but one

carried a reference close enough to the disputed number to warrant checking.

The specialist compared the typography and page dimensions with the disputed circular. The match was not exact. The copy had a wider margin and a different footer, suggesting another form or another reproduction process. Badu refused to treat it as a missing attachment simply because the number looked familiar. They logged it as a possible comparison item and requested the folder’s disposal history, which might explain how the pages had come to be grouped together.

Before leaving, the archive assistant asked whether the folder would now be held indefinitely. Badu said it would remain protected until the comparison was complete, then be returned or retained according to the normal process. The assistant seemed relieved that the investigation would not automatically turn every untidy folder into suspicious evidence. The loose pages had given the team another object to compare, but they had not supplied the missing link.

CHAPTER THREE — THE RETENTION FILE

The archive's retention room had no windows or sign on the door. It lay behind the catalogue office, beyond a corridor where the air-conditioning failed halfway through the afternoon. A notice taped to the wall instructed staff not to remove files without a signed movement slip. Someone had underlined signed twice.

Superintendent Kwame Badu read the notice before entering. In his experience, the rules displayed most prominently were sometimes the ones people had already found ways around.

"We are not taking anything out," Mabel Owusu said. She held her notebook closed against her chest. "We are asking to inspect the movement record, and we will write down every file number we touch."

The archivist, Mrs. Agyapong, examined their letters of authority, checked the signatures, and called her director. She made them wait for confirmation. When she returned, she carried a ledger with a cracked spine and loose slips bound with cotton tape.

"The old system was not designed for people to come back twenty years later asking why a file moved," she said. "It was designed to make sure the file could be found the next morning."

“And could it?” Badu asked.

Mrs. Agyapong did not answer. She placed the ledger on the table and opened it to a page marked with a narrow strip of blue paper. The entry for S-4 appeared in faded ink. Beside it, someone had written: RETENTION REVIEW — HOLD PENDING AUTHORITY.

The line below carried a date, a staff initial, and a destination code that no longer appeared on the archive’s current directory. The movement slip attached to the page was not the original. Its paper was newer, and the staple holes did not align with the holes in the ledger sheet.

Mabel leaned forward, but did not touch it. “Can we photograph the page?”

“Not until we record the condition and obtain permission,” Mrs. Agyapong said. “And not with flash. This ink is already fading.”

Badu watched her complete the condition note. The process was slow, almost painfully so, but it gave each action a witness. He approved. In a case built around missing records, haste could become a form of tampering.

The destination code led to a storage facility closed during a later reorganisation. Its boxes had supposedly been transferred to the central

repository. Mrs. Agyapong used the word supposedly twice; the second time, she glanced at the door.

“Who authorised the retention hold?” Badu asked.

“The entry refers to an office, not a person. The authorisation should be in the supporting file.”

“Should be?”

“If it was filed.”

The reference led them to a thin folder of circulars, transfer lists, and a photocopy of an approval sheet. A dark line from the copying process obscured part of the signature. The name above it might have been Mensah or Mensim; neither Mrs. Agyapong nor Mabel would choose between them.

“We need the original,” Badu said.

“The index says the original was returned to the issuing office,” Mrs. Agyapong replied. “There is no receipt attached.”

Mabel recorded the answer and put a question mark beside returned to issuing office. The missing receipt could not tell them whether the original had been withheld, destroyed, or stolen. For now, it showed only that the archive could not account for what had happened to it.

Badu asked for a certified copy of the relevant ledger page and the transfer list. Mrs. Agyapong

began the request process. She would not promise when it would be ready, but she gave them a reference number and signed the acknowledgement herself.

At the door, Mabel paused. “You said the boxes were supposedly transferred. Why do you doubt that?”

Mrs. Agyapong’s expression tightened. “A few years ago, an auditor asked for a box from the same transfer batch. The register said it had arrived. The receiving list did not include it. We searched for three weeks.”

“Did you find it?”

“We found an empty box with the right label.”

Outside, afternoon heat settled over the compound. Badu slipped the request acknowledgement into a clear sleeve and noted the time. Mabel photographed the public reference board and checked the image against her notes before they left.

“An empty box,” she said. “That sounds like a story someone wants us to tell ourselves.”

“It sounds like an empty box,” Badu replied. “We can ask what it means when we know who handled it.”

His phone vibrated. Daniel Sarpong had sent a message: I have found the envelope. I have not

opened it. I will bring it with my adviser tomorrow. Please confirm where it should be handed over.

Badu read the message twice. Daniel had not claimed the envelope contained the fifth copy or came from the archive. He had said only that he had found an envelope bearing a reference number that might matter.

Badu sent the designated evidence-office address and instructed Daniel to keep the envelope sealed, write nothing on it, and identify anyone who had already seen or handled it. He copied the duty evidence officer into the message. The chain of custody would begin before the envelope crossed the room.

Mabel watched him send it. “Do you believe him?”

“Belief is not a procedure,” Badu said. “Tomorrow we can establish what he has, where it was kept, and who has touched it. Then we can decide what it might prove.”

A second message arrived from the unknown number. It contained no photograph this time, only one sentence: The file was not lost. It was returned to the wrong place.

Mabel read the screen over his shoulder. “That sounds like a correction.”

“Or an attempt to steer us,” Badu said. He saved the message, recorded the time, and forwarded it through the case system. He did not answer it.

By evening, the retention file had given them a route, not a culprit. A movement code, an incomplete approval sheet, a missing receipt, and a box that had once been found empty: each item required verification. Together they suggested that the story of S-4 had been mishandled more than once. They did not yet show whether the mishandling was deliberate, or whether it had anything to do with Judge Agyeman’s murder.

Badu opened his case notebook and wrote a new instruction beneath the earlier one: Establish the receiving location. Identify every custodian. Do not treat a missing receipt as proof of theft.

Then he underlined the final sentence once.

The next morning, Badu returned to the case office before the daily briefing. He had slept badly, not because the records frightened him but because they refused to settle into a sequence. A retention hold could be routine. A transfer code could be obsolete without being suspicious. An absent receipt could mean carelessness, a filing error, or a document that had been separated from its file. The danger was that several ordinary failures, placed beside a murder and a disputed register, could begin to look like one deliberate design before anyone had proved they belonged together.

He drew four columns on a fresh sheet: established, reported, inferred, and unknown. The ledger entry went under established, subject to certification. The old destination code went under established as a notation, but its meaning remained unknown. The empty box went under reported because the current record was a recollection, not the audit report itself. Intentional removal went under inferred—and he crossed it out. It had no business there yet.

Sergeant Lartey arrived carrying the previous evening’s digital evidence receipt. “The message is in the case system,” he said. “Original device retained, screenshot exported, hash recorded. The time on the handset and the server time differ by less than a minute.”

“And the number?” Badu asked.

“Prepaid service. The subscriber information request is pending. We have not attributed it to a person.”

“Good. Keep the wording exactly like that. Pending is not identified.”

Lartey set down another folder. The security office had provided a written response about the corridor camera outside the archive. The camera covered the public entrance and part of the passage, but not the retention room or the records table. Footage from the relevant period had been overwritten under the ordinary retention schedule. A maintenance log noted a brief outage on one afternoon, but not on the date of the S-4 movement entry.

“Someone will say the camera was switched off,” Lartey said.

“Then we will show what the maintenance log says,” Badu replied. “An ordinary overwrite is not proof that someone arranged for the footage to disappear. We can be suspicious without pretending suspicion is evidence.”

They added the response to the chronology and sent a preservation notice for any remaining related footage, access logs, and maintenance records. It was unlikely to restore what had been overwritten. It might, however, establish whether the camera system had been operating normally around other movements in the same transfer batch.

Mabel, meanwhile, met Mrs. Agyapong again in a small interview room at the repository. She had asked permission to record the conversation, and the archivist had agreed after checking the scope of the authorisation. Mabel placed her recorder on the table and read back the points she believed she understood.

“You did not personally see the S-4 box arrive at the central repository?”

“No,” Mrs. Agyapong said. “I was not in that office at the time. I saw the entry in a later register.”

“You did not personally see an original approval sheet leave the issuing office?”

“No. I saw the index entry saying it had been returned.”

“And the empty box?”

“That was a different request, several years later. The box label matched the transfer batch. I cannot tell you who emptied it, or whether the contents were ever in that box.”

Mabel stopped the recording. “I appreciate you making those distinctions. They make the story less dramatic, but more accurate.”

“Accuracy is the only thing I can offer,” Mrs. Agyapong said. “People think an archive is a room full of answers. Mostly it is a record of what somebody remembered to record.”

Mabel restarted the recorder and asked whether any destruction schedule applied to the supplementary schedules. Mrs. Agyapong said the broad retention policy existed, but the relevant annex had been handled under a restricted classification. She would need the classification register and the committee's closure instructions before she could say which schedule governed it. She would not speculate from memory.

After the interview, Mabel checked her notes against the recording and sent a narrow written request for the classification register, transfer inventory, and audit report concerning the empty box. She avoided saying the archive had lost the fifth copy. Her request stated only that the available records did not establish where the original approval sheet or the S-4 enclosure had gone.

At the newsroom, her editor, Kojo, read the proposed headline over her shoulder. "A Missing File at the Heart of the Agyeman Murder?" he asked.

"We cannot say it is at the heart of the murder," Mabel replied. "We have a disputed record trail and a murder investigation. We have not established the link."

"Then what can we say?"

"That a restricted schedule appears in two inconsistent registers, that the archive cannot currently produce the original approval sheet, and that investigators are

seeking the transfer records. We can explain why the questions matter without telling readers we know the answer.”

Kojo leaned back. “It will not make the front page on its own.”

“Then it does not make the front page on its own.”

After considering it, he crossed out his headline. “Get the certified ledger extract. Get the audit report. If the paper trail supports a stronger sentence, we will write it then.”

It was not a victory. It was a boundary, and Mabel knew how quickly boundaries could erode when a source offered a photograph, a name, or a promise of revelation. She saved the draft without publishing it. Then she listed questions that could be answered independently: Who assigned the destination code? Did the transfer batch have a complete inventory? Which office received returned originals? Did the restricted annex follow the same retention schedule as the ordinary file?

That afternoon, Badu received a call from the records director. The director had located a directory from the year of the transfer. It showed that the obsolete destination code referred not to a room but to a temporary records unit established during the reorganisation. The unit had operated from two locations before being dissolved. Its final inventory

was stored separately from the main archive catalogue.

“Can you certify that the inventory is complete?” Badu asked.

“Not yet. The directory lists an inventory, but the inventory itself has not been reconciled with the receiving register.”

“Who can reconcile it?”

“The former unit secretary may still have a personal handover copy. We are trying to locate her through official channels.”

Badu requested the unit’s establishment notice, closure order, staff list, and any surviving inventory. He did not ask the director to guess which employee had handled S-4. The fact that a temporary unit existed explained the code; it did not establish what had passed through its hands.

When he told Mabel about the directory, she said, “The file was not returned to the wrong place. It may have been sent through a place the current catalogue no longer recognises.”

“That is a possibility,” Badu said. “The sender’s sentence is still a claim, not a finding.”

That uncertainty mattered. If the anonymous source knew about the temporary unit, the source might have worked in the archive, seen a document, or simply read an old directory. The message could be a genuine

lead. It could also be an effort to make them chase a plausible dead end while someone removed or altered a different record.

Before ending the visit, Badu reviewed the next day's evidence appointment for Daniel. The envelope would be received in a controlled room, photographed as presented, and opened only with Daniel's agreement and the evidence officer's documentation. Any writing, folds, seals, and prior handling would be recorded before the contents were interpreted. The team would not call it the fifth copy unless the paper itself and independent records justified that description.

He added one final line to the working chronology: "Retention trail incomplete; multiple ordinary and potentially significant explanations remain." Then he closed the notebook. The investigation had moved forward, but not toward a name. It had moved toward the people and records that might tell them what the old code meant—and whether the missing link had ever been in the archive at all.

The Registry's Old Map

The old room map had been folded into quarters and kept inside a transparent sleeve. Its corners were soft from handling, and several labels had been crossed out in different inks. The junior clerk, Lydia Asare, arrived with the registry supervisor and studied it for nearly a minute before speaking.

“I remember this version,” she said. “Not because I remember every room, but because the temporary codes were written in blue. The later map used black.”

Badu asked her to point to the code she remembered without suggesting which location he wanted. Lydia traced a narrow corridor with one finger and stopped at a small rectangle marked C-2. She said the code might have referred to a temporary holding area during the renovation. She could not remember whether it was a room, a shelf, or a numbered section of a larger room.

Mabel photographed the map beside a scale and the document label. The ink colours were visible, but no one treated them as proof of the map’s age. The sleeve had protected the paper from some damage; it had not preserved a complete history of who used it.

Tetteh brought a second plan from the building file. On that version, the same corridor had been divided differently. The rectangle labelled C-2 no longer appeared. A note in the margin said “temporary use only,” but the note did not identify the department that had used the space or the dates during which it existed.

“Could a packet have been kept there?” Badu asked.

“Possibly,” Tetteh said. “But the plan does not tell us that any particular packet was there.”

Lydia remembered a trolley being parked near the corridor while rooms were rearranged. She did not

remember the contents of the trolley, and she could not say whether it had belonged to the registry. When Badu asked if she recognised a photograph of a brown carton, she shook her head. The image showed an ordinary box without a distinctive mark.

The team recorded the map's provenance as incomplete and requested the renovation circulars, the temporary-space allocation list, and any surviving key-control sheets for the period. The map had turned a vague code into a physical area they could investigate. It had not turned that area into the location of the missing copy.

As they packed the documents away, Lydia asked whether she had helped. Badu told her she had helped them ask a better question. He would not call it a breakthrough until the records supported one.

On the way out, Mabel looked back at the corridor on the map. A room could be renamed, divided, or repurposed without anyone intending to hide anything. Yet every change left a chance for a record to fall between systems. The task was to determine whether that had happened here, not to assume it had.

Kwarteng's Statement

Kwarteng's written statement arrived three days later, typed on plain paper and signed on every page. He had included a paragraph explaining that his recollection of the retention system came from several years of service, not from personal handling of the disputed

enclosure. Badu appreciated the qualification. It narrowed the statement, but it also made its limits visible.

During the review, one phrase drew attention: “return after review.” Kwarteng said the phrase was common in his unit, but its meaning depended on what came before it. A bundle could be returned to the originating office, to a supervisor, or to a temporary holding point. The phrase did not identify the recipient unless another entry completed the instruction.

He directed the team to find examples of the phrase in unrelated files. Three were located. In one, the return was a physical transfer; in another, it was a response to a request; in the third, it meant that a clerk had finished checking the index. The examples made the wording less mysterious, not more. They also showed why the phrase could not be used by itself to identify the destination of the missing schedule.

Kwarteng read the comparison table and confirmed that it accurately reflected his general explanation. He declined to comment on whether the disputed record had been handled correctly. He had not seen it at the time, and he would not turn professional familiarity into a personal memory. Badu filed the statement as procedural evidence and moved the next question to the people who had actually worked the corridor during the relevant period.

The Box That Was Not Empty

The next search took place in a store room that had once been used for stationery. The room smelled of cardboard and damp cement. A fluorescent tube flickered above a metal shelf, and the inventory clerk, Mr. Koomson, kept apologising for the narrow space as though he had personally designed the building.

Badu had asked for the empty box labelled S-4, but the search team had found two boxes with similar markings. One was empty except for a brittle strip of masking tape. The other held ordinary transfer slips, a broken file fastener, and a bundle of receipts from a period when the temporary unit was still operating. Neither box could safely be called the one described in the old note.

“If we take both, the chain of custody will be cleaner,” the evidence officer said. “But the authorisation names one box.”

Badu looked at the form. “Then we do not take both under the same authority. Photograph the labels and contents where they are. We will amend the request if the supervisor approves it.”

The inventory clerk seemed relieved. He had expected the detective to treat the similarity of the labels as permission. Instead, the team recorded the shelf, the adjacent boxes, the visible dust lines, and the fact that one container had been moved recently enough to leave a lighter rectangle on the metal beneath it. The

mark established movement, not who had moved the box or why.

While the photographs were being taken, The inventory clerk described the way boxes had been reused. An old label was sometimes crossed out and a new one written beneath it. If the crossing-out was faint, a later reader might see two labels and assume the box had served two related files. In reality, it could have held unrelated papers months apart.

“Would staff ever put an S-4 label on a box that did not contain an S-4 file?” Badu asked.

“If S-4 was a destination or a temporary holding code, yes. If it was a case identifier, that would be different. I cannot tell you which use applied here without the key to the code.”

The answer frustrated one of the younger officers, who had hoped the room would provide a decisive discovery. Badu stopped him from describing the lighter shelf mark as evidence of a hidden removal. The mark was useful because it generated a question: what had occupied that space? It was not useful as an accusation.

They examined the receipts from the second box. Most were routine acknowledgements for stationery, photocopying, or transport. One had a partial reference resembling the code on the retention sheet. The ink had bled through the paper, and the final digit could have been a three or an eight. The receipt did

not identify a packet, only a sealed item received from a unit whose abbreviation was incomplete.

He instructed the officer to photograph both sides and place the receipt in a separate sleeve. He requested a second reader to transcribe the reference independently. If the two readings differed, the disagreement would remain in the report rather than being silently resolved.

Outside the store room, the younger officer asked whether they had found anything at all. Badu looked back at the open door. “We found two boxes that people wanted us to treat as one. We found a mark on a shelf. We found a receipt that may be relevant. That is not nothing. But it is not a solution.”

As they walked toward the main office, Badu felt the familiar pull of the case: every minor irregularity seemed to invite a story large enough to contain it. His task was to resist that invitation until the evidence earned it.

Daniel's Waiting Room

Daniel arrived early and waited outside the interview room rather than taking the chair offered at reception. He watched people cross the corridor carrying files against their chests, each of them moving as if the contents were more fragile than paper. When Badu came to collect him, Daniel stood at once.

"I have been thinking about the envelope," Daniel said before they reached the door. "Not what is inside it. What I thought it meant when I first found it."

Badu let him continue.

Daniel described the first evening he had opened the old school papers. He had been looking for a certificate and had almost discarded the brown envelope because it seemed to contain only routine documents. The form had caught his attention because a name had been written beside a date he could not place. He had photographed it, then put everything back. Days passed before he decided to bring it forward.

"Why wait?" Badu asked.

"Because I did not know whether I was remembering the form or remembering what somebody had told me about it." Daniel rubbed his thumb along the edge of his notebook. "I did not want to give you a memory and call it a document."

It was the most careful answer he had given. Badu recorded the limits of Daniel's recollection. Daniel's recollection could guide a search, but it could not

authenticate the paper. Before the interview ended, they agreed to make a list of everyone who might have handled the envelope and to mark each name as confirmed, possible or merely remembered. Daniel left without learning whether the form mattered. He seemed relieved that nobody had pretended to know.

The Retention Hold

The retention file was kept in a room that smelled of cardboard and old adhesive. Efua Kwarteng met Badu at the entrance and reminded him that the file had been requested through the proper channel. She did not sound defensive; she sounded tired of hearing the word missing used as though it named a person responsible. She had brought the retention schedule, the current index, and a list of boxes whose labels had been changed during a later reorganisation. None was the original register, but together they described the rules that should have governed it.

Kwarteng placed the schedule beside the index and traced the relevant category with a capped pen. Some records were to be retained permanently, some for a fixed number of years, and others until a review was complete. The disputed category fell between two headings because the department had changed its filing language. A record could therefore have been retained under an older description without appearing in the newer catalogue. It was an explanation, not an answer, and Badu asked her to show the same pattern in unrelated files.

She found two examples. One had been indexed under the sending office’s name; the other under the receiving unit. Both could be located because their transfer slips survived. The fifth-copy lead had no such complete slip. “If this was an authorised hold,” Kwarteng said, “there should be a trace somewhere. It may be in the wrong place, or it may never have been completed.” She would not say which possibility she preferred. Badu appreciated the restraint and asked for the examples to be photographed under the same conditions as the disputed material.

At the far end of the room, a junior archivist identified in the catalogue by the surname Mensah showed Mabel a card catalogue that had been kept after the digital index was introduced. Many cards were redundant, but the old system sometimes preserved a cross-reference that had not been carried into the new one. Mabel worked through the drawer alphabetically, stopping whenever a label contained the words return, hold, attachment, or review. The search produced a number used by two different departments in different years. That coincidence made the number less conclusive, not more.

The junior archivist explained that temporary holds were sometimes extended by a handwritten note attached to the main circular. If the note became detached, the circular could appear to have expired even though a separate instruction had existed. He could not remember the disputed file, and he did not

claim to have seen its schedule. Badu asked him to document the practice in a statement that clearly separated general procedure from personal memory. A method could explain how a gap occurred without proving that it had occurred in this case.

Before leaving, Kwarteng asked whether the investigation would publicly name the office if the schedule could not be found. Badu said any public statement would distinguish a missing record from deliberate destruction. “That distinction protects the institution,” she said. “It protects the people who did their work properly, too,” he replied. “And it protects the investigation from making a claim it cannot support.” She nodded—not necessarily in agreement with every possibility, but in recognition of the standard he intended to apply.

Kwarteng’s Second Reading

Badu arranged a second meeting with Kwarteng, not to repeat the first interview but to test the practical limits of his explanation. He placed three anonymised examples of administrative returns on the table and asked Kwarteng to describe the work sequence each one implied. Kwarteng examined the forms slowly. He said that the same phrase could belong to different stages of a file’s journey, and that the surrounding marks were often more informative than the phrase itself.

One example had a receiving stamp but no initials. Another carried initials beside a date that appeared to have been added later. The third had a complete destination line, unlike the disputed reference. Kwarteng would not rank them as more or less suspicious. He explained that a missing initial could result from a rushed shift, a copied form, or a clerk who had expected to complete the entry after returning from another desk. Each possibility required a different kind of corroboration.

Badu asked whether an experienced clerk would notice an omitted step. Kwarteng answered that experience might make a person notice a pattern, but it could not supply the missing fact. In a busy office, staff often remembered the system as it was supposed to work rather than the exact way a particular afternoon unfolded. He said this without defensiveness, and Badu recorded it as a general caution rather than a finding about any named person.

After the meeting, the team revised its interview questions. Instead of asking witnesses whether a file had been returned, they would ask what they personally saw, which desk it came from, what mark they read, and whether they remembered the destination. The new questions were less dramatic and more demanding. They also made it harder for

a witness to agree with an assumption hidden inside the wording. Kwarteng's contribution had not solved the disputed entry; it had helped them ask a better question.

CHAPTER FOUR — DANIEL'S ENVELOPE

The evidence office had a narrow interview room, a table bolted to the floor, and a camera mounted in the upper corner. It was not an interrogation room. Badu had chosen it for the even lighting, controlled access, and the duty evidence officer's ability to document each step without an audience gathering outside.

Daniel Sarpong arrived at nine twelve the next morning with a woman who introduced herself as his legal adviser, Ms. Serwaa Boateng. He carried no bag, only a large brown envelope held flat between both hands. A strip of yellowed paper lay across its flap. It was not a seal, though the fold suggested that someone had once tried to keep the envelope shut.

"Before we begin," Ms. Boateng said, "Daniel is handing this over voluntarily. He is not making a statement about what it contains, where it originated, or who placed it among his belongings. Those matters must be established separately."

"Agreed," Badu said. "We will record what he says he knows, what he does not know, and what the physical examination can actually establish."

Sergeant Lartey, the evidence officer, switched on the room camera and stated the date, time, names, and purpose of the session. Daniel said he had found the envelope inside a folder of old school papers in a box

he had kept since leaving home. He did not remember placing it there, could not say how long it had been in the folder, and could not rule out other people having access to the box.

“Did you open it?” Lartey asked.

“No.”

“Did you remove the paper over the flap?”

“No. I saw it was there and stopped.”

“Did you show it to anyone?”

Daniel looked at his adviser before answering. “I told Ms. Boateng I had found it. I sent Superintendent Badu a message. I did not send a photograph.”

Ms. Boateng added that she had not handled the envelope and had advised Daniel to leave it untouched until a documented handover could be arranged.

Lartey photographed the envelope from several angles beside a scale and evidence card. He recorded the visible reference number, the flap’s condition, the folds, the discoloured paper strip, and a faint blue mark near the lower corner. Only after completing the photographs and initial observations did he place the envelope in a clean evidence tray.

“We need to be careful not to call that a seal,” Mabel said quietly. She had been invited as an investigator

and stood behind the marked line on the floor. “It may be a repair, a label, or something added later.”

“Correct,” Lartey said. “We can describe it. We cannot assign a purpose yet.”

In view of the camera, he cut along one edge of the envelope so the flap and paper strip remained intact. Inside lay a thin sheet folded in thirds, a small card marked S-4, and a second piece of paper with only a few lines visible through its fold. Lartey removed each item separately, photographed it, and assigned it a temporary exhibit number.

The first sheet was a carbon copy of a dispatch note. Its heading had faded, but the lower half remained legible. One line read: “Supplementary schedule — five copies requested.” Beneath it, in a different hand—or perhaps in a different pen—was the notation “four returned.” The final line ended at a torn edge of the paper.

Mabel said nothing. Badu could see her rereading the same words, trying not to let the shape of the discovery harden into a conclusion.

The small card carried the same S-4 reference as the retention ledger. It also bore a date that appeared to precede the ledger entry by several days. The ink had spread into the paper fibres, making the final digit uncertain. The date could not be treated as established until a specialist examined it.

The third item contained a partial list of initials and two columns of numbers. A crease concealed the centre of the page. No names appeared on the visible portion, and the page did not identify the person who had made the list or the office that had received it.

“Does this prove the fifth copy existed?” Mabel asked.

“It supports the possibility that five copies were requested,” Badu said. “That is not the same as proving five complete copies were produced, or that the copy we have here is one of them.”

After the initial documentation, Lartey sealed each item in a separate protective sleeve. He recorded the envelope as the container in which the papers had been found, not as proof that they shared an origin. The evidence register stated that Daniel had submitted the documents and said he found them among old school papers. Their earlier custody remained unknown.

Badu asked Daniel to describe the box and folder without speculating about the papers inside. Daniel recalled a blue exercise book, a school certificate, and several loose sheets. He remembered the box being moved during a house change, but could not remember who packed it. His mother had kept old documents in the same room, and other relatives

had helped move belongings. He could not rule out that someone else had placed the envelope there.

“Why did you tell me about it now?” Badu asked.

“Because of the number,” Daniel said. “When you mentioned S-4, I remembered seeing it on something years ago. I did not know what it meant. I was afraid that if I opened the envelope, I might damage something or be accused of changing it.”

“That was a sensible concern,” Ms. Boateng said. “But it does not answer who put it there.”

“I know,” Daniel replied. “I’m not saying I know.”

The ventilation hummed in the pause. Daniel’s caution might be honest, strategic, or both; Badu had no basis to choose between those possibilities. He recorded the answer as given, then asked whether Daniel recognised any of the handwriting.

Daniel studied the photographs on the monitor without touching the screen. He said the capital S on the card looked familiar, but he could not identify the writer. He had seen similar lettering on school records, office forms, and documents belonging to adults whose names he no longer remembered. Badu recorded the observation without treating it as an identification.

After the handover, Ms. Boateng requested a receipt listing the items and their temporary exhibit

numbers. Lartey provided one. Daniel signed only to acknowledge the transfer, not to certify the documents' authenticity or contents.

Outside the room, Mabel turned to Badu. "Five requested. Four returned. It is the same phrase as the photograph the sender sent us."

"Yes," he said. "Which means the sender may have seen this record, may have seen another record copied from it, or may be trying to make the two look connected."

"And the missing fifth?"

"We have a gap in a record. We do not yet know what occupied it."

Badu's phone rang before they reached the corridor. Mrs. Agyapong from the archive spoke quickly. The destination code from the retention file had been used again in a later transfer list, one that named a receiving office rather than a storage facility. She was preparing a certified copy and had found a cross-reference to a review committee that had been dissolved years earlier.

"Send the reference through the case system," Badu told her. "Do not remove the original from its current location, and do not contact anyone named in the transfer list until we have documented the link."

He ended the call and looked at the evidence receipt. Daniel’s envelope offered a second trace of the phrase, but it did not answer the central question. It only made the question harder to avoid.

Who ordered five copies, and what did the missing one contain?

Badu did not let the question carry them straight into another interview. Before anyone pursued the committee lead, he wanted the envelope’s initial examination recorded in a form another investigator could repeat. He asked Lartey to confirm that the camera file had been copied to the case system, that the original recording remained protected, and that the room camera’s time had been checked against the building’s official clock. Lartey confirmed each step and entered the checks in the log. The routine felt slow beside the discovery, but Badu knew even a dramatic object could become useless if its handling could not withstand scrutiny.

They moved to the evidence laboratory’s consultation room, where Dr. Esi Nkrumah, a document examiner, reviewed the photographs before requesting access to the originals. She did not begin with the words. She studied the edges and folds, pressure marks in the paper fibres, and the points where ink crossed a crease. She asked who had handled each item, whether any adhesive had been removed, and whether the papers had been flattened or cleaned. Lartey answered from the record, not from memory. When he could not answer a question, he said so.

“I can compare features,” Dr. Nkrumah explained, “but I cannot make the paper tell us more than it contains. A carbon impression can show that one sheet was pressed against another. It does not, by itself, tell us where the original went, who typed it, or whether the

text was approved.” She pointed to the phrase about five copies. The lettering was consistent with a typed office document, but the fragment was too incomplete to support a firm conclusion about its date or issuing department. The torn edge could have resulted from later damage; it did not prove that a line had been deliberately removed.

Mabel stood at the far end of the table, hands folded to keep herself from leaning over the exhibits. “Can you tell whether the words ‘four returned’ were added later?” she asked.

“Not from this image alone. The impression appears different in strength, but carbon copies vary across a page. I need to inspect the original under magnification and compare the marks with other entries from the same office, if we can find authenticated examples. Even then, I may be able to say that two entries were made differently without being able to say who made them or why.”

Badu noted the limitation. A good specialist drew a clear boundary around what could not yet be known. A confident answer might travel quickly through a newsroom or corridor; a qualified one took longer, but was less likely to collapse under scrutiny.

The partial list presented a different problem. Dr. Nkrumah could see pressure marks where the folded centre had rested against the opposite half, but the visible initials and numbers were not enough to

identify a person. She recommended non-destructive imaging before anyone attempted to open the crease fully. Badu authorised the examination in writing and specified that no chemical treatment or destructive sampling was to occur without a separate approval. The instruction was precise: preserve first, compare second, and interpret only after the results had been documented.

Meanwhile, Mabel called the newsroom from a quiet stairwell. Her editor, Kojo Frimpong, had already heard that Daniel had brought in documents. He wanted to know whether the team could now say that a fifth copy had been concealed for years. Mabel looked through the glass panel toward the evidence office before answering.

“No. We can say the dispatch note appears to record five copies requested and four returned. We cannot yet say that all five were made, that this document is the missing one, or that anyone concealed it.”

“Readers will ask what it means,” Kojo said.

“Then we tell them what it means and what it does not mean. If we turn a gap into a verdict, we become part of the problem.”

Kojo fell silent. Through the phone, Mabel could hear the newsroom around him: keyboards, a printer, and someone laughing at a message unrelated to the case. “Send me the exact wording you can support,” he said

at last. “No headline about a cover-up until we have proof of one.”

When Mabel returned, Badu had placed the committee reference beside the transfer-list number, not on top of it. He had asked the records unit to preserve the later transfer list and provide a certified copy, along with the file history showing who had accessed it. The archive could not release a page merely because it looked relevant. The original had to remain traceable, and any copy had to identify its source and certifying officer.

“There’s a practical issue,” Mabel said. “If the committee was dissolved, the people who worked for it may have scattered. Some will remember the work; others will remember only the official version. If we ask the wrong person too early, the story could reach whoever sent the message before we understand what they want.”

“That is why we are not calling the names on the list today,” Badu said. “First we establish that the list belongs to the transfer and that the transfer belongs to S-4. Then we decide who can answer a precise question. A name on a page is a lead, not permission to assume involvement.”

He asked the case clerk to maintain two separate lines of inquiry: one concerning the document trail and missing attachment, the other concerning the people who might have handled the records. The inquiries

could eventually intersect, but the shared reference alone was not enough to merge them. The fifth-copy question concerned an object and its movement; the fifth-child question concerned a person and an obscured history. Confusing them could harm someone who had already lived with uncertainty for years.

Daniel waited in the public corridor while the laboratory accepted the exhibits. Ms. Boateng stood beside him, reviewing the handover receipt to ensure it listed the envelope and each insert separately. She asked whether he would receive a copy of the receipt and whether any future request for an interview would specify the subject. Badu answered yes. Daniel was not being treated as the author of the papers merely because they had been found among his belongings, and the record would make that distinction plain.

“I keep thinking that if I had found it earlier, I might have understood something,” Daniel said. He did not sound relieved; he sounded tired of being asked to make meaning from scraps.

“You cannot be responsible for information you did not know you had,” Ms. Boateng replied. “The investigators have to establish the history. You only need to be accurate about your own.”

Badu heard them as he approached. He chose not to turn the moment into another question. Daniel had

already said what he could remember. Repeating it under pressure would not make the memory stronger; it might only make him feel compelled to fill the gaps. Badu thanked him for cooperating and said the team would contact him through his adviser if a specific clarification became necessary.

As the appointment ended, Badu reviewed the preliminary laboratory request. The first comparison would be with authenticated dispatch notes from the relevant period, if the archive could locate any. The second would test whether the S-4 card's uncertain date could be narrowed without damaging it. The third would image the folded list. None of those examinations promised a revelation. Together, they might narrow the range of plausible explanations.

At his desk, he added a line to the case chronology: envelope received voluntarily; contents documented separately; prior custody unknown; authenticity pending. He resisted writing "fifth copy recovered." The phrase was concise, dramatic, and unsupported. Instead, he typed: "The document set contains a dispatch notation recording five copies requested and four returned; its relationship to the unlocated item has not been established."

Mabel read the wording over his shoulder. "It sounds less exciting."

"Good," Badu said. "Excitement is not an evidentiary category."

Outside, the rain had stopped, leaving the pavement slick beneath the afternoon light. In the evidence room, the envelope and its contents rested in separate sleeves, each linked by a number to a handling record. For the first time, the phrase in the anonymous photograph had a physical source they could examine. A source was not an answer, however; it was a basis for better questions.

Daniel's Walk Back to the Car

Daniel Sarpong stayed in the evidence office after the envelope had been logged. His adviser, Serwaa Boateng, spoke with the receptionist about the receipt. She wanted it to state that Daniel had submitted the envelope voluntarily without suggesting that he had vouched for everything it might contain. Daniel waited beneath the veranda, watching a taxi reverse around a puddle.

Badu came out alone. He kept a respectful distance.

"You did the right thing by bringing it in," he said.

Daniel looked at him. "You don't know that."

"No. I know you brought it in under your own name, and that the envelope is now recorded. What it means is still open."

"Everyone keeps saying that as if it is reassuring."

"It is meant to be accurate."

Daniel pressed his palms together, then separated them. "I found it among papers that belonged to my

family. I didn't open it because I thought there might be something inside that would change what I remembered. I didn't bring it because I thought it would prove anything."

"What did you remember?"

"That people spoke about the past as if it had one version. My mother had one version. My uncle had another. When I was young, I thought adults disagreed because they had forgotten details. Later I understood that sometimes they remembered the same thing and gave it different names."

Badu did not ask which adult had lied. Daniel had not offered a charge, and Badu would not turn a family history into a suspect list merely because it sat beside a case file.

"If we need to speak again, we'll contact your adviser first," Badu said.

"And if the envelope contains nothing?"

"Then the record will say what it contains, including if it contains nothing relevant."

Daniel nodded, though he remained unconvinced. He walked to the car where Serwaa waited and paused once to look back at the building. Badu watched him go and wondered how long a person could carry an object without knowing whether he was protecting it, fearing it, or postponing the day someone would ask what it meant.

Kofi Follows the Ordinary Route

Kofi Bediako had spent years learning which questions people answered quickly and which ones made them look toward the door. When Mabel asked him to help trace the old dispatch route, he warned her that he was not an investigator and would not act as a substitute for one.

“I’m not asking you to confront anyone,” she said. “I want to know which public records or former staff might explain the routine.”

They began at a stationery shop that had supplied the office during the period in question. The owner remembered delivering paper, toner, envelopes, and boxes of file labels. He did not remember the alleged fifth copy or the names in the investigation. His invoices, however, included a delivery to a building whose room number had later changed.

Mabel recorded the invoice reference and asked permission to photograph it. The owner agreed after she promised not to publish his address or unrelated business details. The invoice could establish that supplies had been delivered; it could not show what was later printed on the paper or where those supplies were used.

From there, Kofi suggested they check the old transport office, now occupied by a different department. The receptionist directed them to the public counter, where a clerk explained that historical

trip sheets were stored off-site and could only be requested through a formal process. Kofi did not try to persuade the clerk to bend the rules. He asked for the correct form and wrote down the office hours.

“You make this look slow,” he told Mabel as they walked back to the car.

“It is slow.”

“I thought journalism meant finding the person who knows.”

“Sometimes it means finding the person who can show that the person who claims to know is wrong.”

Kofi laughed once, then grew serious. He said people in the neighbourhood had begun treating the investigation as a contest between families. He had heard one version that made Daniel a hidden heir and another that made him a deliberate impostor. Neither version came with a document anyone was willing to show him.

“People like a story with a place for everyone,” Mabel said. “The truth may not be arranged so neatly.”

At the newsroom, she entered the invoice and request form in her source log. Kofi’s observations about neighbourhood rumours went into a separate note on the public atmosphere, not the evidence list. The dispatch route remained incomplete, but the next request now had a reference number and a responsible office.

Kofi declined to be quoted. He had helped because he wanted the truth to be found, not because he wanted to appear in the story. Mabel respected that. Some contributions mattered precisely because they did not become public spectacle.

The Committee's Last Meeting

The old meeting room had been converted into a training space, but the table still bore pale rectangles where nameplates had once stood. Badu visited with permission from the current administrator and asked to see the room only to understand its layout. He did not expect the walls to reveal the committee's secrets.

The administrator showed him the former seating plan, reconstructed from an old facilities diagram. It placed the secretary near the door and the chairperson opposite the windows. A side table had been added later, and the diagram did not show whether it had been present during the committee's final meeting.

"People remember where they sat," the administrator said, "but not always which meeting they mean."

Badu asked whether minutes were routinely drafted in the room. The answer was yes, although final copies could be typed elsewhere and circulated for correction. That created several legitimate versions of a document: notes, draft minutes, amended minutes and approved minutes. A difference between versions might reflect normal procedure or deliberate

alteration; comparison was necessary before either claim could be made.

Back at the station, Badu amended his request for committee records. He asked not only for the final minutes but also for drafts, circulation lists, correction sheets, and any surviving record of approval. He was no longer looking for one decisive page. He wanted to reconstruct how a document became official—and who had been in a position to alter it.

The Conservator's Report

The independent conservator returned a report with three photographs and a caution on the first page. The marks on the reverse were consistent with pressure from another sheet, but the impressions were too incomplete to transcribe reliably. One photograph seemed to show a short vertical stroke; another made it resemble the edge of a ruled line. Neither image established a word.

Mabel asked the conservator why the first examination had seemed more promising. The conservator explained that angled light can make an irregularity appear meaningful until it is compared with images taken from other directions. The human eye is especially ready to complete a pattern once someone suggests a likely word. That was why the examiner had deliberately avoided being told the team's preferred reading before the second pass.

Badu added the report to the evidence file and instructed the team not to describe the marks as a hidden “five.” That phrase could appear only when discussing the hypothesis, accompanied by a warning that it remained unverified. One investigator felt the team was losing a potentially important clue. Badu replied that an unreliable reading was not a clue they possessed; it was a possibility they still had to test.

The conservator recommended stable storage and minimal handling. If a matching sheet surfaced, its layout could be compared with the impressions, though any result would still need careful interpretation. Mabel told her editor that the examination had ruled out certainty, not significance. The paper still mattered; it simply did not yet say what anyone wanted it to say.

Daniel’s Conditions

After the envelope had been photographed, logged, and placed under the evidence officer’s control, Daniel asked whether he could speak to Badu without the camera recording his face. His adviser answered before the detective did.

“We are not asking you to remove the official record,” she said. “We are asking whether the interview can be documented in writing while the camera records the room and the handling of the exhibit—not a close view of Mr Sarpong.”

Badu explained what the system recorded and what could be adjusted under the station's procedure. He would not agree to anything that might later make the evidence handling look informal. After a brief discussion with the duty officer, they settled on a written interview record and a camera angle showing the table, the envelope, and the participants' hands. The adjustment was entered in the log with the reason for it.

Daniel watched the officer complete the entry. "I don't want the envelope to become a story about me before anyone knows what it contains."

"That is a reasonable concern," Badu said. "It does not mean we can accept your account without checking it."

"I'm not asking you to." Daniel rubbed the side of his thumb against the seam of his trousers. "I'm asking you to keep the two questions separate. Where did this paper come from? And what does it mean? I may be able to help with the first. I may not be able to answer the second."

His adviser asked him to explain when he had found the envelope. Daniel said it had been among school papers and household documents kept in a trunk. The trunk had been moved twice, once when a relative's room was cleared and again when Daniel changed houses. He could not identify every person who had handled the papers. He remembered seeing the

envelope years earlier but could not say whether the paper strip across the flap had then been present.

“Why bring it now?” Badu asked.

Daniel paused. “Because of the school form. I had treated it as an oddity. Then I saw the reference in the report you made public. I realised that if I kept it and the paper mattered, I would become part of the problem. If I handed it over, people might decide it proved more than it proves. There was no choice that felt safe.”

“What made you think it was connected?”

“The notation. Not the name. The notation and the date range. I am telling you that was my reason, not that it is a correct conclusion.”

Badu asked him to identify the people who had access to the trunk. Daniel named two relatives and a former landlord, then warned that his memory of the order of events was uncertain. The adviser requested that those names be recorded as possible handlers of the household papers, not as suspects. Badu agreed. He also asked Daniel not to contact them about the investigation before the team had decided whether their recollections were relevant.

When the interview ended, Daniel did not look toward the evidence cabinet. He looked at the empty space on the table where the envelope had been. “I thought handing it over would make the question smaller,” he said. “Instead, it has made it real.”

“It has made it examinable,” Badu replied. “That is not the same as solved.”

After Daniel and his adviser left, Badu reviewed the interview record. Its gaps were clearly marked. Daniel’s uncertainty did not make him dishonest, and his willingness to surrender the envelope did not make his account true. Both possibilities had to remain visible in the file.

The Conservator’s Table

The conservator’s workroom was quieter than the evidence room, with blinds that softened the daylight and a long table covered in neutral cloth. Dr. Kusi had requested the document’s high-resolution images, dimensions, and packaging history before allowing the original to be brought in. He explained that paper could be damaged by a well-meaning person who wanted to flatten a crease or remove a stain. The first task was to understand the object as it had arrived, not to make it look easier to read.

He placed the copy under a magnifier and examined the edges without touching the printed surface. One corner had been compressed, but the mark could have come from storage, transport, or a later folder. The paper was not unusual enough to identify a particular office. A faint impression beneath the final line appeared to be pressure from another sheet, yet the impression was too incomplete to support a reliable

reading. Dr. Kusi photographed it at several angles and labelled each image with the lighting conditions.

Mabel asked whether the impression could reveal the missing attachment's title. "It may reveal that something was written or typed on a sheet above it," he said. "That is the narrow conclusion. It cannot tell us the author, the date, or whether the text concerned this document at all." He turned the image toward her. The marks resembled fragments of letters, but when he adjusted the light, several seemed to disappear. Mabel wrote down the observation without trying to complete the words in her head.

Badu asked the conservator to compare the sheet with known office stock from the period. Dr. Kusi explained that comparison samples had to be documented, not merely described by someone who remembered the stationery. A modern sheet could be used to reproduce an older form, while older paper could be placed through newer equipment. Neither age nor appearance alone would settle authenticity. The examiner would report what the material supported and what remained beyond the limits of the examination.

During a break, the team discussed whether the page should be tested for printer characteristics. The conservator advised them to preserve enough material for further work and to avoid a sequence of tests chosen only because each might produce a dramatic answer. Badu approved the plan. A forensic result was

useful only if its method, limits, and handling history could be explained later to a court or an independent reviewer.

When the session ended, Dr. Kusi sealed the item in its protective enclosure and signed the transfer form. Under the workroom lights, the document looked less mysterious than it had in the evidence room. It was an ordinary sheet with a history that remained unknown. That did not diminish its importance. The investigation depended not on making the object seem extraordinary, but on establishing exactly what could be said about it.

The Statement That Changed Overnight

The clerk returned to the station two days after signing his statement. He had telephoned first, insisting that he was not withdrawing anything, only asking to correct a detail that had troubled him on the journey home. Badu arranged for the evidence officer to sit in and made sure the earlier statement remained untouched. A correction was not a reason to erase the first account; it was a new event that needed its own record.

The clerk explained that he had remembered a supervisor standing beside the incoming tray, not at the counter as he had first described. He could not say whether the supervisor had touched the envelope. His memory had sharpened after he pictured the room, but he admitted that he had also discussed the

interview with his wife, who had asked him whether he was certain about the location. Badu asked him to distinguish what came back to him from what the conversation had prompted him to reconsider.

“I don’t want you to think I am changing the story because someone has spoken to me,” the clerk said. “I am changing one detail because I cannot defend the first version.” Badu said the team would preserve both accounts and record the circumstances of the correction. He asked whether the clerk had seen any photograph, article, or message about the case since the interview. The clerk listed what he had encountered, including a headline Mabel had since corrected.

Mabel was present because the clerk had asked that his correction be understood in the context of the public reporting. She did not defend the headline or argue that it had influenced him. She explained exactly what had been published and when. The clerk said the article had made him reconsider the counter layout, but it had not supplied the memory of the supervisor. That distinction could not be measured with certainty; it could only be recorded and weighed with the rest of his account.

Badu asked the clerk to draw the room again. The second drawing placed the supervisor near the tray, but the clerk marked the position with a question mark. He was sure about the location of the tray because he had worked there for years; he was not

sure about the supervisor’s exact position that afternoon. The drawing did not establish that the supervisor handled the packet. It showed how the clerk’s recollection had changed and where the uncertainty remained.

After the clerk left, the evidence officer asked whether the revised account weakened the case. Badu said it undermined any claim that the first description had been precise. It might help identify the staff roster to examine, but it could not place the supervisor in possession of the envelope. Mabel noted for the newsroom that witness statements can evolve and that a revision should not automatically be called deception. The investigation had gained a correction, not a culprit.

The Conservator’s Workbench

The conservator invited Badu and Mabel to observe a routine imaging session on an unrelated document so they could understand what the equipment could and could not show. Under the workbench lamp, ordinary fibres became visible, but the image also exaggerated tiny shadows that disappeared when the angle changed. The conservator adjusted the light and explained that enhancement could make a feature easier to inspect without making its meaning more certain.

Mabel asked whether a pressure mark could be compared with a missing sheet if one was found.

The conservator said a comparison might reveal compatible spacing or an overlap in the impressions, but compatibility was not the same as unique identification. Many documents used the same ruled forms and typewriter spacing. A meaningful match would need several independent features and a careful account of alternative explanations.

Badu watched the conservator label each image with its settings and file number. The procedure seemed slow, but it meant another specialist could reproduce the examination rather than rely on a dramatic photograph selected for a report. The conservator also kept the original image untouched and worked on copies. Every adjustment was recorded. Badu asked the team to adopt the same practice for its own comparisons, even when the material was only a scan.

At the end of the session, the conservator returned to the disputed circular. The faint impressions remained inconclusive. She refused to describe them as a hidden numeral and asked that no one crop away the blank space around the marks. That surrounding surface showed the limits of the impression. Mabel understood the insistence on keeping uncertainty visible: a cropped image could turn a weak suggestion into a convincing story, difficult to correct once repeated.

CHAPTER FIVE — THE COMMITTEE THAT CLOSED

The records used three names for the committee: the Judicial Records Review Committee, the Review Committee on Confidential Schedules, and, on a faded transfer list, simply “the Review Office.” Badu asked the archive to include all three variants in its search report. The differences might reflect routine administration or point to a connection, but neither possibility was proof.

By midmorning, Mrs. Agyapong had sent a certified copy of the later transfer list through the case system. The document showed that several boxes from the old storage facility had been assigned to a records unit shortly before the committee was dissolved. The receiving officer’s signature was legible, but the destination stamp was incomplete. A handwritten code in the margin matched the code on the retention ledger.

Badu printed the list and placed it beside the photographs of Daniel’s envelope. He did not put the original exhibits on the same table. The photographs were working copies; the documents themselves remained sealed and logged with the evidence officer.

Mabel arrived with a list of questions rather than a theory. “Who created the committee? What was it authorised to review? Who held the files after it closed? And why does the transfer list use a different name?”

“We start with the terms of reference,” Badu said. “Then the closure notice, the staff list, and the transfer authority. If we begin with the names we already suspect, every ordinary detail will start looking like a confession.”

The first request went to the public records office. The second went to the court administration registry. For the third, Badu asked the archive to identify the official custodian of the records unit, not to approach former staff. He wanted the documentary trail before any witness was alerted that the old committee had returned to anyone’s attention.

While they waited, Mabel checked the dates against the case chronology. The committee had closed after the confidential schedule was supposedly returned to its issuing office, but before the later transfer list was prepared. The sequence mattered, though it did not show that the committee had retained the schedule. Its records might simply explain where the archive trail went next.

“There’s another problem,” she said. “If this committee handled confidential schedules, its staff may have been authorised to see them. We cannot treat access as evidence of wrongdoing.”

“Agreed,” Badu said. “We need to know what each person was permitted to do, not just what they could physically reach.”

At noon, a registry officer called back. The committee had been established for a limited review of document-handling procedures following complaints about missing attachments in judicial files. Its public mandate did not name individual cases. The officer could provide the establishment notice, but the annex listing its specific work programme was not in the current registry file.

“Where should the annex be?” Badu asked.

“The notice says it was distributed to the chair and the administrative secretary.”

“Is there a dispatch record?”

“There should be one.”

The phrase was becoming familiar. Badu requested the dispatch register and the secretary’s file inventory. He asked the officer to record that the annex was being sought—not that it had been lost or withheld.

Mabel read the establishment notice twice. “A committee created because attachments were going

missing, then its own work programme disappears from the registry."

"Or is filed somewhere else," Badu said. "We will not write the sentence you want until we can prove it."

The court administration registry provided a staff list from the committee's final year. Most names were ordinary civil-service appointments. One name, K. B. Mensah, appeared as a temporary records liaison for six weeks. The name was common enough that it could not be connected to the retired Inspector K. B. Mensah without further identifying information. Badu marked the entry for verification and left it there.

Mabel noticed the mark. "You're not going to call him?"

"Not on this evidence. We need the personnel file or an official identifier. Similar initials are a lead, not an identity."

The staff list also named an administrative secretary, Ama Serwaa Quartey, whose appointment ended when the committee closed. Her personnel record showed a transfer to another department, but no current contact details. Badu asked the registry to route a formal request through the department's records officer. He did not ask for her home address or private number.

Late in the afternoon, the public records office sent a scanned closure notice. The committee had been dissolved after its mandate expired. Its active files were to be transferred to the central repository; routine administrative records were to remain with the department that had sponsored it. A box schedule was attached, but the list ended at item twelve and contained a faint note beside item nine: “restricted annexes — separate movement.”

The phrase separate movement was underlined in blue ink. The stroke resembled the blue mark photographed on Daniel’s envelope, but resemblance alone meant little. Different clerks used the same pens; old paper could acquire marks from unrelated contact. Badu added the observation to the comparison log and instructed the evidence officer to keep the original exhibits untouched until a document examiner could advise whether the marks were meaningfully comparable.

“The sender knew about S-4,” Mabel said. “Maybe the sender worked in that office.”

“Maybe. Or read a copy of the register. Or learned it from someone else. We have to keep those possibilities open.”

A call came from the registry officer just before closing. The annex was not listed in the secretary’s current inventory, but a cross-reference in the old

index pointed to a set of “restricted appendices” transferred separately from the committee’s ordinary files. The destination field was blank. A faint number at the edge of the index card appeared to be the beginning of a repository accession number, though the last digits were smudged.

He requested a high-resolution scan of the card and a certified note describing where it had been found. He also requested a search of accession numbers from the same transfer batch. He did not authorise anyone to open a sealed box solely because its number looked promising.

Mabel closed her notebook. “The committee did not make the missing copy disappear. But its paperwork may tell us where to look.”

“That is the most we can say tonight,” Badu replied.

They left the office separately. Badu did not want a photograph of them together outside the registry, and Mabel had learned not to turn every precaution into a performance. At the car, his phone vibrated with another message from the unknown sender. It showed a mostly blank form with one typed line near the top: RESTRICTED APPENDIX — MOVEMENT AUTHORISED BY CHAIR ONLY.

No date, signature, or file number was visible. The sender had cropped the page so tightly that the paper’s edges were missing.

Under the image was a short message: “Ask who signed when the chair was absent.”

Badu saved the image, recorded its receipt, and sent it to the case system. The message might point toward a genuine irregularity. It might also be bait designed to make them accuse a person before the records could speak.

He opened his notebook and added three tasks: verify the annex reference; establish the committee chair’s dates of absence from official records; identify the authorisation procedure for restricted appendices. He did not write down a suspect’s name.

The committee had closed. Its records had not finished moving.

The next morning, Badu returned to the office before the daily briefing. He had slept badly—not because the cropped message had persuaded him, but because its question could easily harden into an accusation. “Who signed when the chair was absent” implied a procedure and an absence. It did not prove either had affected the S-4 file. He wrote those distinctions at the top of a fresh page before the team arrived.

Lartey came in carrying the request log. “The records office has acknowledged the scan request. They want the exact accession range before they search the restricted series.”

“Give them the transfer batch and ask them to preserve the neighbouring entries too,” Badu said. “We need the context around the card, not just the one line that fits our theory.”

Lartey checked the wording. “Should we mention the anonymous image?”

“No. The archive search must be based on our documented exhibits and the official cross-reference. If we give them the anonymous claim first, we risk steering the search toward what the sender wants us to see.”

The case system now held the image, its receipt time, and a note that the source was unknown. Badu asked the digital evidence officer to preserve whatever original message metadata the department could access, without assuming that a displayed timestamp

or account name would identify the sender. An image could be forwarded, edited, or stripped of context. Even an authentic form could be used to support a false story.

At ten, Mabel met her editor in a small conference room at the newsroom. She placed the committee closure notice on the table beside her notes, keeping the anonymous crop on her laptop rather than printing it as if it were an official document.

“We have a committee that was created to address missing attachments,” she said. “Its records were transferred in more than one category. A restricted appendix is absent from the current inventory. Someone has sent a cropped authorisation form.”

Her editor read the notes. “That is a report about a records problem. What makes it a story today?”

“The committee’s own paperwork may explain how a confidential schedule moved. But we don’t know that the appendix is the fifth copy, or that anyone deliberately removed it. I can report that the records trail is incomplete if we can independently verify the transfer notices. I cannot say there was a cover-up.”

“And the person who sent the image?”

“Unknown. We should not publish the crop, its supposed wording, or a guess about who sent it until we have an independently sourced version. The message may be trying to get us to name someone.”

The editor nodded and asked her to prepare a short background note for legal review, not a headline. Mabel felt the familiar frustration of having a story that was important but not yet ready to be told. The discipline was not silence. It was making sure the first public account would survive the next document that arrived.

Meanwhile, Badu and Lartey compared the committee's establishment notice with the closure notice. The first described a limited mandate: review document-handling procedures after complaints about missing attachments. It did not name Judge Agyeman, Daniel, or the confidential schedule. The second ordered active files into the central repository and routine administrative records into ordinary storage, while restricted appendices were to move separately under an authorised process.

"That separate route is where we need to focus," Lartey said.

"Focus, yes. Conclude, no." Badu marked the relevant lines. "The route might have been entirely lawful. The question is whether the required authorisation exists and whether the destination can be established."

They prepared three separate requests. The first sought the complete transfer schedule, including every page and attachment. The second sought the committee chair's appointment dates and any formally recorded absences during the transfer period. The

third requested the written rules governing delegated signatures when the chair was unavailable. Each request asked for certified copies or a written explanation if a record did not exist.

Lartey paused over the second request. “If the chair was away, someone else may have been authorised to sign.”

“Exactly. An absence is not misconduct, and a delegated signature may be proper. We need the rule in force on that date, the person named in the delegation, and the document the signature authorised. One piece without the others will not answer the question.”

At midday, the archive supervisor called to clarify that the restricted series could not be searched by the label S-4 alone. Several departments had used similar codes for unrelated collections. The supervisor requested the originating office, transfer year, and accession batch. Badu supplied the details from the certified transfer list and asked the supervisor to record the search terms used, including any variant committee names.

The supervisor also warned that a missing index entry would not necessarily mean the item had never been received. Some older collections had been re-catalogued, and cross-references were not always carried over. Badu asked that any possible match be reported as a lead, with the original shelf or box reference retained for verification.

After the call, he returned to the staff list. K. B. Mensah's six-week appointment as temporary records liaison remained a possible route into the committee's workflow, but not a basis to contact or accuse the retired inspector with similar initials. Badu drafted a request for the staff member's official personnel identifier and appointment record. Until then, he wrote "identity unconfirmed" beside the name.

Mabel sent him a message asking whether the committee had been formally connected to Agyeman's case. He replied that no document in their possession established that link. The committee's mandate made it relevant to the missing-attachment inquiry, but that relevance did not show that it had handled the schedule in question.

Late that afternoon, a certified extract arrived from the court administration registry. It confirmed that the committee had a chair and an administrative secretary, and that certain restricted material required controlled movement. The extract did not include the annex itself, a completed receipt, or the name of the person who had physically transported any box. The gap was real; its explanation remained open.

Badu read the extract with Lartey. The signature block was blank on the copy they had received because the extract certified the register entry, not the original transfer order. That limitation was stated in the covering letter. Badu added the letter to the exhibit

record rather than treating the blank space as evidence of a missing signature.

“The sender may have known exactly which blank would trouble us,” Lartey said.

“Or the sender may know less than we do and be counting on us to fill in the rest,” Badu replied. “We don’t let an anonymous person write our conclusions for us.”

At the close of the review, Badu checked the tasks: obtain the complete transfer schedule; verify the chair’s dates and any lawful delegation; trace the restricted series through the accession register; establish whether the annex reference matched the S-4 materials; and leave the temporary liaison’s identity unresolved until an official identifier arrived. None of these tasks required a suspect’s name. Each required records another investigator could check.

The message remained on the case system, sealed inside its proper category: an unverified lead. Outside the office, the day’s rain had stopped, leaving the windows bright and the street noisy with returning traffic. The committee had closed years earlier, but its administrative decisions were still producing consequences. Whether those consequences came from routine disorder, deliberate interference, or a mixture of both was the question the records had yet to answer.

A Conversation Without a Recorder

Daniel chose the meeting place himself: a small public garden beside a busy road, with benches far enough apart that conversations did not easily overlap. He had told Ms. Boateng that he did not want another office meeting, another table between him and a photograph, or another person asking him to confirm a story someone else had already written.

Mabel arrived first and waited without opening her notebook. When Daniel came, he looked at her hands.

“You’re not recording?” he asked.

“Not unless you agree. I thought we could talk first and decide whether anything belongs in my notes.”

He sat at the opposite end of the bench. For a while they watched a child trying to persuade a reluctant pigeon to move from the path. The ordinary scene made Daniel seem younger than he did in the case room, but when he spoke his voice carried the fatigue Mabel had heard before.

“People keep asking what I remember,” he said. “They don’t ask what I was told not to remember.”

“Do you know who told you?”

“No. That is the problem. There are gaps in my own memory, and there are gaps other people may have created. I can’t tell the difference just because one version hurts more than the other.”

Mabel let the silence stand. She had learned that filling a pause often produced an answer the speaker thought she wanted.

Daniel described a family visit from years earlier. An adult had brought a paper envelope and spoken with his mother in a room where the children were not allowed. Daniel remembered the envelope because it had been sealed with a strip of brown tape, not because he had seen its contents. Later, he remembered hearing the phrase “keep it with the school papers.” He could not place the exact date or identify who had said it.

“Is that the envelope you told Badu about?” Mabel asked.

“It may be. I remember the tape. I remember the phrase. I don’t remember a number on it.”

“Then we shouldn’t say it was the same envelope.”

He studied her as if he had expected resistance. “You really can leave a question open?”

“I have to. Otherwise I turn your memory into evidence it cannot carry.”

Daniel looked back toward the road. He said his mother had kept school certificates, vaccination cards, and old letters in a tin trunk. When he had asked about the envelope years later, she had told him that the family should not go looking for trouble. He could

not say whether she had meant the envelope, a person, or the larger confusion around his records.

“Did she ever explain why?” Mabel asked.

“No. She said some questions were expensive.”

The sentence stayed with Mabel, but she did not immediately turn it into a quotation. She asked whether Daniel wanted Badu to know about the memory. He said yes, provided the account included the uncertainty and did not make his mother appear to have concealed a crime.

They agreed that Daniel would write down what he remembered separately from what he had later learned from records and conversations. The two accounts would remain distinct. If he could not date a memory, he would say so. If he was repeating someone else’s claim, he would identify it as such.

When Mabel finally opened her notebook, she recorded only the agreed next step. Daniel watched the pigeons scatter as a bus roared past.

“I used to think the answer would be a name,” he said. “Now I wonder if the answer is that several people made decisions, and none of them saw the whole thing.”

“That is possible,” Mabel said. “It is also possible that someone did see more than they admitted. We don’t know yet.”

He gave a brief, tired smile. “You are very careful with hope.”

“I’m careful with certainty. Hope is yours to keep.”

They parted without a dramatic revelation. The meeting yielded neither a new document nor a confirmed identity. What it offered was less dramatic but more reliable: a memory whose limits were clearly marked.

Ama’s Unsent Reply

Ama Serwaa Quartey kept a copy of the message she had begun writing to Badu and never sent. She showed it to him at their second meeting, explaining that she had deleted the draft because every sentence sounded either accusatory or evasive.

“I could remember the atmosphere,” she said, “but I could not swear to the wording of an instruction from twenty years ago.”

The draft contained three phrases she had typed and removed: the room was tense; the schedule was incomplete; nobody wanted to sign first. None named a person or established an order. Badu asked whether the phrases came from a diary, a conversation or her own present recollection. Ama said they were recollections, not quotations.

They went through her old meeting notes together. The paper was brittle at the folds, and several pages had been written on the reverse of unrelated notices.

One entry recorded that a discussion had been postponed until a schedule could be checked. Another noted that a member had asked for the number of attachments to be confirmed. Neither entry identified which attachments or why the count mattered.

Ama looked disappointed by the modest result. Badu told her that a limited fact honestly recorded was more valuable than a confident reconstruction. Before she left, she agreed to provide the notes for imaging and to write a separate statement distinguishing what she had seen at the time from what she had learned later. Her cooperation did not solve the case. It made the boundaries of her knowledge clearer.

A Clerk’s Account

One of the clerks interviewed during the archive inquiry, Mr Salia, remembered the corridor repairs because his desk had been moved twice in one week. He brought a small diary in which he had recorded overtime hours and transport expenses. The entries were not a register of files, but they helped establish which afternoons he had remained in the building.

Salia recalled carrying a shallow tray between temporary desks. He remembered it because the tray’s handle had been loose and he had asked for a replacement. He could not recall which bundles were inside it. The team compared his diary with the repair schedule and found that he had been present on two of the days when the disputed records might have

moved. Presence established opportunity to handle routine work, not involvement in the disappearance.

When Badu asked whether Salia had ever taken documents home, the clerk looked offended. He then described one occasion when he had carried a folder to a supervisor’s office after the main corridor was locked. The folder was signed back in the following morning. The episode appeared in a duty note, though not in the central register. It demonstrated that the office had used secondary routes during the repair period, but it did not show that the missing enclosure followed one.

Badu asked for permission to copy the relevant diary pages and recorded the clerk’s account without suggesting a suspect. Salia left relieved that he had been allowed to describe a messy process without being treated as the explanation for it. The team gained a practical lead: find the supervisor’s duty notes and determine whether other after-hours transfers had been recorded in the same way.

The Member Who Stayed Behind

The former committee member agreed to meet in a public garden beside a row of offices, choosing a bench where neither of them would be forced to lower their voices. She introduced herself as Mrs Esi Agyapong, not to be confused with the archive supervisor who shared her surname. She had served as a minute-taker

for only part of the committee's life and had left before its final report was circulated.

"I can speak about meetings I attended," she said. "I cannot speak for the committee as a whole, and I do not want a newspaper saying I confirmed something I never saw."

Badu assured her that any statement would be read back to her before signature. She began with the committee's workload: requests arrived from several offices, some with clear authority and others carrying a note that approval was expected to follow. Staff were asked to keep the work moving while the formal paperwork caught up. She had objected to that practice, she said, because an informal instruction could become difficult to reconstruct once the people involved had moved on.

"Did Yaw Ofori give such instructions?" Badu asked.

"I remember him in meetings. I remember that people listened when he spoke. I do not remember him telling me to remove a document or alter a register."

She recalled one meeting where the committee debated whether certain schedules should remain attached to the main report or be stored separately. The debate concerned privacy and the risk of exposing names that were not necessary to the published findings. One member argued for a separate schedule; another wanted a sealed annex with a cross-reference in the public file. The minutes recorded the decision to

seek further advice, but Mrs Esi Agyapong could not remember whether the advice had arrived.

“Would a separate schedule have been called a fifth copy?” Badu asked.

“Not in the meeting I remember. We spoke about an annex, a working copy, and a sealed schedule. But the terminology may have changed in another office. I will not tell you those phrases mean the same thing.”

She described the committee’s final weeks as a period of fatigue and administrative confusion. People were preparing handover lists while trying to finish outstanding requests. Boxes were moved to make space for another unit. Staff members who had worked together for years disagreed over what should be retained and what could be returned to the originating office. The disagreement was not always sinister; sometimes the rules were unclear, and sometimes two rules seemed to conflict.

“Was the committee dissolved because of the records?” Badu asked.

“I don’t know. We were told the committee had completed its work. Some people believed there was unfinished business. Belief is not the same as a reason recorded in a decision.”

She offered to search her personal calendar and a folder of meeting invitations, but refused to hand over private correspondence that might contain unrelated information about other people. Badu said he would

submit a formal request if a specific document became necessary. He did not ask her to open the folder there on the bench.

Before they parted, the former committee member, Mrs Esi Agyapong, asked whether the investigation had found the schedule. Badu told her it had not been authenticated or located in a form that could answer the question. She looked disappointed, but not surprised.

“Then don’t let them turn my memory into a document,” she said. “I can help you find the meeting. I cannot replace the missing paper.”

Badu returned to the station with a possible date range for the discussion and two names of staff members who had been present. He entered the leads as follow-up tasks. The interview had not identified a culprit. It had made the committee’s administrative history more complicated, and more human.

PART TWO — THE PEOPLE WHO REMEMBER

A Clerk’s Ordinary Day

The clerk agreed to meet Badu at the end of his shift, when the public counter had closed and the queue of people seeking copies, certificates, and corrections had finally disappeared. He brought no dramatic revelation. Instead, he brought a timetable of the tasks he remembered doing on the day the disputed packet may have passed through the office. The timetable was reconstructed from duty rosters and routine work, not from a claim that he could recall every movement after so many years.

He explained that incoming packets were sometimes opened at a desk, sometimes moved intact to a supervisor, and sometimes placed in a tray until the correct officer returned. The choice depended on the label, the urgency, and the instructions available at the time. A tray was not a secure destination by itself; it was a stage in the process. If a packet had been left there, the next movement might have been recorded in a separate book that no longer survived.

Badu asked whether the clerk had ever been instructed to hold a packet without entering it. The man considered the wording carefully. He remembered urgent instructions to delay processing until a supervisor arrived, but he did not remember an instruction to conceal an item. He said the difference

mattered. An authorised delay might leave a gap between arrival and registration; concealment would require evidence of intent. He could not supply that evidence from general experience.

The clerk described one afternoon when a supervisor had asked staff to move a stack of files away from a leaking window. Several bundles were placed temporarily in an adjoining room. The incident was unrelated as far as he knew, and he could not connect it to the fifth-copy lead. Badu recorded it as a possible explanation for the movement of records in that office, not as a claim that the disputed packet had been among them. The clerk seemed relieved that his ordinary recollection had not been turned into an accusation.

At the end of the interview, the clerk asked whether he could read his statement before signing. Badu encouraged him to correct anything that did not reflect his meaning. The clerk changed the phrase “I moved the packets” to “I helped move the packets with two other staff members.” It was a small correction, but it altered the impression of sole control. Mabel watched the change and understood why interviews had to preserve the witness’s own words rather than compress them into a convenient summary.

On the walk back to the car, Badu told Mabel that routine explanations were not obstacles to the truth. They were part of it. If the packet had moved through an ordinary process, the team needed to establish that

process before looking for a person who had broken it. If the process had been manipulated, the comparison records might help show where. Either way, the next step was not to choose a suspect; it was to test the account against the surviving paperwork.

Salia’s Route Through the Temporary Office

Salia offered to walk the investigators through the temporary office where desks had been moved during the repairs. He asked that they visit during ordinary working hours, when the corridor and service counter were in use, because a quiet room made every movement appear simpler than it had been. Badu agreed. They did not ask Salia to recreate the disputed day; they asked him to show the route he remembered using when carrying trays.

The first route passed a noticeboard and a narrow doorway where two people could not comfortably pass with boxes. The second went around the back of a filing cabinet and emerged beside the supervisor’s desk. Salia demonstrated how a tray with a loose handle had to be supported underneath. He remembered the awkwardness clearly, but not the date of any particular journey. Badu noted that a vivid memory of the tray did not identify its contents.

A junior investigator measured the distance between the temporary desks and the receiving counter. The route was shorter than the team had assumed, though the doorway could slow a person carrying a load. The measurement helped explain how staff might move papers during a repair period, but it did not show that the disputed file had taken that route. Badu asked the investigator to label the diagram “possible working route” rather than “document route.”

Salia grew quieter as they returned to the corridor. He said that, years earlier, he had worried that an imperfect recollection would be treated as a lie. Badu told him that a witness could be accurate about the general routine and uncertain about a particular day. The distinction was not a courtesy; it was necessary for a reliable account. Salia signed the route diagram only to confirm that it represented the layout as he remembered it, not to certify the movement of any named bundle.

The Aunt’s Question

Daniel’s aunt called after dinner and asked whether the investigators had found the name she had been afraid to mention. Daniel said they had not asked her to identify anyone, and she had not offered a name in the recording. She explained that the fear had grown over years of hearing the family discuss

the past in fragments. Each retelling had made one person seem more certain, until uncertainty itself began to feel like a betrayal.

Daniel asked whether she wanted to add anything to her statement. She said she wanted to clarify one point: she remembered being told that a document had been taken away, but she could not remember seeing it herself. That distinction had become clear only after listening to the recording. Daniel wrote down her correction and told her he would pass it on without adding an interpretation.

When Mabel received the clarification, she attached it to the earlier account rather than replacing it. The record now showed both the original wording and the later explanation. It was not a dramatic new lead, but it prevented hearsay from being mistaken for direct observation. Daniel thanked his aunt for being willing to correct herself, and she replied that the truth was difficult enough without the family making it more certain than it was.

CHAPTER SIX — THE SECRETARY'S COPY

Ama Serwaa Quartey's first response arrived at 8:17 on Tuesday morning. Its careful wording suggested someone accustomed to turning difficult conversations into formal records.

I am willing to clarify my administrative role on the committee, she wrote. I cannot discuss restricted records by telephone. Please send the purpose of the request and the authority under which you are acting.

Badu read it twice. It was neither invitation nor refusal, but a reasonable boundary. He forwarded it to the case administrator and requested a formal approach through the proper channel. An anonymous sender's reference to a blank signature line was no reason to arrange a private meeting with a former secretary.

Lartey appeared in the doorway with a thin folder. "We have the chair's appointment dates, but not the delegation register. The registry says it may have moved with the committee's administrative files."

"May have been?"

"They have an inventory entry. They don't have the box."

Badu closed the email. "Then we have an inventory entry and a box we haven't located. We do not have evidence of a stolen register."

“I know.”

“Say it that way in the log.”

The case was acquiring a vocabulary of its own: missing, transferred, not located, incomplete, restricted. Each term carried a different meaning. If they blurred those distinctions, gaps could begin to look like proof.

By nine, the formal request had reached the court administration registry. It cited the case reference and explained the possible link between the S-4 dispatch note and the committee’s document-handling procedures. It requested the secretary’s copy of the closure schedule, any delegation register, and the relevant transfer record. It did not allege that the committee had concealed evidence in Judge Agyeman’s murder.

The press liaison sent Mabel a copy of the public-facing request. She had asked for the committee’s published mandate and closure notice, not its restricted annexes. Her reporting first needed to establish what the committee was authorised to do, then what it had actually done.

At the newsroom, she placed the closure notice beside the cropped-form photograph. The notice referred to a “secretary’s working copy” in a paragraph on routine administration; the crop used “restricted appendix.” The difference justified a question, not a conclusion.

She called the records officer who had supplied the public notice. Secretaries, he explained, often kept working copies of schedules for minute-taking and follow-up. They were not necessarily signed originals. Some stayed with the minutes; others went back to the registry when a committee closed.

“Would a secretary’s copy show who authorised a transfer?” Mabel asked.

“It might contain a note for the secretary’s use,” he said. “That wouldn’t prove the note was approved or that the transfer happened exactly as recorded.”

“And if a copy is missing?”

“Then the copy is missing,” he said. “You’d need the register, the receiving office, or another independent record to understand its significance.”

Mabel recorded the answer. It lacked drama but mattered. Careful wording could keep a story from becoming rumour dressed as revelation.

At eleven, Badu and Lartey met the registry’s deputy administrator, Mr. Koomson, in a small conference room overlooking the inner courtyard. Koomson brought a printed index and a list of boxes moved during a digitisation project. Three entries were highlighted in yellow.

“These references may correspond to the committee’s administrative files,” he said. “The original labels weren’t consistent. One box is listed under the

committee’s shortened name, another under the department that hosted it, and the third as general correspondence.”

“Can you confirm that any one of them contains the secretary’s copy?” Badu asked.

“No. The index points to those boxes. Their contents haven’t been checked against your request.”

“Then we need a supervised search. Record each box number before opening it, and document the contents as we find them.”

The deputy administrator seemed relieved that Badu had not demanded the boxes be taken straight to the station. The archive was not a warehouse from which investigators could remove anything that looked relevant. Its procedures protected the records from careless handling and the investigation from later challenges to how evidence had been obtained.

The search was scheduled for the following afternoon. Until then, the deputy administrator supplied certified copies of the index pages and explained the numbering system. The same numeral might identify a shelf, a transfer batch, or a committee exhibit. Without its heading and surrounding entries, it meant little.

That afternoon, Ama Serwaa Quartey replied to the formal request. She confirmed that she had served as the committee’s administrative secretary for part of its existence. She did not recognise the S-4 label, but remembered keeping a personal working copy of the

closure schedule because several departments had disputed which records they were required to return.

The working copy, she wrote, might be among papers she had kept after the committee closed. She would not search for it or hand over personal papers informally. She requested written authority and offered to attend an interview with a representative if the request was approved.

Lartey read the message over Badu’s shoulder. “That sounds promising.”

“It’s specific,” Badu said. “We can decide whether it is promising after we verify it.”

He asked the case administrator to preserve the message and verify what authority was needed for voluntary production of documents. They would not pressure Quartey to search her home or imply that an old working copy made her a suspect. For now, she was a former official who might explain the record system.

Mabel’s own lead arrived from a different direction. A retired typist who had worked in the court administration building agreed to speak on background about the committee’s routine. The woman, who asked that her name not be published until she understood the implications, remembered that the secretary often carried two folders: a blue folder for meeting papers and a grey one for follow-up actions.

“Did you see a restricted appendix in either folder?” Mabel asked during their recorded interview, after explaining that she would not promise secrecy beyond the limits they had agreed.

“I saw a grey folder with a red tab. I cannot tell you what was inside. I was not allowed to read it.”

“Do you remember a fifth copy?”

The typist paused. “I remember being told to prepare five sets of a schedule once. I don’t know whether all five were printed, whether they were complete, or where they went. It was years ago, and I handled many sets of papers.”

“Who gave the instruction?”

“I cannot say with confidence. It may have come through the secretary’s office. I remember the work, not the person.”

Mabel did not hide her disappointment. “Would you be comfortable signing a statement that you remember preparing five sets, but cannot identify the requester or confirm what happened to them?”

“If that is exactly what it says.”

“That is exactly what it will say.”

The interview added one limited fact: a former typist recalled being asked to prepare five sets of a schedule. It did not establish that the sets were the same document as the disputed S-4 enclosure, prove that five complete copies existed, or identify the requester.

Mabel wrote those limitations at the top of her notes before recording the lead.

When Badu heard about the interview through the agreed liaison channel, he asked Mabel to ensure the statement was preserved in its original form. He did not ask her to reveal a source who had not consented to identification. Instead, he sent a formal request for any document the typist was willing to provide and made clear that the investigation would seek corroboration independently.

The leads converged on the phrase “secretary’s working copy.” The typist remembered multiple sets; Quartey remembered a working copy; the registry had an inventory entry for a transfer box. None proved that the disputed enclosure had reached the secretary. Together, however, they offered a lawful, testable route to the next record.

At 4:36, the anonymous account sent another message to the case inbox. It contained no attachment this time. The text read: THE SECRETARY KEPT HER OWN COPY. ASK WHY IT WAS NEVER RETURNED.

Lartey brought the message to Badu without comment.

“It could be someone repeating what they heard,” he said. “Or someone trying to make us interpret an ordinary working copy as evidence of wrongdoing.”

“Either way, we preserve it,” Badu said. “And we do not ask Quartey why she failed to return something

until we know that she had it, that it was due for return, and that it was not returned."

He entered the message as an unverified communication, linked it to the existing anonymous contact record, and requested an access-log review. No one was to open a link or download a file from the sender without approval from the digital evidence officer. The sender appeared to know which questions were being asked. That might indicate access, careful research, or deliberate guesswork; confidence alone could not distinguish among them.

After office hours, Mabel sat with her draft open and deleted a sentence that described the secretary's copy as "the missing link." The phrase made a claim the reporting could not yet support. She replaced it with a narrower line: investigators were seeking to establish whether a working copy existed and whether it could be matched to the committee's transfer records.

Her editor read the revision and nodded. "Less dramatic."

"More accurate."

"Keep it."

At the archive, the following afternoon's search would begin with three boxes, each logged by its existing reference. If the secretary's copy was found, the team would record its condition, location, and relationship to surrounding documents before drawing conclusions. If it was not found, the search would be

recorded as a search—not as proof that somebody had removed it.

Badu wrote the plan on the board: verify the boxes; inspect their contents in sequence; preserve the original order; photograph relevant pages in context; obtain certified copies where permitted; compare dates and signatures with independent examples; and record every limitation. Beneath the list, he wrote a separate instruction: Do not let the anonymous sender determine what the evidence means.

Before leaving, he reviewed the three leads. The typist remembered preparing five sets but could not identify the requester. Quartey remembered a working copy and was willing to cooperate through formal channels. The registry had identified a plausible group of boxes but had not examined them. These remained separate accounts, not a proven chain.

His phone vibrated once. A message from Daniel said he had reviewed the inventory of papers he had already provided and found no reason to alter his account. He was willing to answer further questions with his adviser present. Badu replied that the team would contact him through the agreed channel if clarification was needed.

He turned off the office light. The secretary's copy might be a routine duplicate, a record explaining where the restricted appendix had gone, or an object misunderstood by everyone who had handled it. Until

the boxes were opened, it remained a possibility at the end of an incomplete paper trail.

The next day's search would not answer who ordered five. It might answer a smaller question first: whether the committee's own records could show what the secretary had been given, what she had been asked to return, and what the registry had actually received.

The Minutes After the Meeting

Ama Serwaa Quartey agreed to meet Badu in a public conference room at the legal aid centre, with her own notebook on the table and her handbag placed beside her chair. She had requested that the meeting be treated as a preliminary account, not a formal statement. Badu agreed, provided the record made that distinction clear.

"You want to know why the committee closed," she said.

"I want to know what the records can establish about its closure, and what you personally remember."

"Those are not the same question."

"No. That is why I'm separating them."

She opened her notebook to a page marked with a date. "The last meeting was not dramatic. There was no argument that I can honestly describe as a confrontation. The chair read a prepared summary. Two members asked questions about storage costs. Someone said the work had been completed. The

minutes recorded that the committee's mandate had ended."

"Did everyone agree?"

"The minutes say the resolution carried."

"That wasn't my question."

Quartey glanced at him, then returned to the page. "I remember silence. It is not the same as agreement, but I cannot tell you what each person meant by it."

Badu asked whether she had kept a personal copy of the minutes. She said she had kept a notebook of action items, not the official record. The notebook had been stored with her old work papers and was no longer in her possession; after a move, several cartons had gone to a relative's house. She had not searched them because she did not know whether the notebook remained there.

"Would you be willing to check?" Badu asked.

"I can ask. I won't promise that a notebook exists because I remember writing in one."

"That's fair."

Before leaving, she added that the committee's work had been administrative on paper but personal in practice. People brought family histories, court disputes, missing references, and old grievances to meetings designed to deal with boxes and registers. Some members believed the committee could correct

the past; others thought it could only place the past in a safer cabinet.

“Which side were you on?” Badu asked.

“I was the secretary. I was meant to record what was decided, not decide what the past meant.”

He wrote that down without treating it as a conclusion. The distinction might have been a defence, or it might have been the most honest description she could give.

The Newsroom’s Second Desk

Kojo Frimpong moved Mabel to the second desk near the records cabinet, saying the change would give her more room to spread out her notes. She knew it was also a way of keeping the story away from the main newsroom floor, where every half-heard sentence could become a rumour by lunchtime.

The story was attracting calls from people who wanted to be quoted, people who wanted their names removed from records, and people who wanted to tell her the judge had enemies. Most began with the same assurance: they had information no one else possessed. When Mabel asked for a date, document, or name that could be checked independently, many took offence.

One caller claimed to have worked in the registry during the year of the disputed transfer. He would not give his name, but he described a corridor and a desk number. Mabel asked him to send a written account

through the newsroom’s protected channel. He said he could not risk it. She explained that she could not publish his claim without a way to assess it. He hung up before she could offer another option.

Kojo listened to the call summary and leaned back. “A source who cannot be identified may still be real. But a story cannot rest on a voice that refuses every form of checking.”

“He might be frightened.”

“He might be. Or he might be trying to direct you toward a person he dislikes. Those possibilities can coexist.”

Mabel opened a new page and wrote three headings: what the caller said, what could be checked, and what remained unknown. Under the second she listed the corridor layout, desk numbering system, and staff roster for the period. She did not record the caller’s description as a fact about the transfer.

Later, a junior reporter named Esi asked whether Mabel thought the anonymous messages were coming from someone inside the investigation. The question was asked quietly, without gossiping excitement.

“I don’t know,” Mabel said. “The messages may come from someone with access, someone who has seen published information, or someone guessing what we might do.”

“But they seem to know when we find something.”

“Or they send messages often enough that one appears to match an event. We need timestamps and a comparison before we can say more.”

Esi nodded and returned to her assignment. Mabel realised the younger reporter had expected a secret theory, perhaps a name. Instead, she had offered a method and wondered whether it sounded dull. For people whose reputations could be damaged by a careless sentence, it was anything but.

Near closing time, Kojo brought her a printout of the online response to the latest article. Some readers praised the caution. Others accused the paper of hiding the truth. One comment named a former official and described him as the person who had ordered five copies. The commenter offered no evidence.

“Should we remove it?” Esi asked.

“We should review it under the paper’s moderation rules,” Kojo said. “We don’t have to preserve a potentially defamatory accusation in public just because it appeared online. But we should archive it for the newsroom’s records before any action.”

Mabel added the comment to the list of claims that needed no repetition in the article. She did not call the named official for a reaction to a charge the investigation had not made. Instead, she asked the legal editor how to preserve the comment and document the decision to moderate it.

When she left, the second desk was still covered in papers, but the piles now had labels: verified, unverified, requested, received, and pending. The labels did not solve the case. They helped keep the investigation from reaching a conclusion by accident.

The Secretary's Corrections

Ama Serwaa Quartey arrived with a slim folder and a list of corrections she wanted attached to her statement. She had underlined the phrase "committee secretary" twice. It was not that she denied serving as secretary for a period; she objected to the way the title could imply that she had controlled every document the committee handled.

"I kept minutes," she told Badu. "I circulated decisions when they were approved. I did not run the registry, and I did not supervise the people who stored the schedules."

Badu moved the draft statement toward her. "Then we will make the limits clear."

She read silently for several minutes, marking the margin with a blue pencil. At the paragraph about a meeting held during the committee's final month, she stopped. The minutes showed that members had discussed a request for a confidential annex, but recorded no final decision about its destination. A separate action sheet referred to a temporary holding arrangement; the copy in the file lacked its last page.

“I remember preparing an action list after that meeting,” she said. “I cannot remember whether I sent it to the registry or to the chair’s office. We were working from handwritten notes. I may have kept a copy for myself, but I have not found it.”

“Would you have signed a transfer form?”

“If I was responsible for the transfer, yes. But I might have handed the papers to the administrative officer and expected the registry to issue its own receipt. That would have been normal. It would also mean the receipt should exist somewhere if the procedure was followed.”

She described the minutes as a record of what the committee agreed to discuss, not necessarily what every office later did. A decision could be recorded yet fail to reach the person responsible for acting on it. Conversely, a clerk might complete a routine task without the committee ever seeing the form. The documents were related, but not interchangeable.

Badu asked whether she remembered the phrase “five requested; four returned.” Ama read it twice. “I have seen summaries written that way,” she said. “It could describe a batch of papers received and the number returned. It could also describe outstanding responses. Without the heading and the page before it, I would not attach a meaning.”

She did remember a disagreement about whether a schedule should be copied for the chair, the legal

adviser, and the archive. The number of copies had changed as the discussion developed. One member wanted a working copy for annotations; another insisted that the signed original remain sealed. Ama could not recall the final number ordered, and she did not pretend otherwise.

“Could there have been five?” Badu asked.

“Of course. Five copies can be an ordinary administrative decision. The question is whether the record you have belongs to that decision.”

Before leaving, she authorised the team to contact the former administrative officer through the official channel. She did not provide a private address from memory, explaining that the officer’s circumstances might have changed. Her caution slowed the inquiry by a day, but it also prevented the team from treating an old contact list as current fact.

After she left, Badu added a line to the evidence matrix: MINUTES / ACTION SHEET / TRANSFER RECEIPT — THREE DISTINCT RECORDS. The gap between them had become the central question. No single page could bridge it alone.

The Seal and the Shelf

Before the boxes were opened, the records supervisor asked everyone present to state their role for the log. The ritual took only minutes, but changed the atmosphere. No one could later claim to have been

merely a visitor or to have touched a seal without being recorded.

One box carried a scuff across its lower corner. The scuff was photographed, measured and entered on the condition sheet. It might have come from a trolley, a shelf or the journey from storage. Badu refused to let anyone describe it as evidence of tampering until the packaging specialist had examined it.

Inside were ordinary forms, a broken file fastener and a divider marked with a reference that appeared in the disputed register. The divider was not the missing attachment. It showed only that the file had once been arranged by reference number. A clerk remembered a similar divider in another box, but his memory was too general to identify a matching file.

The team grouped the materials and photographed their original order before moving anything. When the inspection ended, they resealed the box with a new seal number and placed the old seal in an evidence envelope. Badu signed the form last. The record needed to show not only what they had found, but how they had preserved the limits of the discovery.

The Aunt’s Recording

Adwoa Sarpong played the recording once without interruption. The voice was older than Daniel remembered it, softened by the thin microphone of a phone that had been replaced twice since the conversation took place. The speaker mentioned a

school transfer, a box of papers, and a visit to a relative whose name was difficult to hear. There was no direct reference to a fifth child or to the disputed schedule. Daniel sat with his hands folded, trying not to force the familiar voice to say more than it had said.

After the first playback, Badu asked permission to make a working copy and document the device on which the recording was stored. Adwoa agreed but wanted to keep the original until the team explained its preservation process. Badu accepted the condition. The recording was a family item, not automatically a police exhibit because it might be relevant. The team would make a documented copy and record what could be established about its date and history.

Daniel asked to hear the part about the box again. This time he noticed a pause before the speaker said that the papers had been moved. He had always remembered the sentence as a warning, but the pause made him wonder whether the speaker had been searching for a word. Badu reminded him that pauses in recordings could reflect distraction, signal loss, or the speaker’s natural rhythm. They would note the feature without assigning it a meaning.

Adwoa explained that the family had used several boxes during a move. One contained school papers, another receipts and household documents, and a third had been left with a relative for safekeeping. She could not be certain which box the recording referred to. She remembered the move because it had been

stressful, not because she had kept a detailed inventory. Daniel listened without interrupting, and when she finished he asked her to mark the places where her memory was strong and where it was uncertain.

The family's disagreement did not become a confrontation. Adwoa believed the envelope had been kept with school records; Daniel remembered it in a drawer; another relative thought the papers had travelled separately. Each account could be mistaken in a different way. Badu asked them to prepare separate statements before comparing notes. The request seemed formal for a family conversation, but it would help prevent one person's recollection from quietly replacing another's.

Later, Daniel walked alone to the street where his aunt had lived at the time. The house had changed, and the shop on the corner had a new sign. He did not knock on the door or ask the current occupants to explain the past. Instead, he stood across the road and tried to remember the move as an event rather than a clue. What he remembered most clearly was the feeling of being told to wait while adults sorted out things he did not understand. That feeling was real. What the papers contained remained unknown.

The Recording's Missing Minute

Daniel listened to his aunt's recording again with Mabel present. They used headphones and stopped

the audio at each pause, not to force a meaning from silence but to identify where the recording device had captured a break. At one point a chair scraped across the floor and his aunt's voice became distant. The pause that followed lasted less than a minute, yet Daniel had built several competing explanations around it since the first listen.

Mabel asked him to write down what he remembered before they replayed the segment. Daniel wrote that his aunt had been talking about a visit to the school office. After listening, he admitted he had imported that detail from a later conversation. His aunt had not mentioned the office in this section. The correction unsettled him because the borrowed detail had felt like his own memory.

They labelled the transcript as a working aid, with time stamps and uncertain words marked openly. Mabel did not ask to publish the recording. She wanted to know whether the aunt had independently remembered a date, a person, or a document. The audio supported none of those details with certainty. It did, however, show that she had been careful not to claim knowledge she did not possess.

Daniel left with a copy of the time-stamped transcript and a new understanding of how family stories could change without anyone deliberately inventing them. A detail repeated by three relatives

might still come from one original speaker. A silence could be a forgotten word, a pause for breath, or a sound lost beneath the recording. He told Mabel that he wanted to keep searching, but not at the cost of turning his aunt’s hesitation into evidence against someone.

CHAPTER SEVEN — A SIGNATURE IN THE WRONG PLACE

The three boxes arrived on a trolley, their seals intact and reference numbers visible. Badu watched the records officer photograph each side before anyone touched a lid. Archive supervisor Mrs. Agyapong stood beside the table with the search authorisation in a clear folder. She had insisted that the search remain limited to the references in the written request.

“We are not opening the whole room,” Badu said. “We are examining these boxes because the index points to them. If the index is wrong, we record that too.”

Mabel observed from the marked area behind the table. She had been allowed to witness the public-facing stages of the process, not handle the material. Her notebook remained open, but she had agreed not to write down restricted personal information that was not relevant to the investigation.

The first box held routine correspondence: travel claims, meeting notices, and stationery receipts. The second contained duplicate agendas and a thin bundle of dispatch summaries. The third was heavier than its label suggested. Inside, folders were arranged by year, some with faded tabs and others with newer labels pasted over older ones.

The records officer read each reference aloud while the camera recorded the sequence. When they reached a folder marked “Supplementary Schedule — Movement,” he paused. Its tab had been replaced. A strip of older adhesive remained beneath it, and a handwritten code, S-4, was visible at the lower edge.

“That matches the code we are following,” said the archive supervisor, “but we still cannot say this is the missing file.”

“Exactly,” Badu replied. “We record the match and examine the contents.”

The folder contained a movement sheet, two routine memoranda, and a photocopied approval page. The original supplementary schedule was absent. A signature appeared in the lower right corner beneath the printed word CHAIRPERSON. The date stamp crossed the upper margin, while a handwritten note in the left margin read, “signed on behalf.”

Mabel leaned forward, then stopped herself before crossing the marked line. The signature looked familiar from the cropped anonymous image, but familiarity was not identification. She wrote down the visible wording, not a conclusion.

He instructed the records officer to photograph the page in place before removing it. The officer captured its front and back, the surrounding documents, and the folder label. The page went into a transparent sleeve, received a temporary exhibit number, and was

entered in the register. The remaining contents stayed in their original order.

“Who signed it?” Badu asked the archive supervisor.

“I cannot tell you from this copy. The signature register for that period is held separately. And “signed on behalf” could refer to delegated authority, a later annotation, or an administrative explanation. We need the delegation record.”

Badu nodded. “Then that is the next request. We do not fill the gap with a guess.”

The movement sheet recorded the folder as sent to a temporary review office, but the receiving field was blank. In the next column, a date had been written and crossed out with a single line. No initials accompanied the correction. It might have been a clerical fix, an incomplete entry, or something less innocent. The page alone could not distinguish among those possibilities.

Mabel asked whether the crossed-out date matched the date on the anonymous photograph. The records officer checked the photograph’s already logged description, not the sender’s unverified explanation. The dates appeared similar, but the photograph was cropped and its metadata had not been independently authenticated.

“A similarity is a lead,” Badu said. “Not a match until we can establish what we are comparing.”

The archive supervisor located a separate register listing officers authorised to approve temporary transfers. The relevant page was missing from the bound volume, but the pages before and after it were intact. There was no tear visible at the binding. The register included a note that certain approvals had been kept in an annex during the committee's final months.

"Missing from this register," Mabel said quietly, "doesn't tell us where the page went."

"Or whether it was ever inserted," Badu answered. "We need the register's history and the annex inventory."

They photographed the gap and recorded the condition of the binding. The archive supervisor signed the observation record, making clear that she had found the page absent during this search, not that she knew when or why it had become absent. Badu asked her to identify every person who had custody of the register since the committee closed. She warned that the list might be incomplete because responsibility had passed between departments during a building move.

By noon, the team had two distinct findings: a photocopied approval page with an ambiguous signature placement, and a transfer register missing a page from its current binding. Neither established that the fifth copy existed in the form described by the

anonymous sender. Neither proved that the chairperson had authorised a transfer personally.

Badu sent the copied approval page to a second document examiner, Dr. Lartey, under the same exhibit procedure. The examiner reviewed it alongside the previously logged carbon dispatch note as an independent assessment, but refused to compare the signature as if the two documents had the same purpose or origin.

“This is a reproduction,” Dr. Lartey said. “I can examine its visible features and state the limitations. This image alone cannot identify a signer reliably or tell me whether the annotation came before or after copying. We need a better source, if one exists.”

She pointed to a faint rectangular shadow around the signature block. It might have come from a photocopier lid, a prior copy, or a page overlay. The reproduction lacked enough detail to distinguish those possibilities. The words “signed on behalf” were clearer than the name beneath them, a fact that made the page more interesting but not more conclusive.

“Could someone have placed the signature in the wrong place?” Badu asked.

“A signature can be placed in an unusual position for many reasons. Layout alone cannot tell us why. We need the form’s original template, the applicable delegation rules, and a reliable comparison sample.”

Badu recorded all three requirements. The case had accumulated fragments that looked meaningful in isolation. His task was to find the records that could test them against one another.

Mabel returned to the newsroom with a careful description of the archive search. Her editor read it twice, then circled the proposed headline: “CHAIR’S SIGNATURE FOUND ON SECRET FILE.”

“It is not a secret file yet,” Mabel said. “It is a photocopied approval page in a folder associated with a restricted schedule. We do not know whose signature it is, or whether the authority was valid.”

“That headline is shorter,” her editor said.

“And wrong.”

They replaced it with a working note for a later story: investigators had located an incomplete transfer record and a photocopied approval page with an ambiguous annotation. Publication would wait until the newsroom independently verified the document’s status and the relevant authority rules. Mabel disliked the restraint because the public might mistake caution for indifference. She preferred that risk to turning uncertainty into accusation.

That evening, Badu received the official delegation schedule for the committee’s final six months. It listed a deputy chair who could approve routine transfers when the chair was unavailable, but only if the absence was recorded in the meeting log. The schedule

did not identify the person who signed the page. It did, however, provide a testable question: was the chair absent on the date written in the margin, and was the deputy's authority properly activated?

The meeting log was stored in another department. Badu requested it formally and asked that the original volume be preserved pending inspection. He also requested the template used for approval pages, the signature register, and any annex inventory covering the restricted appendix. Each request named the specific record and the question it could help answer.

Before leaving, he reviewed the findings with his team. The signature remained unidentified; the crossed-out date unexplained; the register page's removal date unknown. The anonymous crop could not serve as corroboration merely because it resembled a page found during the search.

"The signature is in the wrong place," one officer said, looking at the photograph.

"We do not know that yet," Badu replied. "We know it is in a place that requires explanation. That is a different statement."

He logged the next steps: authenticate the approval page's source; obtain the original template; compare the delegation schedule with the meeting log; trace custody of the transfer register; and, if possible, establish where the anonymous photograph came

from. The list was longer than the conclusion everyone wanted, but every item could be tested.

At home, Mabel reread her notes and noticed a small detail she had not included in the draft: the handwritten phrase “signed on behalf” was written at a slight angle, unlike the printed text. That did not establish a different author. People wrote annotations at angles for ordinary reasons. Still, she sent the observation to Badu with a note that she was not offering it as a conclusion, only as a feature worth documenting before the page was handled further.

Badu added the observation to the examiner’s list, then closed the file for the night. The investigation had not found the fifth copy. It had found a document whose authority depended on another document, and a missing register page that could not explain its own absence.

The next question was no longer merely who had signed. It was whether the signature had been made under a valid delegation—and whether the record that could answer that question had been kept, moved, or lost.

A Second Visit to Room Four

Badu returned to the building associated with Room Four with a facilities officer and a notebook full of questions. The room had been renamed and its furniture replaced. He was not looking for a ghostly trace of the past; he wanted to learn which details

could still be checked and which had vanished with renovation.

The officer showed him the old floor plan beside the current one. A partition had moved, and a door shown on the earlier plan had been sealed during refurbishment. There was no evidence that the door had been used on the relevant night. The change did mean that witnesses might be describing different layouts—or different stages in the building's history—when they spoke about the corridor.

He requested the renovation work order, the contractor's report and any photographs taken before the wall was closed. The officer agreed to search the facilities archive. He warned that photographs were often taken to document wiring and plumbing, not doors or people.

As they left, Badu paused outside the room. He could imagine a hurried meeting there, but imagination had no place in his report. He listed what the visit had answered and, beneath it, what remained open. The discipline was slow, but it helped prevent a room from becoming a story witnesses felt pressured to confirm.

The Book's First Owner

The stationery clerk who had found the blue dispatch book was able to identify an old label beneath the brown wrapping. The label carried a department abbreviation used before the office reorganised its sections. Badu requested the old staff directory and a

list of the rooms assigned to that department. The book’s first owner might be identifiable, but the label could also have been reused when a cabinet changed hands.

A retired assistant named Adjei recognised the abbreviation and remembered a dispatch book kept near the outgoing mail tray. He did not recognise the photographed cover. Staff sometimes reused books after their printed pages were exhausted, he explained, especially when replacement supplies were delayed. A book could therefore contain entries from different periods, and a pasted slip might be routine rather than suspicious.

The team compared the book’s paper, ruling, and handwriting with two other registers from the department. The comparison suggested that the first section belonged to the older period, while the pasted slips might have been added later. The specialist could not date the slips precisely. Badu ordered a page-by-page inventory and asked that no one infer a continuous history from the cover alone.

Adjei’s account gave the book a plausible administrative context, not a proven provenance. Mabel noted that this was the second apparently dramatic object made more complicated by ordinary office practice. That did not make the book unimportant. The team still had to establish which parts were contemporary with the disputed reference and which might have been added during later reuse.

The Inventory Witness

Before the boxes were opened, Badu asked a retired inventory officer to review the list that had led them there. Mr Frimpong arrived with reading glasses and tapped each line with one finger as he read. The inventory, he explained, guided storage; it did not guarantee that every box remained where the list placed it.

He recognised the format but could not identify the person who had compiled the particular list. Several departments had used the same template. The initials at the bottom might belong to a clerk who had checked the page, a supervisor who had approved the count, or an officer who had simply received the bundle. The original signature was too faint to distinguish.

“Would a wrong shelf number be unusual?” Badu asked.

“It would be an error. Whether it is unusual depends on the period and how often the room was reorganised.”

Frimpong remembered a relocation during which boxes were placed in temporary rows and the catalogue updated later. In the interim, a label might accurately describe a box’s former location while the box stood somewhere else. He could not say this had happened to the S-4 boxes, only that the system allowed for it.

Badu asked him to sign a statement describing the practice and its limits. The officer did so, then asked whether his name would be made public. Badu explained that disclosure would depend on the legal process and the needs of the investigation; no promise of secrecy could be made without authority. Frimpong appreciated the direct answer and agreed to remain available.

The interview offered a practical explanation for one kind of mismatch, but did not explain this one. Badu requested the relocation schedule and asked the archive to preserve every surviving version of the inventory, drafts included. A later version might show when the shelf reference changed, provided its date and provenance could be established.

The School’s Ordinary Files

Daniel accompanied the records officer to the school archive, where the oldest documents were stored in labelled cartons beneath a shelf of current admission books. The officer explained that old forms had been retained unevenly: some because of policy, some because a clerk had found them useful, and some because nobody had decided what to do with them.

They found a fee receipt with a date that matched one of Daniel’s remembered school terms, but it did not carry the disputed annotation. A transfer note used a shortened name common enough to belong to several

people. The school register listed a class and a term, not the personal history Daniel hoped it might settle.

“It is strange,” Daniel said, “how a record can be accurate and still leave out the thing you need.”

The records officer replied that forms answered administrative questions; they were not biographies. Listening by phone, Badu asked that each document’s location be recorded and no page detached from its folder. They also requested the school’s retention schedule so the absence of any related form could be assessed fairly.

Daniel left with certified copies, not originals. He seemed to understand the distinction now. The documents could support parts of his timeline, but they could not establish his identity history on their own.

The First Owner’s Ledger

The retired clerk who had first handled the book agreed to meet the team in a public reading room. He had kept a notebook of dates and assignments, but he warned them that it was a personal record, not an official diary. Badu asked him to begin with the notebook’s origin: when he started it, why he used it, and whether he had added entries later. The questions were practical, yet the clerk seemed to understand that his credibility depended as much on what he could not remember as on what he could.

He said the notebook helped him track work that crossed from one desk to another. He did not copy confidential contents; he wrote reminders such as a date, a box number, or a name to call. Several pages had been added after the original binding loosened. The paper differed slightly, and the clerk acknowledged that he had transferred a few reminders from loose scraps when he repaired it. The team photographed the binding, the pages, and the loose inserts before asking about any individual entry.

One line contained a reference similar to the one on the alleged fifth copy. The clerk could not say whether it referred to the same item. He remembered a period when the department reused short codes because the new catalogue had not yet been fully adopted. Badu asked for examples, and the clerk identified two unrelated files with overlapping numbers. The discovery made the reference less distinctive, but it also provided a test: the team could compare the date and destination against other surviving registers.

Mabel asked why he had kept the notebook after retirement. The clerk said it helped him remember the sequence of his work. He had also once been accused of failing to follow up a request. He did not present the notebook as evidence against anyone. “It tells me what I intended to do,” he said, “not always what happened after I left the desk.” Badu recorded the sentence because it captured a limitation of the entire inquiry.

The clerk remembered that a supervisor sometimes initialled a page after checking the day's entries. He could not identify the initials on the disputed copy from memory. The team requested verified examples from the personnel archive, with the consent of the records office. They would compare letter forms only if the samples could be tied to known dates and writers. No one was permitted to select a sample merely because it looked similar to the mark under investigation.

When the meeting ended, the clerk asked whether his notebook would be taken away. Badu explained the available options and the need to preserve the original while any examination was conducted. The clerk chose to provide it temporarily under a signed receipt. Before handing it over, he turned one page back and pointed to a note about a routine staff meeting. It might help establish who was present that afternoon, or it might be unrelated. He made no claim beyond that, and Badu did not ask him to make one.

The Book's Binding

The book conservator examined the blue dispatch book again after the team found a second register from the same department. She placed the volumes side by side and compared the binding thread, the way the cover folded at the spine, and the residue left by old labels. The similarities were real but ordinary. Books from the same supplier could share

materials, and a repair carried out years later could make two unrelated volumes look alike.

Badu asked whether the pasted slips had been added at the same time as the original entries. The conservator said that the paper edges suggested more than one period of handling, but the adhesive could not be dated with precision from appearance alone. She recommended a limited examination of the pasted areas and warned that removing a slip would risk damaging the underlying page. The team agreed that no physical intervention should be made unless the potential benefit justified the risk.

Mabel photographed the book’s outer edges and recorded the order in which the slips appeared. One slip overlapped a faint line of writing, but the overlap did not prove the line had been deliberately concealed. It might have been placed there to repair a tear or to attach a cross-reference. The book had become important because it was unusual, and that importance made it especially vulnerable to overinterpretation.

Before they left, Badu asked the conservator to prepare a neutral description for the file. It would identify the book’s materials, visible alterations, and limits of examination without suggesting who had altered it or why. The report would not give the investigators the certainty they wanted, but it would

protect the inquiry from a claim that they had mistaken physical age for criminal intent.

A Stop at the Public Counter

Badu and Mabel returned to the public counter during the busiest hour of the day. They watched the way visitors queued, how staff received envelopes, and how the delivery tray was cleared when it filled. The exercise was not designed to identify a particular person. It was meant to test whether the earlier reconstruction had underestimated the number of ordinary movements that could occur without attracting notice.

At one point a visitor placed a document beneath a ledger while searching for a pen. Another clerk moved a stack of forms to make room for a signature. Neither action was unusual, and neither concealed anything. Mabel noted how quickly the counter returned to its previous arrangement. A witness arriving later might remember the desk as orderly without remembering the brief confusion that had preceded it.

Badu asked the supervisor whether the routine had changed since the period under investigation. The supervisor listed new security procedures, a different tray, and a revised visitor log. The team marked those differences on the reconstruction so the modern demonstration would not be mistaken

for a precise recreation of the past. They left with a better understanding of the counter’s limitations, not a recovered memory of the disputed delivery.

CHAPTER EIGHT — THE ROOM FOUR WITNESS

The name came to Badu through a route that made him distrust it before he could even read it properly.

It was written on the back of a photocopy, in blue ink that had faded at the edges: E. A. Mensima. Beneath it, someone had added a telephone number and then crossed the number out. There was no date, no signature, and no explanation of why the paper had been kept.

Sergeant Lartey placed it on the table without touching the other exhibits. “It was inside the folder marked S-4. Not attached to anything. The archive officer says it was there when the folder was opened.”

“Did anyone photograph the folder before removing the paper?”

“Yes.”

“Photograph the paper in place?”

“No. The folder was already open when the officer noticed it.”

Badu looked at the image on the tablet. It showed the

folder's contents, but the angle concealed the lower corner where the note had been found. A procedural gap, small but real. He wrote it down instead of pretending it did not matter.

"Record the limitation," he said. "We can use the note as a lead. We cannot use it to say when it entered the folder."

The name had appeared once before, in an old visitor register connected to the building where the confidential review committee had met. The entry was difficult to read. The initials could have been E. A. or F. A.; the surname might have been Mensima or Mensah. It was enough to justify a search, not enough to identify a witness.

Badu asked the registry to locate the original visitor register and any index made at the time. He also asked for a record of who had handled the book since it entered the archive. He did not want a fresh transcription to become more authoritative than the damaged original.

By late morning, the registry had supplied a scan of the relevant page. The line read: "E. A. Mensima — Room 4 — called by secretary." The date column had been torn at the binding, leaving only the final digit. The entry directly above it was dated 1998; the one below it appeared to be from 2001. The damaged page

could not establish the exact date.

“Room Four,” Lartey said. “That sounds like our witness.”

“It sounds like a person was recorded as going to a room,” Badu replied. “We still need to establish which building, what Room Four meant there, and whether this is the same person.”

He made three separate enquiries. One went to the records office for the building plan. Another went to the committee’s former administrative staff. The third went through official civil-registration channels to determine whether the name could be matched to a living person without exposing unrelated personal information.

Mabel received the same clue from a different direction, though she did not know that Badu had found the note. Her source was a retired court messenger named Kofi Tandoh, who had agreed to meet her in a small chop bar near the old commercial district. He had contacted her after seeing a short, carefully worded report about the committee’s missing records.

“I don’t want my name in your story,” he told her as soon as she sat down. “And I won’t say anything that sends trouble to somebody who has done nothing.”

“Then don’t tell me anything you can’t stand behind,” Mabel said. “I’m not promising publication. I’m listening first.”

Tandoh stirred his water with a straw. He had worked as a messenger for a court office, not as a clerk for the committee. His duties had sometimes taken him to the building where the review panel met. He remembered a corridor with numbered doors and a room where visitors waited before being called in.

“People called it Room Four,” he said. “But I can’t swear that was the official number. It may have been the fourth room along the corridor.”

“Did you see a child there?”

He took a long pause. “I saw a young person. I cannot tell you how old. They were sitting with a woman. The woman kept telling them not to answer questions unless someone explained why they were being asked.”

“When was this?”

“I don’t know the date. I remember the rain. That is not a date.”

“Did you hear a name?”

“I heard someone say “Emmanuel.” I cannot tell you which Emmanuel. There were many people with that name.”

Mabel did not take out her recorder until she had explained what recording meant and asked permission. Tandoh agreed to an audio record but refused to sign a statement that day. He wanted time to think and to consult a lawyer. Mabel accepted the boundary. A reluctant witness could not be made more reliable by pressure.

“Did you see a document being removed from the room?” she asked.

“No. I carried envelopes from one office to another. I never opened them. I remember one envelope because the person who gave it to me told me twice that it was not to go through the general registry.”

“Who gave it to you?”

“I don’t remember. I might remember if I saw the old duty book, but I won’t guess at a face now and call it memory.”

It was less than Mabel had hoped for and more than she could responsibly print. She asked whether he would speak with an investigator if the meeting were

arranged through a formal channel. Tandoh said he would consider it after speaking with counsel. He would not hand over personal papers or identify former colleagues without advice.

At the office, Mabel wrote a note to herself: **Possible witness to corridor procedure; no confirmed date; no confirmed identity of child; no direct observation of document removal.** She saved the audio file in the restricted source folder and did not share it with the wider newsroom. The story was becoming more serious, not more publishable.

Badu’s official enquiry located a former committee receptionist, Esi Agyeman, who remembered a visitor called Mensima. She would speak only at the records office, with a lawyer present and no informal recording. Badu agreed. He wanted an account that could be tested, not a frightened recollection extracted in a hallway.

Agyeman arrived the following afternoon with a small notebook and a careful expression. She was not certain the name on the note belonged to the person she remembered.

“There was a woman who came more than once,” she said. “She asked whether a child could be interviewed without a parent being told. The secretary said any interview had to be authorised. I remember an

argument about procedure.”

“Was the visitor E. A. Mensima?”

“I cannot be sure. I remember “Mensima” because I had to write it down. I don’t remember the initials.”

“Did you see a child?”

“I saw a young person in the waiting area. I did not speak to them. I don’t know whether they were a witness, a relative, or someone brought for another reason.”

“Did you enter Room Four?”

“No.”

“Did you see the committee’s restricted appendix?”

“No.”

Her answers frustrated the investigators because they did not close any of the gaps. They also made her account more useful than a dramatic story would have been. Agyeman separated what she remembered from what she inferred, and she refused to fill the silences.

She remembered that the receptionist’s desk had a daybook and that visitors were sometimes entered

after the fact when the corridor was busy. She could not say that this had happened on the day in question. She recalled that the secretary controlled access to the committee rooms, but she had never seen a written delegation order.

Badu showed her a copy of the visitor-register line only after asking her to describe her memory without prompting. She studied it, then shook her head.

“I can’t authenticate this handwriting,” she said. “And the paper is a copy. If you want to know who wrote it, you need the original and someone qualified to examine it.”

The interview was documented. Agyeman read the record, corrected a date in her employment history, and signed only after the correction was made. She did not identify the retired Inspector K. B. Mensah as the person on the note or on the committee list. No one had asked her to, and she had no basis for doing so.

That evening, Badu and Lartey compared the new accounts. Three details overlapped: a numbered room, a young person in a waiting area, and an adult who questioned the procedure for interviewing that person. None established that the young person was Daniel. None established that the room was the same Room Four associated with the missing records. None proved that a document had been removed.

“Could be our witness,” Lartey said.

“Could be several people whose memories have been drawn toward the same phrase,” Badu replied. “We need to test the room number before we test the story.”

The building plan arrived the next morning. The committee had occupied two floors during the relevant period. On one floor, Room Four was a storage room. On the other, Room Four was a small interview room. A later renovation changed the numbering. The visitor register did not specify the floor.

The note’s apparent certainty dissolved into a more complicated question. Room Four might be a location, a file label, a shorthand used by staff, or a number added later. Until the building plan, visitor register, and committee timetable could be aligned, the phrase was not a conclusion.

Mabel received a message from an unknown number that night: “The witness remembers what the file forgot. Ask about the woman who waited outside.”

She took a screenshot, recorded the time, and sent it to her editor under the newsroom’s source-handling procedure. She did not reply. The message might have come from someone who knew the old building,

someone following the investigation, or someone trying to push her toward a particular story. It contained no verifiable detail beyond the reference to a woman waiting outside.

Badu was informed of the message through the established liaison. He asked for the original device and metadata to be preserved if a formal request became necessary, but he did not assume that Mabel's anonymous sender was the same person who had sent the earlier documents. Similar tone was not proof of common authorship.

The following day, Mabel and Badu met separately with their respective teams and reached the same practical conclusion: they needed the original records, not another chain of retellings. The visitor register had to be examined in its physical form. The room numbering had to be reconstructed against the building's renovation records. The former staff needed to be interviewed without being shown one another's statements first.

One question remained particularly delicate. If a young person had been brought to the committee building, the investigation had to establish the circumstances without exposing a possible child witness or turning a vulnerable person into a public spectacle. Badu instructed the team not to circulate names beyond those who needed them for

verification. Mabel removed every identifying detail from her working draft.

Before leaving the office, Badu reviewed the exhibit list. The handwritten note remained a lead. The visitor-register scan remained a copy of a damaged entry. The two recollections remained separate witness accounts. The anonymous message remained an unverified communication. Each item pointed toward the same corridor, but none yet established what had happened there.

He wrote a new task on the board: **Identify the room before identifying the witness.**

Below it, he added another: **Find the woman who waited outside—if the account can be independently confirmed.**

The fifth copy was still missing. The fifth child was still only a question. And now, for the first time, the investigators had a reason to ask whether Room Four had ever meant the same thing to everyone who used the name.

The Print Archive

The print archive occupied two rooms behind the newsroom's library. Old issues were stored in bound volumes, while the searchable digital database began only in the later years. Mabel had requested access to

the editions published around the period when the judge's name first appeared in connection with the records inquiry.

The archivist, Mr. Nartey, warned her that the collection had gaps. Some pages had been damaged by humidity; a few supplements were missing; the digital index occasionally misread names. He asked her to note the edition and page number for every item she wanted to cite.

They found a short report about an administrative reorganisation. It listed several offices moving to temporary accommodation and mentioned a public notice concerning delayed access to records. The report did not name the missing schedule. It did not mention Daniel. Still, the date gave Badu a way to compare the room-map changes with the movement forms.

A second article described a dispute over delayed responses to records requests. The article quoted a spokesperson who said that some files had been transferred to a central store. Mabel resisted the temptation to connect that statement directly to the packet. The wording was general and the date range broad. It might describe the same administrative process, or it might concern a different set of files altogether.

Mr. Nartey brought out the letters-to-the-editor folder. One letter complained that a request for a copy of a

school register had gone unanswered for months. The writer gave no name for the school and no reference number. The letter demonstrated that delays had been publicly discussed, but it could not prove the particular delay the team was investigating.

“Could the paper have reported the missing schedule at the time?” Mabel asked.

“If someone knew it was missing and told us,” Nartey said. “But a missing file is often invisible until somebody tries to use it.”

She requested scans of the relevant pages and recorded the collection’s limitations. When she later briefed Badu, she separated contemporary reporting from the official records. The newspaper articles were independent evidence of what had been publicly said, not confirmation that every statement was accurate.

Badu asked for the exact publication dates so the team could compare them with the registry’s renovation calendar. He also asked whether the articles might have informed the anonymous sender’s wording. If a phrase had been published years earlier, the sender would not need insider access to repeat it.

Mabel returned the volumes to the archivist. The search gave them a chronology and another possible route through which information could have travelled, but it did not identify the sender. In her notes she wrote: “Publicly available does not mean true; confidential-sounding does not mean private.”

The Signature Exercise

Badu asked the records team to prepare three enlarged copies of signatures attributed to the same period: one from a routine attendance sheet, one from the disputed transfer list, and one from a document whose origin was not in question. He did not ask the specialist to identify the writer of the disputed mark. He wanted to know whether the differences were significant enough to justify further examination.

The specialist, a patient man named Dr Kweku Asare, arranged the pages beneath a neutral lamp. He pointed out the variation in the way the writer crossed a letter and the uneven pressure at the end of the surname. Such differences could result from speed, pen type, writing surface, or a different hand. The samples were not all close enough in date or circumstance to support a firm comparison.

“People expect handwriting to behave like a fingerprint,” Asare said. “It does not. A person can write differently when signing a receipt in a queue than when preparing a formal letter. A copied signature introduces another layer of uncertainty.”

Badu asked whether the mark could be a tracing. Asare said the available image did not preserve enough detail to answer. He could request the original, if it still existed, but the image alone would not permit a responsible conclusion.

Mabel, attending to understand what she could accurately report, asked whether the apparent correction beside the signature suggested concealment. Asare shook his head. “It suggests a correction. Concealment is an explanation of motive. The paper does not establish that.”

The team logged the specialist’s observations as preliminary and agreed to seek the original document through the proper channel. Badu also requested examples of routine signatures from the same office, not because quantity would guarantee certainty, but because a comparison needed context.

After the meeting, Mabel told Badu that every careful answer seemed to produce three more questions. “That is what a careful answer does,” he replied. “It shows us where the boundary lies.”

On her way out, she looked again at the enlarged mark. It was no longer a villain’s signature in her imagination. It was a mark made by a hand, in circumstances they did not yet understand. The distinction was less dramatic and more useful.

The Route Reconstruction

Badu asked the transport unit to map the messenger’s possible route using only documented entrances, public corridors, and the delivery desk. The exercise was not a reenactment of a particular person’s movements. It was a way to determine how many

ordinary routes could lead to the same counter and which records might exist for each one.

The map showed three practical approaches. One passed the main gate and the public waiting area; another used a side entrance during scheduled deliveries; a third required a staff escort. The access log could confirm passage through the gate but did not record every turn inside the building. The map therefore explained why the existing log could not identify the messenger’s exact path.

A security officer remembered that the side entrance had been temporarily used during repairs, but his memory was not tied to a specific date. The maintenance log showed the entrance was available for several weeks, though it did not record each person who used it. Badu requested the contractor’s daily sheets and asked whether the guard roster could narrow the period. No one treated the side entrance as evidence of concealment; it was a feature of the building that needed to be accounted for.

Mabel studied the route map. The envelope could have arrived through several ordinary channels, weakening the assumption that an unusual route had been used. It also sharpened the question: they needed a record that distinguished this delivery from the many others. Badu filed the map as an investigative aid and barred the team from presenting it as a reconstruction of the actual delivery unless a witness or record supported that conclusion.

The House Beside the Old Staff Quarters

Mabel Owusu found the address through a public directory and checked it twice before leaving the newsroom. The house stood behind the remains of an old staff compound, its low wall patched in three places and its gate painted a blue that had faded toward grey. She did not enter. She called the number listed for the occupant and introduced herself as a journalist asking about a former records assistant whose name appeared on a public document.

“I don’t give interviews at home,” the man said.

“I’m not asking to come inside. I’d like to arrange a time and explain the subject.”

“The subject is old.”

“The records are old. The questions are current.”

“That sounds like a headline.”

“It isn’t one. I’m trying not to write a headline before I understand the facts.”

He did not answer immediately. Mabel could hear a radio in the background, then a chair scraping over concrete.

“You should speak to the archive,” he said.

“I have. They directed me to the public index. Your name appears there as a contact, but I don’t know whether the entry is current or whether you ever held the role it suggests.”

“Then don’t print it.”

“I won’t print an unverified claim as fact. But I would like to give you a chance to correct the record if it is wrong.”

He asked for her editor’s name and the newsroom’s main number. She gave both. He said he would call after checking with his family. The conversation ended politely, which made it no easier to interpret.

From the pavement, Mabel saw a narrow strip of garden where old files had been used to cover earth beneath a leaking gutter. For a moment she imagined every scrap of paper in the city given a second life as wrapping, lining, or fuel. Records survived in places no archive could catalogue, but survival did not make them reliable. A page could outlast its author and lose the explanation that once made it intelligible.

She returned to the newsroom without a photograph of the house. In her notes she recorded the date, the public source of the number, the man’s refusal to meet, and his request not to be named until the entry had been verified. It was not a revelation. It was a boundary, and she intended to respect it.

The Inspector’s Notebook

Retired Inspector Mensah brought a notebook to their follow-up meeting, but kept it closed until Badu explained the purpose of the session. The notebook had belonged to him during a period of consultancy work, and he wanted the record to show which entries

he was willing to discuss and which contained unrelated personal information.

The relevant page listed a meeting time, two initials and the words “security consultation”. It did not name the committee or mention S-4. Mensah said he remembered being asked about document movement and access control, but could not say whether the request concerned the disputed schedule.

Badu asked whether Mensah had written the entry on the day of the meeting. Mensah believed so, though he could not independently establish the date. The paper and ink were consistent with the notebook’s general period, according to a preliminary visual inspection, but that was not a forensic conclusion.

They agreed that a document examiner could review the notebook if necessary. Mensah would provide a signed account separating the written entry from his present recollection. The meeting ended without a revelation, but Badu left with a useful boundary: the notebook supported the existence of a consultation, not the identity of everyone present or the subject of every question discussed.

The Route Between Buildings

Kofi Bediako began the route reconstruction on foot, carrying a map printed from the facilities plan and a notebook with blank columns for time, distance, and uncertainty. He wanted to understand what a person could do between the old administrative building and

the receiving office without relying on the assumption that the shortest route was the one taken. The buildings had changed since the period under review. A gate had moved, a stairwell had been closed, and a passage shown on the old plan was now a storage corridor.

At each junction, Kofi recorded the current layout and asked facilities staff when the alteration had occurred. Their answers ranged from exact dates to vague recollections, which he marked accordingly. A route taking four minutes today might have taken six then—or been blocked entirely. The reconstruction could identify possible paths, but could not place a particular person on one of them.

Badu joined him at the covered walkway and asked why the receiving office mattered if the packet's contents remained unknown. Kofi explained that the records showed a possible movement between desks, and the route could help determine which logs or access records might have recorded the transfer. It did not prove the transfer had occurred. The point was to find the records that should exist if the proposed route were correct, then check whether they did.

They interviewed a caretaker who remembered a period when deliveries were sometimes redirected because the main entrance was being repaired. The caretaker could not recall the exact week or the packet. Kofi asked him to describe the procedure rather than identify the object. The caretaker's account

suggested that temporary diversions had been announced on a noticeboard and in the daily facilities book. Those books might have been discarded under normal retention rules, but the team now had a specific place to search.

At the receiving office, the route ended in a corridor with two doors that looked alike. One led to a public counter; the other to a staff workroom. A person unfamiliar with the building could easily have mistaken one for the other, but the old signage had been different. Kofi photographed both doors and requested historical plans. He refused to write that the corridor proved the messenger's familiarity. It showed only that the building offered more than one plausible path.

On the return journey, rain began to fall. The team waited beneath a concrete canopy while staff moved boxes away from a damp wall. Kofi watched the cartons, labels, and signatures on the temporary relocation sheet. The ordinary scene made the recordkeeping problem tangible: a box could be moved carefully and still become difficult to trace if its temporary note never reached the permanent register. He recorded the observation as context, not evidence about the disputed packet.

The Route in the Rain

A sudden rainstorm interrupted the route reconstruction and forced the team to wait beneath

the covered entrance. The delay gave Mabel time to speak with a cleaner who had worked in the building during the repairs. The cleaner remembered placing warning signs near a wet corridor and moving a bucket away from the doorway. She did not remember the envelope, the dispatch book, or any particular visitor. Her account was about the building’s conditions, not the disputed delivery.

When the rain eased, Badu asked her to show where the signs had stood. The cleaner pointed to two places, then corrected herself after seeing the maintenance photograph. One sign had been moved to keep a passage open. The small correction mattered because the original route map assumed that the corridor had been clear. The investigators revised the map to show that access might have been slowed or redirected during the repair period.

The cleaner asked whether her evidence was useful if she could not remember a person. Badu said it helped define what the route might have been like, but it did not identify who had travelled it. He explained that the team was collecting the conditions under which a memory had formed, not merely the names of possible suspects. She agreed to sign the diagram only after the note made that limitation explicit.

Back in the vehicle, Mabel watched rainwater gather along the kerb and wondered how many confident accounts had been shaped by an ordinary obstruction. One person remembered the corridor as open because it usually was; another remembered a detour because a sign had moved. Neither memory had to be false. They might describe different moments in a changing place. The route remained unresolved, but the reconstruction was more honest.

CHAPTER NINE — THE NAME ON THE SCHOOL FORM

The school form had survived because no one had thought it important enough to destroy.

It was folded inside a thin brown envelope with two fee receipts, a transfer note, and a list of textbooks. The paper had softened at the creases. A rusty staple had left two orange marks near the top. Across the first line, a clerk had typed a name in capitals: EMMANUEL BADU. Beneath it, in handwriting that leaned sharply to the right, someone had added: “known as Daniel.”

Badu read the two names without speaking. Daniel Sarpong’s history had passed through so many hands that every new document threatened to feel like an answer. Badu had learned to distrust that feeling.

“Where did this come from?” he asked.

Daniel sat across the table with Ms. Serwaa Boateng beside him. The envelope had been brought in voluntarily and logged under the agreed procedure. The original remained in a protective sleeve; the team had made working images so that the paper would not need to be handled repeatedly.

“From my old school papers,” Daniel said. “That’s what

I told you before. I didn't know this form was inside. I remembered the envelope, not every sheet in it."

"Did you write the words "known as Daniel"?"

"No."

"Do you recognise the handwriting?"

Daniel looked at the note for several seconds. "I've seen writing like it in old school records. That doesn't mean I know who wrote this."

Boateng leaned forward. "Please distinguish what you remember from what you're being asked to infer. We're here to preserve the document, not to turn his uncertainty into a statement."

Badu nodded. He asked the exhibit officer to record the exact location of the annotation, its appearance, and the fact that Daniel denied writing it but could not identify the writer. The officer photographed the form beside a scale, recorded the sleeve number, and confirmed that the image files would be retained with the original exhibit record.

"Could the annotation have been made later?" Badu asked the document examiner, Dr. Naa Korkor Addo, when she joined them.

“It could have been,” she replied. “The ink and paper may allow some observations, but we should not promise a date that the material cannot support. A handwriting comparison may identify similarities or differences if we have suitable known samples. It will not tell us automatically why a person wrote a name.”

The examiner noted that the form was a copy, not the original school admission record. The typed name and handwritten annotation might have been reproduced together, or the annotation might have been added to a later copy. The edges and staple marks suggested repeated handling, but they could not establish the document’s full journey.

Badu recorded the limits first. Only then did he list the possibilities.

The next task was to locate the original school register. The school had changed its record system twice and had moved some older files to a district archive. A former administrator remembered a register kept in a locked cabinet, but she could not say whether it still existed. The current headteacher agreed to cooperate through an official request and asked that student information be handled confidentially.

Badu’s team did not arrive with a list of accusations. They sent the document details, the likely year range, and the record categories they needed to search. The

school appointed a records officer to supervise the search. A second staff member recorded each box opened and each file returned to storage.

The first register contained an entry for Emmanuel Badu. The date of birth was partly obscured by a water stain. A transfer reference appeared in the margin, but the corresponding transfer book was not in the same box. No parent or guardian signature was visible on the scanned page. It was unclear whether the signature had been omitted, lost with a torn section, or recorded elsewhere.

A second register, from a later school year, contained Daniel Sarpong. Its transfer column referred to a previous school, but the name of that school was abbreviated. A note in the margin said “records reconciled.” It did not explain who had reconciled them, which records had been compared, or what the phrase meant in that school’s routine practice.

“Two entries,” Lartey said after the team reviewed the scans. “One child?”

“Possibly,” Badu replied. “Or two records connected by a process we have not yet identified. The documents suggest a link, but we still need independent corroboration.”

They requested the transfer book, the admission index,

and any circular explaining how the school handled changes to a student's name. They also asked whether the phrase "records reconciled" had been used for ordinary administrative corrections. Without that context, the annotation could be made to carry more meaning than it deserved.

Mabel heard about the school records through the formal liaison, not from Daniel. She asked her editor whether the newspaper should name the school. The editor said no. A school could be drawn into a national scandal through an incomplete record, and children who had attended it had no reason to be exposed because investigators were following a historical lead.

Mabel drafted a paragraph that said investigators were examining inconsistencies across historical educational records. She did not include the school's name, the image of the form, or the partially visible date of birth. The article could explain the public importance of reliable records without publishing details that might identify Daniel or invite strangers to contact former classmates.

Her editor returned the draft with one comment: "What do we know that we can prove?"

Mabel deleted the sentence that called the name change deliberate. She replaced it with a narrower statement: the records contained different names and

an unexplained annotation, and the reason for the discrepancy had not been established.

The narrower sentence lacked drama. It had the advantage of being true.

At the archive, a records officer found a transfer ledger with a reference matching the later school register. The entry pointed to a district office that had since merged with another administrative unit. A box list showed that several transfer books had been moved during the merger, but the list did not name every volume. One book was marked “not located” in a later inventory.

Badu asked who had written that notation and when. The archive could provide a staff rota and the inventory date, but no signed search report. The phrase “not located” meant only that the item had not been found during that search. It did not establish destruction, theft, or even that the book had reached that storage location.

The records officer agreed to search the adjoining collection. She also warned that some boxes had been repacked after a roof leak, and that labels might refer to the old shelf system rather than the current one. Badu asked her to document the search and preserve the original box labels.

That afternoon, Daniel returned to the office after reviewing the records request with Boateng. He was unsettled by the two names appearing in different registers, but he did not offer a theory about who had changed them.

“I’ve spent years trying to make sense of what I was told,” he said. “Every time I see another paper, people want me to say what it means. I don’t know. I can tell you what I remember being called. I can’t tell you who typed this.”

Badu asked what Daniel remembered from childhood. Daniel spoke about being called different names by different adults, but he could not place the changes in a precise order. Some memories came from his own experience; others came from family explanations repeated later. Boateng asked that those categories be recorded separately.

No one treated Daniel’s uncertainty as a failure. Memory could be sincere yet incomplete; a genuine document could still mislead. The records and testimony had to be tested against each other.

The examiner later reported that the available photocopy could not establish the author of the handwritten annotation. The typed name appeared consistent with the typeface used on other forms from the same broad period, but that was not a date

authentication. There were too many possible sources and too little original material for a stronger conclusion.

Badu added the report to the case file and revised the evidence board. The school form now had three columns beside it: what it showed, what it might suggest, and what remained unknown.

What it showed: the names Emmanuel Badu and Daniel, with an annotation reading “known as Daniel.”

What it might suggest: that a school record had attempted to connect the two names.

What remained unknown: who made the annotation, when it was made, what source they relied on, and whether it reflected a legitimate correction, an informal practice, an error, or something more troubling.

The distinction mattered because the broader case already contained a separate name history: Daniel’s birth name was Emmanuel Sarpong; a record had substituted Emmanuel Badu; later records used Daniel Sarpong. The new school form did not, by itself, prove who authorised any substitution. Nor did it explain whether the name Emmanuel Badu had been entered through mistake, coercion, impersonation, or a process whose paperwork had been lost.

Late that evening, an envelope arrived at the newspaper office without a return address. It contained a photocopy of a school transfer slip. The printed field for “previous name” had been left blank, while the field for “name to be entered” contained Daniel Sarpong. A short note in the margin said: “This was not the first form.”

Mabel did not assume it came from the same anonymous sender. She photographed the envelope as received, logged the time, and notified her editor. The slip was a copy of uncertain origin. Its paper, layout, and wording looked similar to the other school records, but resemblance was not proof of authenticity or common source.

She called Badu through their agreed liaison and described the item without sending it around the newsroom. Badu asked her not to mark it, fold it further, or try to locate the sender. If she chose to hand it over, the transfer would be documented; if she retained it for source protection, she would preserve the envelope and record what she could about its arrival.

The note had introduced a new possibility, but not a conclusion. There might have been more than one form. There might have been a routine administrative process. There might have been an attempt to correct a

prior error—or to conceal one. The copy did not tell them which.

Badu returned to the evidence board. The old committee file, the visitor-register entry, the school forms, and the disputed fifth copy now touched the same wider question: how had records travelled from one office to another, and who had authority to change them?

But the lines between the documents were still drawn in pencil.

He wrote one final instruction beneath the school-form exhibit: **Find the original transfer record. Establish the rule before alleging a breach.**

The name on the form was a clue. It was not yet an answer.

The Key Under Test

The locksmith arrived at the station carrying a plain tool case and a letter from the court authorising a controlled examination of the duplicate key. He was older than Badu had expected, with careful hands and a habit of asking people to repeat the exact question they wanted answered.

“You want to know whether this key could open the study lock,” he said. “That is different from asking who

used it, when it was used, or whether it was the key present on the night of the murder."

"That distinction is understood," Badu said.

"Then let us keep it understood."

The lock had been removed by a qualified technician and transported under seal. The locksmith photographed its condition before touching it. He checked the key's dimensions, the visible wear, and the pattern of cuts, then compared them with the lock cylinder. The examination was slow and unshowy. There was no dramatic click that settled the investigation.

The key could be inserted, but resistance varied. The locksmith explained that wear, dirt, later handling, or changes to the lock could affect the result. He would not force the mechanism simply to produce a yes-or-no answer. A damaged lock could create a false impression of compatibility, and a forced test could alter the very evidence they were trying to understand.

"Can you say it is the duplicate key?" Mabel asked from behind the observation line.

"I can describe its measured features and compare them with the recorded features of the key described in the earlier inventory. I cannot give it a history by looking at its teeth."

Badu asked the locksmith to make a formal report that separated measurements, observations, and interpretation. He also requested that the key and lock be returned to their separate evidence containers after examination. The chain-of-custody log was checked before and after the session.

During a break, the locksmith examined a photograph of the lock taken months earlier. The photograph showed a small mark near the plate, but its resolution was too poor to establish whether the mark had existed before the lock was removed. The locksmith said it could be a scratch, a reflection, or a compression artefact in the image.

Badu asked whether the mark could indicate that the lock had been manipulated.

“Not from this photograph,” the locksmith replied. “A mark is not a method. We would need a clearer image or a physical feature that can be examined directly.”

Mabel watched Badu write the answer without argument. She knew how easily the word manipulation could travel from a technical possibility into a headline. The public wanted to know whether the key had been used. The evidence could currently say only that a test had been conducted and that the result had limitations.

At the end, the locksmith sealed his report envelope and signed across the seal. The key was photographed again beside its evidence label. The lock was returned

to storage. No one had been identified as its user, and no one had been excluded solely by the test.

In the corridor, Badu stopped beside the noticeboard where the team had pinned the timeline of the judge's final day.

"The key tells us less than people expect," Mabel said.

"It tells us what it can," he replied. "The danger is asking it to tell us what only a witness or another record could establish."

He added the locksmith's report to the timeline, not as a solution but as a limit. The next task was to compare the technical findings with independently established times and accounts. A key could be compatible with a lock and still fail to explain the murder. That was why they had tested it.

The School Registrar's Ledger

Daniel agreed to accompany Badu to the school office where the surviving admission books were kept, but only after his adviser had been told the purpose of the visit. The school had changed its administrative system twice since the years in question. Its current registrar, Mr Antwi, met them in a room crowded with boxes of examination forms and old exercise books awaiting disposal.

Antwi cautioned that an admission register was not a pupil's biography. It recorded whatever information had been supplied at the time—by a parent, a

guardian, or a transfer form. Names were misspelled; dates were corrected; a child might use one family name at home and another at school. The school's practice was to preserve corrections rather than erase them.

Badu asked to see the relevant pages with the surrounding entries intact. Antwi placed the register on a padded table and turned the pages slowly. The entry for Daniel Sarpong was present. A separate entry for Emmanuel Badu appeared in a different term. The entries did not establish that the two names belonged to one person. The ages beside them were too imprecise to settle the question.

Daniel leaned forward, then stopped himself from touching the page. "I recognise the handwriting on the transfer note," he said, "but I cannot tell you when I first saw it."

"Would you recognise the person who wrote it?" Badu asked.

"Possibly. I would not promise that I could."

Antwi found a duplicate fee receipt in a separate ledger. It carried a date close to the transfer note, but the payer's name had been abbreviated. The registrar warned them that the books were stored in different rooms for years and that no continuous chain of custody existed for every volume. The receipt was useful as a lead, not as independent confirmation of Daniel's recollection.

Badu requested certified images of the pages and a written explanation of the school's recording practices. Daniel left with no answer to the question that had brought him there. Yet he seemed relieved that the register had not supplied an easy verdict. "At least nobody has to pretend the page says more than it does," he said outside.

Badu looked back at the school building. A record could preserve a name without preserving a life. Their task was to establish what the surviving paper could support, not force it to remember what had been lost.

Mabel's Three Envelopes

Mabel placed three envelopes on her desk and labelled them A, B and C. They represented three anonymous communications that had reached her by different routes. She refused to staple them together simply because each mentioned a records problem.

Her editor asked whether she believed the messages came from the same person. Mabel said she had no defensible basis for that belief. One message used formal language; another contained a phrase familiar from the registry; the third had no signature and little context. Similar wording could point to a shared source, copied language, or coincidence; it could not identify a sender.

She reviewed the newsroom's intake notes with a colleague who had witnessed the arrival of one envelope. They recorded who had handled it, when it

had been opened and which details were entered into the newsroom log. They did not reveal the identity of a confidential source, and Badu had not asked them to do so.

The editor wanted a headline that promised a breakthrough. Mabel proposed a narrower one: “Questions Remain Over Missing Registry Attachment”. It was less dramatic, but it did not claim the evidence had answered what it had merely raised. The editor accepted it after adding a line explaining that no individual had been accused of the murder on the basis of the messages.

When the story went to print, Mabel kept the envelopes separate. Their connection remained a hypothesis, and the newsroom’s credibility depended on preserving that distinction.

The Source’s Terms

The person who had called the newsroom returned with a short email and one scanned page. The page contained a reference to a committee meeting, but no signature or clear date. The caller asked Mabel to print it immediately and promised that the rest would follow once the story appeared. Mabel declined to make publication a condition of receiving the material.

She explained that the newsroom could protect a source’s identity within its ethical and legal limits, but it could not promise that a document would be published before verification. The caller said the

family had waited years and had lost faith in official channels. Mabel did not dismiss the anger. She asked for the original or a way to verify where the scan had come from. The caller refused, saying that the page had been copied by someone who feared retaliation.

Mabel passed the scan to the editor and recorded the terms under which it had arrived. They decided not to publish the page or describe its contents as authentic. Instead, they would use the reference to ask the archive whether a meeting of that committee had taken place. The inquiry could test whether the meeting had occurred without exposing the caller or endorsing an unverified document.

The response from the archive was limited: a meeting had been listed under a similar title, but the surviving minutes did not include the attachment mentioned on the scan. That result did not validate the page. It did establish a new route for a records request. Mabel sent a neutral follow-up and told the caller that the newsroom would continue checking, but would not trade accuracy for access. The caller did not reply. The page remained a lead, not a published fact.

The Source Sets a Boundary

The source agreed to a meeting only after Mabel confirmed that no recording would be made and that the conversation would not be treated as an on-the-record interview. Mabel did not promise secrecy beyond what she could ethically and legally maintain;

she explained the limits plainly. The source, whose identity remained protected in her notes, wanted to discuss the records system without being drawn into an accusation against a named official. Mabel accepted the boundary and asked the source to distinguish firsthand knowledge from office rumour.

The source described a practice of preparing duplicate schedules when a review was likely to attract later questions. One copy could remain with the originating office, another travel with the packet, and a third be retained by a supervisor. The number of copies varied according to the department and the urgency. The source had heard colleagues refer to an extra copy, but had never seen a document labelled the fifth copy. Mabel asked whether the phrase might have been informal. The source said it might, and would not speculate further.

When Mabel asked who could authorise an extra copy, the source described several roles rather than one person. A supervisor might approve it; a clerk might prepare it; a receiving office might request it. A person who signed the instruction would not necessarily have handled the paper. The chain of work was distributed. This did not make accountability impossible, but it meant that a signature could not stand in for a complete history of the document.

The source also warned that staff often used the word “missing” loosely. Sometimes a page had not been attached; sometimes it had been filed separately;

sometimes a copy was still waiting for a signature. The same word could describe different situations. Mabel asked whether the source had seen the disputed schedule. The answer was no. She did not press the question after it had been answered. A source was not a tool to be pressed until it produced the conclusion a reporter wanted.

After the meeting, Mabel wrote two columns in her notebook: what the source had directly observed and what the source understood from colleagues. The columns were not equal in length, but the distinction was clear. She shared the factual procedure with Badu without revealing identifying details that were not necessary to the inquiry. He asked whether the source could provide a formal statement. Mabel said she would return to that question only if the source consented and the legal safeguards were understood.

That night, an editor asked whether the source had confirmed that Ofori ordered the extra copy. Mabel said no. The source had explained a practice, not identified an order. The editor frowned at the distinction but did not argue. Mabel prepared a short note for the case file describing the limits of the information. She knew it would be tempting to turn an anonymous source into a witness who could solve everything. The source had given them a map of procedure, not a name.

The Table of Alternatives

Kofi cleared a section of the conference table and placed three folders side by side. The first contained the evidence supporting deliberate removal; the second held material consistent with a routine delay or filing error; the third contained facts that did not yet fit either explanation. He asked every member of the team to place each new document in the folder that best represented its current value. If a document supported more than one explanation, they were required to say so aloud.

The exercise exposed how often the same fact had been used in different ways. The overwritten count had been treated as evidence of manipulation, but it could also have resulted from a correction after a second count. The absent page suggested a gap, but the binding history offered a possible explanation unrelated to the packet. The anonymous message appeared to know details of the records, yet its author could have obtained those details from public sources or from someone repeating office gossip. None of those possibilities could be excluded by tone alone.

One investigator objected that listing alternatives made the team timid. Badu replied that alternatives were not excuses; they were tests. A sound theory should survive comparison with explanations that did not require a hidden conspirator. The team agreed to identify one observation that would strengthen each alternative and one observation that would weaken it.

That approach gave the next stage of work a practical purpose instead of allowing the inquiry to circle around the same suspicions.

Mabel used the table to prepare questions for her editor. What could the newsroom say about the missing page? It could say that the surviving volume had a gap and that the cause was not established. What could it say about Ofori? It could report his documented role in the committee and the fact that investigators had sought records relating to his calendar, provided the context and response were included. What could it say about the murder? Only that the records inquiry had not yet produced a verified link to the killer.

Daniel arrived later with a list of family papers he had found. The list included school certificates, a transfer receipt, and two envelopes that might have come from the same drawer. He had not opened or rearranged them beyond what was necessary to make the inventory. Badu thanked him and arranged for the items to be photographed in place. None of the labels matched the disputed reference exactly, but one date fell within the period of the family move. The team added it to the chronology as a lead with a clearly stated source.

By the end of the meeting, the folders had not produced a single dominant theory. Instead, they showed which checks remained possible: compare the receiving count with another independent register,

obtain verified handwriting samples, and establish the date range of the family papers. Kofi photographed the table before the folders were returned to their case sections. The image preserved not just the evidence, but the discipline the team had agreed to apply. They would continue to investigate suspicion, but they would not allow suspicion to decide what a document meant.

Mabel's Editorial Conference

The editor called a short conference after receiving two messages from readers who claimed to know the source of the anonymous document. Neither message included a verifiable detail. One reader offered a name; the other offered a theory about a political rivalry. Mabel asked that both claims be logged without being repeated to the reporting team as established leads. The editor agreed, though he worried that ignoring them might mean missing a genuine tip.

They reviewed the newsroom's publication checklist. A document needed a traceable origin, a reason to believe the copy was complete, and independent support for any allegation drawn from it. The checklist also required the team to distinguish what a source had personally observed from what someone else had told them. Mabel added a field for the chain of custody, because the

scanned page had passed through an unknown number of hands before reaching her.

A reporter argued that publishing a cautious story now might encourage the source to reveal more. Mabel said publication could not be used as bait when the claims concerned real people and a serious crime. If the story was wrong, the damage would not disappear simply because a later correction was printed. The editor did not dismiss the reporter’s urgency; he asked the team to prepare a version that explained the unanswered questions without naming an unverified suspect.

After the meeting, Mabel sent the source a brief response through the agreed channel. She asked for the original document or a clear account of how the scan had been obtained, but promised neither anonymity beyond the newsroom’s actual limits nor publication on demand. The source did not reply that day. Mabel filed the silence as a fact about the communication, not evidence of guilt or deception.

CHAPTER TEN — THE INSPECTOR'S SILENCE

Retired Inspector K. B. Mensah agreed to meet only after Badu's office sent a formal letter explaining the subject of the inquiry and the limits of the request.

He chose the conference room of a legal aid office, not the police headquarters. His solicitor sat beside him, and he asked that the meeting be recorded in a written note rather than an audio file. Badu accepted. The aim was to obtain an account that could be checked, not to win a contest over procedure.

Mensah arrived with a walking stick he rarely used and a folder that stayed closed on his lap. He looked at Badu for a long moment before sitting.

"You have a name on a list," Mensah said. "You have a question about a committee. You do not yet have a reason to make those two things one story."

"That is why I asked to speak with you," Badu replied. "I want to establish whether you served on the committee or had any role in the records under review."

Mensah opened the folder. Inside were copies of his service postings, a retirement notice, and an old identification card. He had brought them to establish

his identity, not to volunteer his entire career. Badu asked permission to copy the relevant pages. Mensah agreed, provided the originals remained with him and the copies were logged.

The personnel record confirmed that he had served as an inspector during the period under investigation. It did not place him on the committee's administrative staff. The committee list contained the initials "K. B. Mensah," but no service number, rank, or signature that could connect the entry to the retired inspector.

"I never worked as that committee's secretary," Mensah said. "I was asked once to advise on a security procedure. That is not the same as being a member, and I did not handle their files."

"When were you asked?"

"I would need to see the letter or the diary entry. I remember a conversation, not the date."

"Who asked you?"

"I believe it was an administrator from the building. I cannot honestly give you a name from memory."

Badu did not press him to guess. He asked whether Mensah had kept correspondence relating to the advice. Mensah said his personal papers were

incomplete. Some had been transferred to a family home; others had been discarded when he moved after retirement. He would search what remained, but he would not promise that a document existed.

“Did you ever see a file marked S-4?”

Mensah’s expression changed slightly, but not enough for Badu to assign it a meaning. “S-4 was a label used in more than one office. You must tell me which system you mean.”

“The confidential supplementary schedule associated with the committee.”

“No. Not that I remember.”

“Did you know Justice Agyeman?”

“I knew of him. I met many judges during service. If you are asking whether I had a dispute with him, you will need to be more specific.”

Badu asked about the night of the judge’s death. Mensah said he had been at home, but he understood that an alibi needed more than his own assertion. He offered the name of a neighbour who had visited that evening and said his household telephone records might still be obtainable through the appropriate process. He did not claim that either would prove

every minute of his whereabouts.

The interview remained measured. Mensah denied handling the committee's restricted appendix, denied authorising a change to Daniel's school records, and denied knowing who had requested five copies of the schedule. Each denial was recorded as his account, not as an established fact. Badu made clear that the investigation would seek corroboration rather than treat either denial or suspicion as decisive.

Outside the room, Lartey asked whether Mensah's reaction to the S-4 question had meant something.

"It meant I noticed a reaction," Badu said. "We don't know what caused it. Surprise, irritation, recognition, fatigue—there are several explanations. We need evidence that doesn't depend on our reading his face."

They requested the official committee membership register, the appointment letters, and the list of external advisers. They also asked the archive to search for any security-procedure correspondence issued during the relevant period. If Mensah had been consulted, the paper trail might identify who contacted him and what question he was asked.

At the same time, Badu arranged for an independent comparison between the personnel records and the committee's staff list. The comparison did not assume

that identical initials meant identical people. It sought full names, service numbers, appointment dates, and signatures. Until those fields aligned, the K. B. Mensah entry remained an unresolved identity question.

Mabel approached the matter differently. She had learned that the retired inspector had been interviewed, but she did not seek to publish his name. The fact that investigators had spoken to someone did not establish suspicion, much less guilt. She asked her editor whether a general report on the identity problem would serve readers better than a story built around a retired officer.

“Only if it explains why the distinction matters,” the editor said. “Otherwise we are just reporting that a man was questioned.”

Mabel drafted a short explanation of how initials on old administrative lists can create false connections when records are incomplete. She used no identifying details and did not suggest that the retired inspector was responsible for any wrongdoing. The editor asked for a second source before publication. Mabel decided the point could wait until it contributed to a verifiable account of the larger process.

Two days later, the archive replied to Badu’s request. It had found a security-procedure memorandum from the committee building, but the copy lacked its final

page. The visible section described how restricted rooms were to be opened after hours and who could authorise access. A reference number in the top corner did not match the numbering system used in the committee’s surviving index.

The memorandum carried no signature on the copy. A typed line identified the sender only as “Security Liaison.” It could have been an office title, a role, or a temporary designation. There was no basis for attributing it to Mensah.

Badu asked the archive to preserve the original folder and search the correspondence register for the memorandum’s reference number. He also asked whether the missing final page had been listed in any earlier inventory. The archive could not answer immediately. Its staff had to compare several finding aids created during different transfers.

Mensah later sent a short letter through his solicitor. He had searched his papers and found a pocket diary from the relevant year. One entry read: “Meeting—building security arrangements—ask for written scope.” The date was legible, but the person he was to meet was not named. The entry supported his recollection that he had been consulted about security arrangements. It did not prove that he had attended the committee, seen the restricted appendix, or handled the S-4 schedule.

Badu asked for the diary to be examined in place by an independent archivist and photographed with Mensah's consent. The solicitor agreed to arrange supervised access. The diary would not be seized or removed merely because it might be relevant. Its ownership and condition would be recorded, and any comparison would distinguish what the entry said from what investigators inferred.

The new detail altered one narrow part of the picture. Mensah's memory of a security consultation now had some contemporaneous support. It did not connect him to the missing fifth copy. It did not resolve the committee-list initials. It did not establish his whereabouts on the night of Agyeman's death.

Badu updated the evidence board. Under Mensah's name he wrote: "Identity confirmed; committee role not confirmed; security consultation partly corroborated; S-4 handling not established." It was less satisfying than a single answer, but it was more accurate.

That evening, Mabel received another anonymous message: "He kept the key because the others trusted him."

She preserved the message and sent it to her editor. The phrase could refer to a literal key, authority to

access a room, or something entirely unrelated. It named no person and offered no verifiable detail. Mabel did not forward it to former staff or ask the sender to explain. She logged it as a separate communication and notified the agreed liaison.

When Badu saw the message, he resisted the urge to connect it to the security memorandum. A missing final page and a vague reference to a key could belong to the same story, but they could also be deliberately placed beside one another to encourage an unsupported conclusion.

He instructed the team to establish what keys existed, which office maintained the key register, and whether access was recorded at all. The work would proceed from physical records and documented procedures, not from the anonymous message's implication.

Before the day ended, Badu reviewed the interview note with Mensah's solicitor. A correction was made to the description of the old memorandum, and the correction was initialled by both parties. Mensah had not withdrawn his denials, and the investigation had not confirmed them. The account was now clearer about its limits.

Lartey placed the updated identity comparison beside the committee list. "We've spent days proving what the entry does not prove."

“That is part of the job,” Badu said. “An innocent person can be pulled into a case by a shared name. If we don’t separate identity from implication, we can manufacture a suspect from a line of ink.”

The retired inspector remained a possible source of information about a security consultation, not an established participant in the record changes. The missing final page of the memorandum became the next document to locate. The key question remained open, as did the question of who had requested five copies.

Badu wrote a final instruction on the board: **Verify the key system independently. Do not infer custody from a message.**

The inspector had not solved the mystery. His silence had not proved guilt, and his denials had not ended the inquiry. What the interview provided was narrower and more useful: a boundary around what the investigators could honestly claim, and a paper trail they could now test.

The Prosecutor’s Questions

The prosecutor, Ama Nyarko, reviewed the case summary with a red pencil in hand. She had asked Badu to separate the evidence into three bundles: the murder, the records inquiry, and any material that

might connect the two. The third bundle was almost empty.

“That is not a criticism,” she said when she saw Badu glance at it. “An empty category is better than a false connection.”

They began with the duplicate key. Nyarko asked what the locksmith had actually established, whether the lock had been altered after the photograph, and whether the chain of custody was complete. Badu answered from the report, not from memory. Where the record did not supply an answer, he marked the question for follow-up.

Next she reviewed the witness accounts. One witness remembered a corridor; another remembered a delivery; neither could identify the packet. Nyarko asked whether their accounts had been influenced by the public discussion. Badu said the team had recorded the timing of each interview and would compare any later statements with earlier ones. He did not claim that memory contamination had or had not occurred without a basis.

When the temporary-hold circular came up, Nyarko turned to the records bundle. “What does this establish?”

“That an order with this wording circulated. The schedule it refers to is missing. We cannot yet establish which packet it covered.”

“Does it establish that someone deliberately removed a document?”

“No.”

“Does it establish a motive for the judge’s murder?”

“No.”

Nyarko set down the pencil. “Then those are the answers we must be prepared to give, even if they disappoint everyone.”

She asked Badu for a timeline that included contradictions and gaps, not only facts that supported the team’s working theories. She also wanted a list of records at risk under routine retention schedules, so the team could seek preservation orders where justified.

Before the meeting ended, she pointed to an anonymous message that had been included in the bundle. Its wording suggested that someone wanted investigators to connect the missing copy with the murder.

“Have we established who sent it?”

“No.”

“Have we established that the sender knows the evidence?”

“No. The sender may know something, may have read public reports, or may be guessing.”

Nyarko returned the page. “Keep it as a lead about communication. Do not let it become a witness.”

Badu left with a longer list of work and a clearer sense of what the team could responsibly say. The prosecutor had not solved anything. She had tested the boundaries of the case, and those boundaries were part of its integrity.

The Diary’s Missing Week

Badu’s team returned to the retired inspector’s diary with a narrow question: whether the blank week around the security consultation reflected a missing page or an ordinary gap in the inspector’s notes. The diary had been kept in a plastic sleeve by his solicitor, who insisted that the original remain in his presence while the team photographed it.

The binding showed no obvious tear where a page might have been removed. Several dates were skipped elsewhere in the diary, particularly during weeks when the inspector had been assigned to court duties. The gap was still notable because it fell near the period mentioned in the incomplete security memorandum, but a coincidence of dates did not establish a connection.

The inspector watched the photographs being taken. “I wrote notes for myself,” he said. “I did not write a daily record for an investigation that would happen twenty years later.”

Badu asked whether he remembered meeting anyone from the committee during that week. The inspector thought for a long time before saying he remembered a conversation about building access and the replacement of a door lock. He could not identify the room or say whether the discussion concerned the judge’s chambers. The recollection might have referred to a routine security matter elsewhere in the building.

“Did you prepare the memorandum?” Badu asked.

“I cannot say that I did. I may have been asked for an opinion. The copy you showed me has no signature, and I would not claim it as mine.”

His solicitor asked that the statement distinguish the diary entry from the memory. Badu agreed and arranged for the inspector to review the wording. The final statement recorded the dated note, the separate recollection, and the limits of each.

Later, an officer suggested that someone might have removed the missing week. Badu pointed to the other gaps. “We need a reason to distinguish this one from those. The date makes it worth asking about; it does not answer the question.”

The diary was returned under a receipt that listed the condition of the sleeve and the number of images made. The inspector signed the handover form and watched the evidence officer close the file. He looked tired rather than evasive. Badu left with a more

precise timeline and no new basis for naming the memorandum’s author.

The Missing Page’s Neighbours

The records specialist asked the team to stop referring to the missing leaf as though it had a known position in the original bundle. The surviving stubs established where a page was expected in the register, but not necessarily where it had sat in every later arrangement. A bundle could be reordered without changing its index, and an index could be copied from an earlier version after the papers had moved.

They examined the pages before and after the gap. One contained a short notation referring to an enclosure; the next began with a continuation mark, but the wording could refer to a different attachment. The team compared punctuation, spacing, and numbering with intact entries from the same period. The results supported more than one possible sequence.

Badu asked the specialist to create a diagram showing each plausible order, with the assumptions written beside it. The diagram looked untidy because no single arrangement accounted for every mark. That was precisely why it belonged in the case file. A neat diagram would have concealed the uncertainty that mattered most.

One of the junior investigators suggested searching for the missing page by its presumed title. Badu redirected

the search toward the reference number and the receiving office, explaining that a wrong title could lead staff to overlook a document filed under different wording. The team broadened the request without naming the fifth copy as a confirmed item.

By the end of the review, they understood the register's structure better but knew little more about the missing leaf's contents. Mabel struggled to explain that kind of progress to people who wanted a simple update. Badu reminded her that narrowing the possibilities was progress, even when the answer remained out of reach.

The Pages Around the Gap

The records team laid the neighbouring pages on a long table in the order indicated by the binding, then compared the sequence with an older index. The gap looked larger when the book was open than it had in the photocopy, but that visual impression could be misleading. A page might have been removed, never inserted, or lost during a repair. The binding showed wear in several places. The examiner asked the team not to infer a missing leaf from the space alone.

Each neighbouring entry was transcribed into a separate schedule, with the original spelling, punctuation, and abbreviations preserved. Where a word could not be read, the transcriber marked it uncertain instead of supplying a likely term. The work was slow. Mabel watched the staff debate a single

abbreviation for ten minutes, then realised the abbreviation might determine whether the entry belonged to a dispatch, a return, or a routine request for a copy.

Badu asked for a comparison with other books from the same office and period. The archive supplied two ledgers with similar binding and one with a different format. In the first, a loose page had been reattached during a later repair. In the second, the numbering skipped because the book had been divided between two desks. Neither example matched the disputed gap exactly. Both demonstrated that an irregular sequence could arise without deliberate removal.

The team then reviewed the daily count sheets. One count had been corrected in a different hand, but the correction carried an initial that had not yet been authenticated. The original count was not visible beneath the alteration. A specialist might be able to determine whether the writing had been added later, but could not necessarily establish why. Badu asked for the count sheet to be preserved as an independent exhibit rather than merged into the schedule comparison.

Mabel found a small discrepancy between the public catalogue and the internal index. The catalogue listed a bundle as returned; the index described it as pending. The dates were several weeks apart, and either description might have reflected a different stage of processing. She prepared a chronology that

included both records instead of choosing the one that supported the more dramatic story. The disagreement itself was now a question for the archive staff.

By day's end, the missing pages had context but no known history. Badu replaced "removed" in the draft summary with "absent from the surviving volume." The new phrase was less satisfying, but it described what they could see without inventing an action. Next they would search for an independent copy of the entries or a transfer record that might clarify the missing pages" contents.

The Space Between Two Pages

The records specialist brought a transparent overlay to the next review. It marked the surviving page numbers, the attachment references, and the places where the numbering system changed. When placed over the disputed bundle, the overlay showed that the apparent gap could fit more than one sequence. The missing page might have belonged to the enclosure list, or it might have been part of a later compilation. The diagram made the uncertainty visible instead of hiding it behind a single preferred reconstruction.

Badu asked the specialist to explain what evidence would narrow the possibilities. She named a matching reference in a receiving ledger, a dated copy in another department, or a contemporary

note that identified the attachment by description. A later recollection could help direct the search but would need corroboration. The team updated its requests accordingly, sending the reference number to offices that had not been asked to search under the disputed title.

One office returned a form with a similar number but a different suffix. A junior officer initially treated it as a match until the specialist pointed out that the suffix marked a separate series. The correction kept an unrelated record out of the evidentiary chain. Badu thanked the officer for catching the mistake and asked that the near-match remain in the file as an excluded possibility, with the reason documented.

Mabel noticed that the search was producing more negative results than dramatic discoveries. Badu reminded her that a documented exclusion could be valuable: it reduced the chance that a future investigator would repeat the same false lead. The gap between the pages still offered no answer. The team did, however, know which kinds of evidence might resolve it—and which records merely resembled the one they needed.

The Guard and the Driver

The vehicle-log follow-up led Badu to a former driver who remembered being redirected to the side entrance during a period of repairs. He could not

recall the date without seeing the log, and the log contained only the last digits of his registration. The driver said that he had carried sealed envelopes for several offices over the years, but he had never been told what they contained. He would not guess which delivery the investigators meant.

They compared his route description with the maintenance plan. It was compatible with the temporary entrance, but several vehicles had used the same route. The driver's account helped explain why the guard might have recorded a delay without recording the contents of the vehicle. It did not connect the driver to the envelope or establish that the disputed file had travelled by van.

Before the interview ended, Badu asked whether the driver had kept receipts or dispatch slips. The driver promised to look through a box of old work papers, but the team made no assumption that any would survive. The lead remained open with a clear next action and a clear limit: a route could be verified, but the contents of a delivery required separate evidence.

PART THREE — THE COST OF DISCLOSURE

CHAPTER ELEVEN — THE ANONYMOUS ROUTE

The first mistake would be to assume there was only one sender.

Mabel wrote that sentence at the top of her notebook before the morning editorial meeting. Messages had arrived by different routes: an envelope left at the newspaper office, a photograph sent from an unknown number, and a note delivered through a channel that could not be traced from the copy alone. Their wording sometimes seemed to speak to one another. Their timing invited the same conclusion. Neither was enough to establish common authorship.

Her editor, Adjoa Kusi, read the list. “What can we verify about each route?”

“Not much yet. We can establish when we received them, what device or envelope carried them, and who handled them after arrival. We cannot establish who created them.”

“Then that is the story of the evidence, not the story of a conspiracy.”

Mabel prepared a chronology that separated the communications into individual exhibits. The message about the woman outside Room Four was listed separately from the ledger photograph. The reference to a key was not linked to either. The school transfer

slip had its own entry because it had arrived in a physical envelope rather than by phone.

She recorded the limits of each item. The photograph showed part of a ledger, but its original page and source were unknown. The transfer slip was a photocopy; no one had established where it had been copied. The text messages carried timestamps on the receiving device. Those timestamps established when the device received them, not when they were created or who had sent them.

Adjoa asked Mabel to check the reception log and camera system before describing the physical envelope. The log showed that a receptionist had accepted it and placed it in the editor's in-tray. The camera covered the front desk, but a delivery trolley blocked part of the view for several seconds. The footage could help establish the sequence of events; it could not identify the sender with confidence.

"Do not enhance the image until a face appears," Adjoa warned. "We are not going to turn pixels into a witness."

Mabel requested a preserved copy of the original footage and documented who exported it. The original recording remained in the system under the newsroom's retention procedure. The receptionist said she had not recognised the person. She remembered a dark jacket and a paper envelope, details too ordinary to narrow the field meaningfully.

Badu's team opened a separate line of inquiry. The anonymous communications were relevant, but they had arrived through a journalist, raising different concerns from an exhibit found in a public archive. Badu did not demand Mabel's private notes or source list. Through the agreed liaison, he asked whether she could preserve the original messages and record the circumstances of receipt so that a later lawful request could be considered if necessary.

Mabel discussed the request with Adjoa and the newspaper's legal adviser. They agreed to preserve the messages and the devices on which they had arrived, but they would not volunteer confidential source material merely because investigators were interested. If a formal legal demand came, the newsroom would assess it through the proper process. Badu accepted that boundary and narrowed his request to non-confidential details already recorded in the newsroom's incident log.

That boundary was essential. A journalist could cooperate without becoming an unofficial extension of the police; source protection, in turn, did not make a message true. Each communication still required independent corroboration.

Lartey's team reviewed archive access records for the days before the first anonymous message. Several staff members had entered the records room, including a facilities worker who repaired a light and an archivist who moved a trolley of boxed files. The access log

recorded entry times but did not list the contents of every trolley. None of those entries established that a particular person had copied or removed the disputed schedule.

A second log, maintained by the building's security desk, used a different clock system. Its times differed from the archive log by several minutes. The security supervisor said the clocks were not synchronised automatically. Badu ordered the discrepancy recorded rather than "corrected" by choosing the time that best fit a theory. The two systems could help establish a broad sequence, but not a minute-by-minute reconstruction without further checks.

The team examined printer information on one anonymous photocopy. It showed faint vertical marks and a partial toner pattern. Dr. Addo, the document examiner, explained that these features might be consistent with a class of office printer, but they were not unique identifiers. Similar machines could produce similar marks, and later copying could obscure the original pattern.

"Can you tell us where it was printed?" Badu asked.

"Not from this copy," she said. "I can describe what is visible. I can't turn those marks into an address."

A staff member had mentioned that the committee's former administrative office used a printer with similar streaks. But the examiner could not connect the anonymous copy to that machine. Badu told the

team to keep the observation out of any public statement unless stronger evidence emerged.

Mabel's own inquiry led her to a courier counter near the commercial district. The envelope's adhesive and label suggested it might have passed through a retail mailing service, but the suggestion was weak. Many envelopes used the same stock, and the label had been removed before it reached the newsroom. She asked the business what records it retained for anonymous drop-offs. The clerk explained that ordinary counter sales did not always require identification, and that any available records would need to be preserved and requested through an appropriate process.

Mabel did not ask the clerk to speculate about customers. She recorded the business's retention policy and gave the information to her editor. It established that an anonymous route was possible; it did not establish that the envelope had come from that counter.

Later, a new message arrived on the unknown number that had sent the note about the woman waiting outside. It read: "You are checking the door. Check the person who was allowed through."

The message sounded as though it referred to access control. It did not name a person, date, or door. Mabel logged it as a new exhibit and did not reply. She wondered whether the sender knew the building or

had read the developing story and was trying to direct the investigation.

Badu received a summary through the liaison. He asked the team to review access procedures for the committee rooms, including visitor authorisations, after-hours entries, and records of keys issued to temporary staff. He did not ask them to search for a person who “was allowed through” until the wording could be tied to a verifiable event.

The key register, when located, was incomplete. One page had been replaced with a photocopy, and the copied page did not show the signatures in the margin clearly enough to identify them. The archive could not say when the photocopy had been inserted. The original page might have been damaged, misplaced, or copied for routine reasons. Its absence created a gap, not proof of tampering.

The security supervisor remembered that contractors sometimes signed for temporary access cards rather than keys. The forms for that period were stored separately. Badu requested them and asked that the search be documented, including any gaps in the record. The investigation could not safely treat the word “key” in an anonymous message as proof that a physical key had been involved.

Mabel returned to the newsroom footage. She watched the envelope delivery at normal speed, then frame by frame, without applying filters that might

manufacture details. The person's face remained partly obscured. The image showed that the envelope had been delivered by someone who approached the desk, placed it down, and left. It did not show where the person had come from or who had instructed them.

The receptionist's account remained consistent with the footage. She remembered the envelope being placed on the desk and the person leaving before she could ask a question. She could not identify the individual. Mabel documented the agreement between the account and the recording, as well as the limits of both.

Adjoa asked whether the newsroom should publish a short note saying investigators were examining anonymous communications.

"Not yet," Mabel said. "We would be reporting on our own evidence handling rather than adding anything the public can use. If a message makes a claim we can independently test, we can report the result. We should not make the sender the centre of the story just because the sender wants attention."

Her editor agreed. The newsroom would preserve the material, but would not publish the messages or imply they had revealed a suspect's identity. The unknown sender might be a genuine whistleblower, a frightened participant, someone repeating hearsay, or someone trying to mislead both journalist and police.

That evening, Badu laid the communications out in chronological order. The sequence was useful, but it was not a chain of custody for the documents" creation. He could trace how the items had reached Mabel and the investigators after receipt. He could not yet trace their origin.

He added a separate question to the board: "Who benefits if we believe these messages came from one person?"

It was not an accusation. A single sender could be trying to help, protect themselves, or manipulate the inquiry. Several senders could be acting independently. One person could have copied another's wording. The available evidence did not distinguish among those possibilities.

The next morning, the courier business confirmed it could not identify a sender from the information available. The newsroom's camera footage remained inconclusive. The archive logs documented access but not the contents of every movement. The printer marks could not identify a machine. The key register was incomplete. Each result narrowed a different question, but none supplied the answer the anonymous messages seemed to promise.

Badu met Mabel briefly through the established liaison. Neither showed the other confidential source notes. They compared only the verified chronology and questions that could be tested independently.

Mabel agreed to preserve the envelope and its outer wrapping. Badu agreed not to describe the newsroom as a source of police evidence beyond what the record supported.

“Someone wants us to follow a route,” Mabel said.

“Then we follow the evidence,” Badu replied. “If the route is real, it will survive verification.”

Before they separated, Mabel received one final message: “The person who carried it did not write it.”

For the first time, the sender’s claim did not simply point toward a room or a key. It offered an explanation for the anonymous route itself. But the statement could be true, false, or an attempt to prepare them for a future denial. There was no independent support for it.

Mabel logged the message. Badu added it to the list of unverified communications. Neither treated it as a confession or a reliable account.

The anonymous route had produced a clearer picture of what the investigators did not know. They had a record of receipt, a partial camera view, inconsistent administrative logs, and several messages whose authorship could not be established. They did not have a confirmed sender, a proven motive, or evidence that one person had supplied every clue.

Badu erased the word “sender” from the top of the board and replaced it with “senders?” The question mark stayed.

The case had not moved closer to a name. It had moved closer to a method: preserve each item, verify each claim separately, and refuse to let an anonymous voice choose the conclusion.

The Newsroom’s Receipt Log

Mabel asked her editor to approve a limited review of the newsroom’s incoming-mail log. She did not ask for the names of confidential sources, nor did she want the staff to open sealed correspondence unrelated to the investigation. The purpose was narrower: establish when each item had arrived, who had first handled it, and whether the newsroom had followed its own routine for preserving envelopes.

The log had been designed for parcels and official correspondence, not anonymous notes. Some entries recorded only a date; others included a time and the initials of the receptionist. A photograph had arrived by email, while another message had been forwarded from a personal device. The routes were different, and the log could not be treated as a single chain connecting them.

The receptionist remembered one envelope because it had been placed beneath a newspaper rather than handed across the counter. She could not recall the person who left it. The camera at the entrance showed

a busy stretch of pavement, but the angle did not capture the envelope's placement clearly. The footage was not good enough to identify a face.

Mabel asked the editor whether the newspaper could publish the log's limitations alongside the findings. He worried that the explanation would sound weak. "Readers want to know who is sending these messages," he said.

"Then we must tell them what we can and cannot establish," Mabel replied. "If we make three routes look like one because that makes a cleaner story, we become part of the confusion."

They agreed to publish only the fact that the newsroom had received communications by more than one route, with no claim that they shared an author. The editor also authorised a preservation notice for the original envelopes and digital files. Mabel recorded the time of the notice and the names of the staff who carried it out.

When she left the newsroom, a text arrived from an unlisted number containing a single sentence: "You are keeping the wrong record." She did not answer. She saved the message, documented its arrival, and told Badu through the agreed liaison.

The sentence might have referred to the newsroom log, the archive register, or nothing specific at all. Mabel refused to let its confidence become evidence.

The Unrecorded Interval

The interval between the first receipt and the later register entry lasted less than an hour on paper and much longer in Badu’s mind. He laid the known times on a whiteboard, leaving blank space where the records did not speak. The blank was not evidence of a secret meeting. It was a reminder that the sequence remained incomplete.

A messenger’s route sheet placed him at another office during part of the interval, but the sheet had been completed at the end of his shift. A telephone log showed a call to the registry switchboard, but no surviving note explained the subject. A staff rota established who was on duty, not who handled a particular packet.

Badu asked a junior investigator to create two timelines: one containing confirmed events, the other containing possible explanations. The second timeline was not to be shown to witnesses as if it were a fact. The investigator found the instruction odd until Badu explained how easily a suggested sequence could become a borrowed memory.

By evening, the board looked less like a solution than a map of the investigation’s limits. That was progress. The team now knew precisely which gap needed evidence and which gaps were only the result of records that had never been designed to answer the questions being asked of them.

The Fourth Return's Carbon

The carbon slip was examined under several kinds of light, then photographed at a scale that made its fibres appear like a landscape. The specialist could distinguish pressure marks from stains in some areas, but the signature remained too faint for reliable attribution.

Badu asked whether the paper could identify the office that had produced it. The specialist explained that the stock was common and had been used by several departments. A torn edge might be compared with another sheet if a matching fragment existed, but no such fragment had been found.

They compared the slip with blank forms from the same general period. The layout resembled a return acknowledgement, although the package description was incomplete. The word “return” described a process, not the contents of the packet. It could not establish that a fifth copy had travelled through the system.

In his notebook, Badu concluded that the slip was consistent with an administrative return, though its exact function and destination remained unresolved. He knew how easily a suggestive title could make a small piece of paper seem more conclusive than it was.

The Guard's Shift

The security guard returned with his written account and a copy of the maintenance entry for the newsroom

window. He had initially described the latch as open. After checking the contractor’s note, he clarified that the latch had been loose before and might not have held fully shut. He had not seen anyone at the window and had not heard a noise during his rounds.

Mabel asked whether he had checked the window on the previous shift. He said the log recorded the courtyard round but did not specifically mention the latch. That omission meant the team could not establish when the window had shifted. The guard agreed to add a note to the log for future rounds, while leaving the earlier record unchanged.

The editor was still concerned about access to the newsroom. He asked that the case papers be stored in a locked cabinet and that staff use a sign-out sheet. Mabel accepted the measure but asked that it apply to all sensitive reporting files, not only this case. If the rule looked like a reaction to an unknown intruder, it could fuel speculation and invite staff to interpret every small problem as part of the investigation.

Later, a reporter joked that the anonymous sender had become a member of the newsroom. Mabel told him not to include the joke in any story. There was no evidence that the sender had entered the building, and humour could become a rumour once repeated. She checked the cabinet, recorded the access, and returned to her notes. The window remained an unresolved maintenance issue alongside a legitimate security concern. Neither interpretation cancelled the other.

Mabel and the Night Editor

The newsroom was nearly empty when Mabel spread the messages across the conference table. She had printed each one separately, with the date and method of receipt written on a cover sheet. The night editor, Kojo Armah, came in carrying two cups of tea and looked at the pages without touching them.

“You think they’re connected,” he said.

“I think someone wants us to think they’re connected. That’s different.”

“And you think one of them may be genuine.”

“A message can contain a genuine detail and still mislead us about everything around it.”

Armah placed a cup beside her. “The paper will want a story by Friday. The public has heard about the judge’s death, the archive, and the old committee. They will join the dots whether we do or not.”

“Then we need to show which dots are actually on the page.”

He pulled out a chair. Together, they reviewed what could be published: investigators were examining archival inconsistencies; no document then available established a single author for the messages; the newsroom would not identify a confidential source; and the existence of a numbered copy did not, by itself, prove what it contained or who had handled it.

“That is not much of a headline,” Armah said.

“It is a fair one.”

“Fair stories can still be dangerous.”

Mabel knew he was not talking only about defamation. A story could direct strangers to a clerk’s house, invite a witness to destroy a paper, or persuade a frightened person that silence was the only safe choice. She had once believed publication was a clean act: the truth went out, and the people who needed it could decide what to do. Now she understood that the route from a fact to its consequences was rarely clean.

They agreed to hold the draft until Badu confirmed what could be stated about the inquiry without compromising evidence. Armah asked her to keep a separate record of every message and not to annotate the originals.

“You’re treating the messages like evidence,” he said.

“I’m treating them like things we received. Whether they become evidence is not my decision.”

After he left, Mabel locked the prints in the newsroom cabinet and kept only her working notes. She did not feel safer. She felt, instead, that she had chosen one responsibility over another and would have to live with the space between them.

The Witness Who Wanted a Promise

The witness arrived fifteen minutes early and asked to speak to Badu without the rest of the team present. Her name was Abena Lartey, and she had worked as a

temporary receptionist in the building where several of the disputed records had passed through. She had already given a short statement about routine deliveries, but the new call suggested she remembered something else.

Badu met her in an interview room with the door open until she agreed to close it. He explained the purpose of the meeting, the recording procedure, and her right to pause or seek advice. Abena listened carefully, then asked whether he could promise that her name would never appear in court.

“I cannot promise that,” he said. “I can explain the protections available and make sure any request for confidentiality is considered properly. But I will not mislead you about what the law or the case may require.”

She looked at the table. “Then I don’t know if I can help.”

“You do not have to answer anything you are not ready to answer. You can take advice before deciding.”

That response seemed to unsettle her more than a demand would have. She had come prepared to bargain, and Badu had refused to trade a false promise for information.

After a short break, Abena agreed to describe what she remembered without naming anyone she could not identify. She recalled a busy afternoon when a staff member brought a packet to the reception desk and

asked whether a particular office was still accepting deliveries. She remembered a disagreement over whether the packet should be entered under a temporary location or sent back to the registry. She did not recall seeing the packet’s contents.

“Was it the packet we are investigating?” Badu asked.

“I can’t say. I remember a brown wrapping, but lots of packets were brown.”

“Do you remember the date?”

“Not exactly. It was around the time the office was changing its room numbers.”

Badu showed her a calendar of the relevant period, without suggesting a date. She pointed to a week, then withdrew her finger. “Maybe that week. I’m not sure.”

The statement was less precise than she had hoped it would be. She became frustrated and said she had delayed coming forward because she believed the memory would return more clearly once she began talking. Badu explained that memory could be incomplete even when a person was sincere. The team would record what she recalled and the conditions under which she recalled it, then compare it with records that existed independently.

Before leaving, Abena asked whether the former officials would know she had spoken to them. Badu told her he could not control every future disclosure, but he would handle the statement according to the

applicable procedures and avoid unnecessary circulation. He gave her the contact details for the case liaison and reminded her not to discuss the interview with other potential witnesses if she wanted her recollection to remain independent.

Mabel, who had waited outside, asked whether Abena had brought them closer to identifying the packet.

“She has described a routine event that may or may not be relevant,” Badu said. “If the reception log confirms a delivery in that period, we can narrow it. If it does not, we will record that too.”

“Do you believe her?”

“I believe she has given us an account. Whether each part is accurate is a different question.”

They requested the surviving reception logs and the room-number change circular. Abena’s memory would be tested against those records, not against the team’s desire for a breakthrough. Her fear was real; the event she remembered remained uncertain. Both facts deserved to be handled with care.

The Guard’s Personal Shift Notes

Former security attendant Addo arrived with a small notebook in a plastic sleeve. He explained that it was his own record of reminders, not the official shift book, which he had often found difficult to read. He used it to note equipment faults and other details he wanted to follow up. He did not claim it was complete.

Badu asked when he had started it, whether he had kept it continuously, and whether anyone else had written in it. Addo answered each question before the team examined the relevant page.

The entry for the disputed period mentioned a maintenance call and a visitor whose name had not been written in full. The time was rounded to the nearest quarter-hour. Addo could not remember the visitor's face and would not guess whether the person had carried a packet. He recalled that a corridor light had been unreliable, but the note did not identify the exact location. The information raised a question about building routines; it did not identify anyone.

An officer asked whether Addo had ever let someone through a door without signing them in. Addo said that a staff member with an authorised pass might enter through a side door when the main entrance was closed, but the procedure required the pass to be checked. He could not say whether the procedure had been followed on the night in question. Badu stopped the questioning when it began to imply that Addo had witnessed a particular person. The witness had described a system, not a suspect.

A note in Addo's notebook had no obvious counterpart in the official shift book, but the date was not precise enough to establish that both records referred to the same shift. Addo said he sometimes wrote reminders before completing the formal entry. The discrepancy might reflect an incomplete record, a date error, or an

event from another day. Badu requested a forensic comparison of the ink only if it could answer a defined question.

After the interview, Addo asked whether he was now part of the murder case. Badu told him that his account had been recorded because it might help establish the building's routines. It did not make him a suspect or prove that he had seen the killer. Addo seemed to relax, though he remained concerned that his old notebook might be misunderstood. He asked for a copy of his statement and received one after checking the corrections.

Mabel later wrote that the comparison between Addo's personal notes and the official shift book reflected the wider investigation: both could be useful, incomplete, and vulnerable to confident interpretation. She deleted the sentence from her article because it sounded like a conclusion. In her private notes, she kept it as a reminder. Addo's account would remain in the file with its limits attached, ready to be compared if another record supplied a more precise time or location.

The Guard's Separate Pocket Notebook

At a later meeting, Addo produced a second item: a separate pocket notebook he had not mentioned in his first statement. It contained shift reminders, phone numbers, and brief notes about maintenance requests. He said he had not thought it relevant because he used

it for personal reminders rather than official entries. Badu asked him to leave it closed while they agreed on the scope of the review, then recorded Addo's consent to inspect only the pages covering the relevant period.

The second notebook included a note about a delivery van waiting at the wrong entrance. The date was close to the repair period, but the year appeared only once at the top of the page. Addo remembered the driver complaining about the route, though he could not recall the company or what the vehicle carried. The official vehicle log contained a similar entry, but the registration number was incomplete in both records.

Mabel asked whether the note might relate to the envelope. Addo said he did not know and had no reason to connect the van with the case before investigators asked. Badu treated the note as a possible lead, not proof of a delivery. He requested the original vehicle log and asked the team to check whether the van had served other offices that day.

Addo seemed disappointed that the second notebook had not produced a name. Badu told him that a contemporaneous note could be useful even when incomplete, provided they did not force it to answer a question it had never recorded. The notebook was copied under supervision and returned to its owner. The van became one more route to check, not a shortcut to a conclusion.

CHAPTER TWELVE — THE UNRECORDED INTERVAL

The newsroom's receipt review did not identify a sender. It established something narrower: the messages had reached Mabel by separate routes, at different times, and with different levels of documentation. Badu asked her to bring the non-confidential timeline to the station so the team could compare it with the archive's recorded movements without exposing protected sources.

In a small interview room, Mabel laid out a timeline with three columns: what had arrived, what had been preserved, and what could be checked independently. The earliest item had a date but no reliable time. The photograph carried a digital timestamp, though its original device and transmission history were unknown. The envelope had a receipt entry with a correction that still needed examination.

"If the same person sent all three, the routes suggest planning," Badu said. "If different people sent them, the differences may mean very little."

"And if one person copied the habits of another?" Mabel asked. "The appearance of a pattern might be deliberate."

Neither possibility could be tested from the messages alone. They agreed to treat the timeline as a record of

receipt, not a map of authorship. Mabel left her confidential source out of the document, noting only that one item had arrived through a protected channel.

A call from the records office interrupted them. A clerk had located a daily movement sheet from the week of the first message. It showed a routine transfer to a temporary desk, but the relevant line was partly obscured by a fold. The sheet did not mention the anonymous message and could not be linked to it without further evidence.

Badu asked the clerk to preserve the sheet and send a certified copy through the case system. He did not ask whether the transfer was suspicious. He asked what the sheet recorded, who had signed it, and whether the original remained available.

When the call ended, Mabel looked at the timeline. “Everything is near something else,” she said. “A date near a transfer, a name near a committee, a number near a return.”

“Near is not the same as connected,” Badu replied. “Our job is to find the bridge, if one exists.”

The meeting ended with checks to make, not a theory to defend. For the first time, Mabel felt the separate strands could be examined side by side without being tied together prematurely. The interval between one record and the next was not necessarily empty; its meaning simply remained unknown.

The Roster

The duty roster for the repair period was found in a payroll folder rather than the registry archive. Its entries listed staff by initials, and one initials pair matched a name on the transfer sheet. The match was promising but not conclusive: several employees shared initials, and the roster did not state which room each person had worked in during every hour of the shift.

Badu asked payroll to confirm the full names through the underlying staff records. The request took two days because the older folder had been moved to a separate storage unit. When the confirmation arrived, one person on the roster had left the service years earlier and another had died. The team would have to seek surviving colleagues or family-held work papers to fill in the gaps, without assuming that a relative could speak for a deceased employee’s actions.

The roster also showed that one afternoon shift had been extended because of a power interruption. That detail explained why the repair work had run later than the initial schedule, but it did not establish that a document moved during the extra hours. Badu asked the team to locate the power report and compare it with the contractor’s delivery sheet.

The new records narrowed the interval but did not explain what had happened within it. Someone had been present; a room had been used; boxes had been

delivered. None of those facts identified the missing schedule. Badu placed the roster beside the other documents and wrote a question in the margin: what contemporaneous record, if any, described the tray's contents?

The Interval Between Entries

The team arranged the known records chronologically, leaving gaps wherever the time or sequence could not be established. At first, the blanks looked like failures. Then Badu asked the investigators to define what each source actually measured. The delivery book recorded receipt, the access log recorded entry, the maintenance book recorded a reported fault, and the statements recorded recollections. They were not interchangeable clocks. Any discrepancy had to be understood in light of each record's purpose before it could be reconciled.

Kofi drew a timeline on the whiteboard and used separate symbols for confirmed times, approximate times, and dates supplied retrospectively. The interval between the registry transfer and the next surviving entry remained wide. It could contain an ordinary delay, an unrecorded movement, or a recordkeeping failure. None of those explanations could be selected by the size of the gap. The team needed a source that described what happened inside it.

Mabel asked whether the timeline could be published. Badu warned that a simplified version might imply a precision the records did not support. She noted that

the public had already heard claims that a packet was removed at a specific time. They agreed that any account must state plainly that the available evidence could not establish a minute-by-minute sequence. The message would be difficult to communicate: uncertainty often sounded like incompetence, even when it was the most accurate conclusion.

Daniel reviewed the timeline with his adviser. He recognised one date as the week his family had moved houses, but he could not say whether the envelope had travelled with them. He added the move to his own chronology and marked the source of the memory. The date might help locate family papers, but it could not establish the identity of the document. Badu accepted the information as a lead and asked Daniel not to alter any original papers if he found them.

The team also considered the possibility that two apparently connected events had occurred independently. The judge’s death and the irregular records both involved a period of institutional pressure, but shared timing did not prove a shared cause. The prosecutor had warned them against allowing a compelling story to substitute for a tested link. Badu divided the timeline into two tracks, with a third column for any fact that might legitimately connect them. At present, that column contained questions rather than conclusions.

By evening, the whiteboard looked less like a route to a solution than a record of the work still required. Badu

left the gaps visible. He would not let the team fill them with assumptions merely because an empty line was uncomfortable. Any new discovery would have to earn its place on the timeline. Until then, the interval remained unrecorded and unexplained.

The Roster Correction

The payroll officer called after finding a photocopy of the duty roster filed upside down in a folder from another month. The original was intact, but the copy placed one employee's initials beside the wrong date. Two sheets had been copied together; the lower page had been turned before the stack was separated. It was an ordinary clerical error, but one capable of sending the investigation in the wrong direction if left uncorrected.

Badu asked the officer to document the correction and retain both versions. The original roster and the misfiled copy were assigned separate exhibit references so no one would later mistake the copy for an independent record. The officer signed a note describing the discovery and the method used to identify the mismatch. The correction changed the timeline for one employee, but it did not establish that the employee had handled the disputed bundle.

The team revisited the interviews that had relied on the earlier copy. One witness had said the employee was probably on duty; another had merely repeated

the roster. Badu marked the first statement for a clarification interview and left the second unchanged, since it accurately reflected what the witness had been shown at the time. He refused to treat the mistake as misconduct without evidence that anyone had known about it.

The corrected roster made the timeline less tidy but more reliable. Mabel wrote that the case was narrowing through corrections as well as discoveries. The investigation was not a contest to collect suspicious names; it was an effort to establish what had happened, even when progress meant ruling out a possibility.

CHAPTER THIRTEEN — THE FOURTH RETURN

The fourth return appeared in a box that had already been checked twice.

The discovery was quiet. There was no hidden compartment, no confession, no cabinet opened by a conveniently timed key. The document was a thin carbon copy, folded down the centre and filed between two routine acknowledgement slips in the retention archive. Its edges had yellowed, and a pale mark at the top suggested a former staple. In the lower corner, someone had written a reference number that differed from the number on the folder.

Badu was careful not to call it the missing copy. In an old index, the archive clerk had written “fourth return,” but the entry did not say what had been returned, who returned it, or whether the number referred to a document, a transaction, or a stage in a process. The phrase seemed relevant, but it was not an answer merely because it fit the mystery.

“Where was this when we searched the box?” he asked.

The clerk, Mr. Lartey, looked at the shelf list. “The box was catalogued under general committee correspondence. The retention slips were filed

separately. We searched the box for the attachment, not the acknowledgement slips."

"Who separated them?"

"I cannot tell you. The arrangement predates the current register."

"Then record that as unknown."

Lartey nodded. He was a careful man, and Badu had no reason to turn a gap in the archive into an accusation against the person who happened to be standing beside it. They photographed the copy where it lay, recorded its position, and documented each transfer. The archive's custodian signed the movement sheet before Badu's team placed the paper in a protective sleeve.

The document itself was unremarkable. It acknowledged receipt of an item associated with the committee's review of the Haven House records. The description was incomplete. A line after the word "attachment" had been left blank, and the final digits of the reference number were blurred. A signature occupied the bottom right corner, but the carbon impression was too faint to identify the writer confidently.

At the top, beside the date, stood the words: FOURTH RETURN.

Badu studied the phrase. It might describe a fourth attempt to return a file, the fourth copy of a form, or a

label added later by someone familiar with the system. The paper supplied no explanation.

“Can we compare the number with the main register?” he asked.

Lartey brought the register from a locked cabinet. Its pages had been repaired at the binding, and several entries were faint where the ink had transferred to the facing page. The reference on the carbon copy matched the first part of an entry from the same general period, but the final digits remained uncertain. The register listed a return from a committee office. It did not identify the contents of the returned package.

“Does this prove that a fourth copy existed?” the assistant asked.

“It proves that a record bearing this label exists,” Badu said. “It may support the possibility of a fourth return. It does not establish what was inside the package or whether the label refers to a copy.”

The assistant looked disappointed. Badu understood why. For weeks, they had followed references that seemed to point towards a single missing object, and each new paper raised hope that the next would finally define it. But records were created for practical purposes; their later significance was rarely as neat as investigators wanted.

They sent a request for a document examiner to assess the writing, the carbon impression, and the relationship between the paper and the other forms in

the retention series. The request did not ask the examiner to identify a person from a faint signature. It asked what could reliably be said about the document's physical features and whether the writing appeared contemporaneous with the form. Any conclusion would need to state its limits.

Meanwhile, Badu asked for the archive's transfer logs. If the acknowledgement slip had been separated from its original folder, the movement history might explain when and why. The logs were incomplete, but they showed that a batch of committee correspondence had been moved during a reorganisation several years after the original inquiry. The list recorded box numbers, not individual sheets. It could explain how the paper came to rest among the slips. It could not show who had placed it there.

He wrote that distinction into the case note.

At the newsroom, Mabel received a different fragment of the same history. An old clerk, contacted through a former colleague, remembered that committee staff had sometimes made several carbon copies of outgoing correspondence. One copy went to the recipient, another stayed with the department, and a further copy could be attached to a movement slip. The clerk could not remember the specific Haven House file and had no surviving notebook to consult.

Mabel asked whether the clerk remembered a fifth copy.

“I remember making extra copies when a supervisor asked for them,” the clerk said. “I don’t remember a rule that every document had five copies.”

“Could there have been five in this case?”

“There could have been. There could also have been two, three, or none beyond the usual set. I would be guessing.”

Mabel did not write that five copies had been made. She recorded that the former clerk remembered variable copying practices but could not confirm how many copies had been produced for this file. It made the article less sensational—and more accurate.

When she asked whether the clerk could identify who had ordered the copies, the answer was equally cautious. Requests had come through supervisors and secretaries. Sometimes a document was copied because a meeting was expected; sometimes because an office wanted a record of what had been sent. Years later, the reason for a particular request had faded from memory.

The interview gave Mabel a new direction, not a conclusion. She requested access to surviving office procedures and sought independent confirmation of the former clerk’s employment period. She also sent Badu a note describing the general practice, without implying that it established what had happened to the disputed records.

Badu read her note that evening. Their inquiries were approaching the same question from different directions without pretending to rely on the same evidence. His team had a physical acknowledgement slip; Mabel had a general account of copying practices. Neither could identify the package's contents, who had handled it, or how many copies had been made.

The next morning, the document examiner's preliminary response arrived. The paper was consistent with the kind used for other forms in the archive, but that feature was common and did not establish a shared source. The carbon impression had deteriorated. The signature could not be attributed from the material supplied. The examiner could not determine whether the words FOURTH RETURN had been written when the form was first completed or added later.

Badu placed the response beside the copy. It narrowed a few possibilities but left the central questions open.

He returned to the retention register and studied the sequence of entries. One return had a complete reference. Another had a reference ending in a different digit. A third was marked as cancelled, though the cancellation did not say whether the item itself had been cancelled or merely the entry. The fourth return appeared in the carbon copy, but its relationship to the other entries was not certain.

The fifth copy might be a physical document. It might be a duplicate of a record already located. It might be a label used by someone who had been tracking a different process altogether. The number could be meaningful, or it could be an accident of filing. Nothing yet justified choosing one interpretation.

A message arrived on Badu’s secure line from the archive custodian. Someone had called asking whether the retention box had been reopened and whether the fourth return had been found. The custodian had refused to discuss the investigation and recorded the call according to procedure. The caller gave no name.

Badu did not assume that the caller was the anonymous sender. The caller might have been connected to the committee, the archive, the press, or none of them. Knowledge that a box had been reopened was not proof of access to the disputed records; the archive’s movements were not entirely secret, and several staff members knew the inquiry was active.

Still, the timing mattered enough to document. He asked the custodian to preserve any call record and to notify the inquiry of further contact. He did not ask staff to speculate about who might have called.

That afternoon, Badu convened a short meeting with his team. He placed the carbon copy on the

screen and outlined what it established, what it suggested, and what remained unknown.

“We have an acknowledgement with an incomplete description,” he said. “We have a register entry that may correspond to it. We have evidence that copying practices varied. We have no verified inventory of the package’s contents, no reliable identification of the signature, and no proof that this is the fifth copy.”

One investigator asked whether they should now search for a fifth return rather than a fifth copy.

“We should search the records using the language they actually contain,” Badu replied. “We should not let our working title become an instruction to the evidence.”

He assigned the team to compare the surviving retention series with the transfer logs, request any duplicate indexes held by the former committee secretariat, and trace the carbon copy’s provenance as far as possible. Every result would be logged with its source and limitations. If the search found no further record, the report would say so—not claim that someone had stolen it.

After the meeting, Badu stayed behind. The phrase FOURTH RETURN remained visible on the screen. It was an ordinary label, written by an unknown hand for a purpose that might once have been obvious. Years later, it had become a doorway into a mystery. But the doorway did not tell him what lay beyond it.

He saved the image under the archive reference, then added a separate note to the evidence board: “Fourth return located. Contents and numbering significance unresolved.”

Beneath it, he retained the two questions that had shaped the inquiry from the beginning: who had been allowed to handle the records, and what had the official account left out?

The carbon copy did not answer either question. It did something more modest and, for now, more valuable. It gave them another authentic piece of the archive without pretending that the piece explained the whole.

Before leaving, Badu checked the sealed sleeve and the custody log once more. The copy had been found in a place that earlier searches had not covered. That was a reason to widen the search, not to declare victory.

On his desk, the case file remained open. The fourth return had returned nothing certain except the need to keep looking.

The Fourth Return Revisited

After the interview with Ofori, Badu asked the team to revisit the fourth return without treating the new account as confirmation. The term had appeared in a handwritten note, but its meaning was not fixed. It could refer to a fourth attempt to return a packet, a fourth copy of a form, or a return entry in a sequence whose beginning had been lost.

The registry supervisor brought the surviving return slips into the review room. They were arranged by date, not by subject, and several carried reference numbers that had been rewritten. The team photographed each slip and made a comparison table. They did not place slips side by side as if similar handwriting automatically meant the same author.

One slip showed a packet received back from a temporary desk. The destination column was blank. A second slip, dated later, recorded a return to the central registry but gave no enclosure count. Neither could be matched conclusively to the disputed reference.

“Could these be the fourth return?” Mabel asked.

“They could be examples of returns,” Badu said. “We cannot say they are the return until the identifiers match.”

The records officer noticed that the ink on one slip had bled through to the reverse. Under angled light, the reverse showed pressure marks, but not enough to

reconstruct a missing entry. The team photographed the marks and sent the image for assessment. They did not write a speculative reading on the evidence label.

During the review, one investigator suggested that the repeated number five must refer to a person because Daniel's history included conflicting names. Badu stopped the discussion. The number could refer to a person, a copy, an enclosure, a desk, or a count in a procedure. The case contained several uses of numbers, and their similarity did not make them identical.

They agreed on three independent searches: the original return-slip sequence, the destination code's history, and the document retention rules for temporary returns. Each search had a named officer and a deadline. If no matching record survived, the final report would say so.

Mabel studied the slips in their protective sleeves. The papers had survived; the context that once made them ordinary had not. The task was to restore that context without inventing it—a harder undertaking than finding a villain, and perhaps a more important one.

Ofori's Public Calendar

The team reconstructed Yaw Ofori's public calendar from meeting notices, travel claims and invitations retained by different offices. The records overlapped, but not perfectly. Several dates were supported by two

sources; others appeared only in a draft diary whose author had not been established.

One meeting had been moved at short notice. Another had ended earlier than scheduled. Neither fact was unusual in itself. Badu asked the team to avoid writing “Ofori was present” where the document showed only that he had been invited or expected.

A former assistant confirmed that Ofori sometimes delegated meetings and sometimes arrived without appearing on the printed agenda. The assistant could not remember the specific day under review. Her statement was recorded as context, not an alibi or an accusation.

The calendar helped the investigators identify people who might have seen Ofori during the relevant period. It did not place him at the scene of the murder. Badu approved a fresh list of interview requests and insisted that each be framed around what the witness had personally observed.

The Language of Returns

Mabel interviewed a former administrative translator who had reviewed correspondence from the relevant period. He warned that the phrase “return for correction” could describe either a physical file being sent back or a request being returned to a clerk because it lacked a required detail. The distinction was easy to miss when a later index shortened the phrase to “return”.

They reviewed three sample forms from unrelated files. In each, the full wording made the destination clear. In the disputed reference, the phrase had been abbreviated, and the space where a destination would normally appear was blank. The translator could explain the office’s conventions but could not supply the missing information.

Badu asked whether the abbreviation might have been made by a clerk who expected the destination to be obvious. The translator said that was possible, particularly in a small unit where staff knew one another’s habits. It was equally possible that the short entry had been copied from a summary. Without a dated original, neither explanation could be preferred.

Mabel revised the working diagram, separating the wording on the surviving reference from the fuller phrases in the examples. She sent the translator’s report to the team and stressed that it described administrative usage, not the history of the disputed file. The fourth return remained a useful lead because it pointed towards a process and possible offices. It did not prove that the fifth copy had passed through them.

The Carbon Paper Test

The fourth return was examined again under magnification after the document specialist noticed that the pressure marks did not match the visible writing on the front. The team brought in a second examiner to check whether the marks could have been

produced by a sheet beneath the carbon copy or by pressure from a document stored on top of it.

The second examiner asked for the paper to be left untouched until she had photographed both sides under ordinary and angled light. She found several impressions, but none formed a complete sentence. One line might have contained a reference number; another could have been the lower edge of a table. The specialists disagreed about one digit, and both recorded their readings separately.

“Can the marks tell us what document was above this one?” Mabel asked.

“Not from what survives,” the examiner replied. “They can tell us that pressure was applied. They cannot reliably identify the page that caused it.”

Badu asked whether the carbon copy had been folded before or after the impressions were made. The examiner said the fold crossed one of the marks, but the sequence was not clear enough to establish when the fold occurred. A storage crease, routine handling, or later filing could account for it.

The team arranged for the original to be returned to secure storage and retained the images for comparison. Badu refused a suggestion that they circulate a cropped image of the most suggestive fragment to witnesses. A fragment shown without context could influence a witness’s memory and make a later identification less reliable.

That afternoon, Mabel drafted an internal note on the document’s significance and its limits. She described the fourth return as evidence of a recordkeeping event whose object remained uncertain. Before saving, she deleted the phrase “the missing fifth copy.”

The change did not diminish the discovery. It kept the claim honest.

Reconstructing the Fourth Return

At the next review, Badu asked the team to revisit the fourth return without reading the earlier summary first. Each investigator wrote down what the document showed, what they believed it might mean, and what information would disprove their interpretation. The exercise irritated two officers who thought the file had already been examined enough. Badu reminded them that repetition was useful only if it tested a conclusion rather than strengthened familiarity with it.

The return form listed a packet, a reference code, and a destination that had been corrected in pencil. The correction could have been made by the original clerk, a receiving officer, or someone reconciling the books later. The paper did not identify the writer. A second record used a similar code, but the date differed. The team needed the codebook that governed both entries before they could say whether the similarity mattered.

Kwarteng found an old circular describing how return numbers were assigned when an item crossed between departments. The circular had been replaced

several years later, and the replacement used a different format. The disputed entry fell close to the transition. A number that looked unique under the newer system might have been routine under the old one. Badu requested a full copy of the circular and its distribution list, including any amendments that might have accompanied it.

Mabel interviewed a former records supervisor who remembered the transition as confusing. Staff had been told to use the new code for new files while completing older work under the previous format. The supervisor could not recall the fourth return or the fifth copy. She did remember that corrections were sometimes made in pencil before the final register was typed. Her account supplied context but did not identify the author of the disputed correction.

The team tested the new explanation against unrelated returns from the same month. Several contained similar pencil corrections, including entries that had no connection to the committee or the judge. The pattern weakened the claim that the correction itself was suspicious. It did not establish that the disputed return was legitimate. The team now had to focus on its destination and the records expected at the receiving end.

Before the meeting ended, Badu asked each investigator to state the strongest alternative to their preferred theory. The room’s tone shifted. The officer who suspected deliberate removal conceded that a

delayed transfer could produce the same gap. The officer who favoured clerical error admitted that the attachment might still have been withheld deliberately. The case had not grown simpler, but the team was less likely to confuse a favoured explanation with a proven one.

A Translator’s Test

The former translator returned with a set of examples showing how abbreviations had changed across departmental forms. He had prepared them from unrelated files, removing names and personal details so the comparison would focus on language rather than people. The same short phrase appeared in three contexts: a file physically sent back, a request returned unanswered, and a draft returned for correction. The words alone did not tell the reader which action had occurred.

Mabel asked the translator to read the disputed phrase without seeing the surrounding page. He offered a cautious interpretation, then revised it after reading the line above. The change did not make his first reading careless; it showed how context could alter the meaning of compressed notation. Badu asked that both readings be preserved, along with the reasons the second seemed possible rather than certain.

The translator pointed to a blank destination field. In a complete form, the destination often resolved the ambiguity. In the disputed reference, the field was empty, perhaps because the clerk had intended to complete it later, perhaps because the copy had not preserved the whole entry. He could not distinguish between those explanations from the page alone. Mabel added a request for any related dispatch copy that might contain the missing field.

Before leaving, the translator asked whether his report would be quoted as proof that the record had been altered. Badu said it would not. The report addressed language and form, not authorship or motive. The translator read and signed the final wording. His analysis sharpened their interpretation while confirming that the document could not carry the case by itself.

CHAPTER FOURTEEN — OFORI'S SHADOW

The first thing Badu learned about Yaw Ofori was that people rarely described him directly. They described the room after he had left it.

A clerk remembered that a meeting had ended early. A former committee member remembered being told that a matter was already settled. A records assistant recalled an instruction delivered in a voice so calm that she had not understood it as an instruction until someone later asked why she had obeyed it. None of them accused Ofori of anything. Each spoke around him, as if naming the man would make the rest of the sentence dangerous.

Badu arranged the accounts on his desk but kept them separate. Ofori had wielded influence around the committee, but influence alone proved no particular act. His name appeared in correspondence, recollections and the margins of old administrative papers. The same name had also appeared in the investigation of Judge Kweku Agyeman's death. The danger was that one set of suspicions could be used to make the other look settled.

He wrote two headings on a fresh sheet: THE MURDER and THE RECORDS. Beneath the first he listed the evidence that could be independently tested: the scene, the clock, access to the study, the key arrangements, the timeline and the accounts of those present.

Beneath the second he listed the altered forms, the Room Four references, the missing attachment, the disputed committee procedure and the identity substitution in Daniel's records. He left the two columns adjacent, without drawing a boundary between them.

His assistant, Kofi, stood at the door with a file. “You want these kept separate even though Ofori appears in both?”

“Especially because he appears in both,” Badu said. “If one column borrows certainty from the other, we will stop investigating and start telling ourselves a story.”

The file contained a copy of a committee memorandum dated years earlier. The paper was ordinary, the language bureaucratic. It referred to a review of records from Haven House and said that further circulation should be restricted until the committee had confirmed the status of the material. Ofori's initials appeared beside a distribution note. There was no instruction to destroy anything, no mention of Daniel, and no direct reference to a fifth copy.

“Could be routine confidentiality,” Kofi said.

“It could.”

“Could also be a way to keep the file from being seen.”

“It could also be that. What does the document actually establish?”

Kofi considered it. “That Ofori was involved in restricting circulation of the material.”

“If the copy is authentic and the initials are his.”

Badu circled those qualifications. They were not obstacles to the inquiry. They were the boundary that kept the inquiry honest.

They sent the memorandum for document examination and requested the registry entry that should have recorded its creation and distribution. The original had not been found. Until it surfaced, the copy could guide the next step, but it could not establish who wrote the note, when the initials were added, or whether the page had been altered after leaving the office.

That afternoon Badu interviewed a retired administrative officer who had worked near Ofori. The man arrived carrying a small notebook and the guarded patience of someone who had spent years avoiding disputes that no longer belonged to him.

“Did Mr. Ofori direct you to alter records?” Badu asked.

“No.”

“Did he direct you to restrict access to records?”

“He said certain files should not be circulated until the committee had decided what could be released.”

“Was that unusual?”

“Not in itself. Some files contained confidential information.”

“Did you understand which files he meant?”

“At the time, yes. Looking back, I cannot say that I remember every file.”

Badu asked him to describe the procedure. The officer explained that requests were sometimes held while a secretary checked the authority of the person requesting access. In other cases, a chairperson or legal adviser would give written approval. The process was imperfect, and staff sometimes relied on verbal directions when deadlines pressed. That did not make every verbal direction improper, but it made later reconstruction difficult.

“Was there a separate register for Room Four?” Badu asked.

The man frowned. “There were room books. There were file registers. I do not remember a register specifically for Room Four.”

“Could the room number have been written in the margin of another book?”

“Yes.”

“Could a handwritten number be mistaken for a file reference?”

“If the page was unclear, yes.”

The answers were limited, but useful. “Room Four” appeared in several sources, yet the references might indicate a physical room, a file designation, or an annotation added later. Badu told the officer not to guess which was which. Instead, he requested the names of the staff who maintained the room books and the retention schedule in force at the time.

Before the interview ended, Badu returned to Ofori.

“Did you ever see him carrying a file from the committee offices?”

“I may have.”

“Can you recall a particular file?”

“No.”

“A date?”

“No.”

“Then what do you remember?”

“That he was a senior person. People made room for him. When he asked for something, it tended to happen.”

“That describes influence,” Badu said. “It does not identify a file.”

The man looked relieved, as though the distinction had lifted a burden he could not name. “That is fair.”

After the officer left, Badu reviewed the old notes on Agyeman's death. Ofori's place in the wider institutional history justified scrutiny, but it did not

establish that he had entered the judge's study, used a duplicate key, moved the clock, or caused the fatal encounter. Each possibility required evidence of its own.

A message arrived from the document examiner. The memorandum copy showed no obvious sign of a recent physical alteration, but the examiner could not authenticate the initials from the copy alone. The original paper and a reliable comparison sample would be needed for a stronger conclusion. The result was neither confirmation nor exoneration.

Badu placed the message beside the memorandum. Then he received another call, this one from the records office. A staff member had found a reference in an old index to a “restricted return” filed under a number that did not match the surviving copy. The index entry gave no title and no author. The date remained legible; the number after the slash, however, was overwritten or damaged.

“Does it say Ofori?” Badu asked.

“No, sir.”

“Does it say Room Four?”

“No. It says restricted return.”

“Then that is what we have. Please photograph the full page, preserve the original, and record who handled it before we arrived.”

He ended the call and studied the two documents. One showed that a senior figure had participated in limiting circulation of some material. The other showed that a restricted return had once been indexed. Neither established that they concerned the same file. Neither proved that a record had been stolen, destroyed, or deliberately concealed.

But together they gave him a lawful, specific next step: identify the restricted-return procedure, locate the corresponding register, and determine whether the number could be reconciled with the surviving papers.

Mabel called later that evening. She had received another message from an unknown source, this one naming Ofori and claiming he had ordered the removal of the fifth copy.

“Do you have evidence for that?” Badu asked.

“No. Only the message.”

“Then it is an allegation, not a finding.”

“I know. I haven't published it.”

He accepted her answer without asking her to identify the source. She had a duty to protect confidential communications, and he had no right to turn a journalist into an informal evidence-gathering instrument. He asked only whether the message contained a document, a date, or a claim that could be checked independently.

“It gives a date for the alleged instruction,” Mabel said. “But no place, no recipient, and no copy of the instruction.”

“Send the date through the liaison. We can compare it with the official records without asking you to expose the source.”

“And if the date matches?”

“Then we will know the date matches. We will still have to establish what happened.”

After the call, Badu added a new line to the board: OFORI — SCOPE OF AUTHORITY AND DOCUMENTED ACTIONS. He did not write KILLER beside the name. He did not write INNOCENT either. The inquiry had to be capable of moving in either direction as evidence developed.

In a separate section, he recorded the anonymous allegation and marked its source as unverified. The date would be checked. The claim would not be repeated as fact.

Near midnight, as the office emptied, Badu noticed that the two columns on his sheet had begun to accumulate their own weight. The murder had a victim, a scene and a set of physical questions. The records inquiry had altered forms, gaps in procedure and people who remembered different fragments of an old administrative life. Ofori's shadow crossed both, but a shadow was shaped by the light as much as by the object that cast it.

Badu placed the memorandum in an evidence sleeve and sealed it for transfer. The chain-of-custody form recorded the time, handler, and destination. Its movement would now be documented rather than left to memory.

He switched off the desk lamp. Tomorrow, they would begin with the restricted-return register.

For now, Ofori remained a person of interest in a story whose separate questions had not yet earned the right to become one answer.

The Former Driver's Account

The former driver asked to meet at a roadside café where buses stopped often enough that no one would notice a visitor arriving late or leaving early. Badu chose a table near the open front, away from the television. The man introduced himself as Mr. Kwarteng and said he had driven committee members on official errands years earlier. He brought no documents.

"I remember Mr. Ofori," Kwarteng said. "I remember taking him to meetings. I remember waiting outside offices. I don't remember every date."

"That's understandable. We can work with what you do remember."

"People think a driver hears everything. Usually you hear the door close."

Kwarteng described a day when he had driven Ofori and another committee member to a government building. He remembered rain, a delayed meeting, and a brown folder placed on the rear seat. He could not say what was inside the folder. He did not remember seeing a fifth copy, a list of names, or a document bearing the S-4 notation.

“Did Mr. Ofori give you an instruction about the folder?” Badu asked.

“He told me not to leave it in the car when I went to buy lunch.”

“Did you take it inside?”

“No. I waited with the car. He took it with him.”

“Could someone else have handled it?”

“Anyone who came to the car could have. But I don’t remember anyone doing so.”

Badu repeated the distinction aloud to ensure it was understood: the witness remembered the folder and the instruction, not its contents or its later destination. Kwarteng nodded.

“Will that help you?” he asked.

“It may help establish a routine. It doesn’t establish what happened to a particular record.”

Kwarteng seemed disappointed, as if he had hoped memory could offer something firmer. “I have thought

about that day for years. I wondered whether I should have followed him inside.”

“You were a driver carrying out an ordinary task. We can’t assign meaning to what you didn’t know at the time.”

When the meeting ended, Badu asked permission to contact him again if a date or route could be independently established. Kwarteng agreed, then left without finishing his tea. Badu recorded the account as a lead, not corroboration. Ofori’s name had appeared in enough places to deserve scrutiny. It had not yet earned the right to become an answer.

The Missing Register’s Shelf

The archives team inspected the shelves where the restricted-return register should have been stored. They measured the gaps between neighbouring volumes and checked the old shelf labels against the current catalogue. A book of similar thickness had once occupied the space, but the label did not identify its title.

The store supervisor remembered a reorganisation in which several ledgers had been moved to make room for new filing cabinets. He could not remember whether the restricted-return register was among them. His recollection led to a work order, and the work order led to a list of cartons sent to temporary storage.

The list was incomplete. It contained a carton number without a full destination and a handwritten initial that might belong to more than one employee. Badu requested the original sheet and the corresponding transport receipt rather than treating the photocopy as conclusive.

The search yielded another location to examine, not proof that anyone had deliberately removed the register. A senior officer, hoping for a clearer briefing, was disappointed. Badu explained that uncertainty still had value when it narrowed the next search.

Ofori's Calendar — Initial Account

The office calendar supplied by Ofori's former department was found to have been updated in pencil after the month had ended. A small note in the corner referred to a meeting moved from one room to another, but the initials of the person who made the change were unclear. Badu requested the diary of the clerk responsible for maintaining the calendar and asked that the original be preserved for examination.

Ofori's account placed him in a meeting that afternoon. A second witness remembered seeing him in the corridor but could not say whether he had entered the meeting room. The visitor register showed his arrival at the building, not his movements after he passed the reception desk. Each record supported part of the account, while leaving the central timing unresolved.

When Badu interviewed the clerk, she remembered moving the meeting because another office had reserved the room. She could not recall whether Ofori had attended for the entire session. Her diary showed the room change, but no attendance list survived. She was careful not to fill the gap with what she believed must have happened.

Badu added the calendar, diary, and visitor register to a single timeline, marking which entries were original and which were retrospective. Ofori's account remained possible, but not independently confirmed in every detail. The team would continue testing it against phone records and other witnesses. For now, the calendar did not place him at the judge's study, nor did it clear him of being there. It described a meeting whose attendance had not been recorded well enough.

Ofori's Former Office

Badu visited the office Yaw Ofori had used during the committee's final year. The room now belonged to a different department, and the furniture had been replaced. A facilities manager brought out an old floor plan and explained that the corridor had been reconfigured during renovations. The plan was not precise enough to establish who could see the committee room door from the desk Ofori once occupied.

The manager remembered that Ofori's office had been used for meetings when the committee room was

unavailable. He could not say which meetings had taken place there, and the booking register from that period had not survived. Badu asked him to record those limits in his statement rather than offer a general recollection as a specific fact.

A former administrative assistant, now working elsewhere in the building, remembered carrying folders to Ofori's office. She said the folders were usually closed and that she had not read their contents. Once, she had been asked to wait while a telephone call ended; another time, she had been told to leave a packet on the side table. She could not recall a label or reference number.

"Did you ever see him remove a file?" Badu asked.

"I saw him carry files. I cannot tell you what was inside them or where they went afterwards."

Her answer frustrated the officer accompanying Badu, who had hoped to establish a route between the office and the archive. Badu made sure the statement did not imply more. A person carrying a folder was an ordinary sight in an administrative building. Its significance depended on what the folder was and what happened next.

As he concluded the visit, Badu asked for the renovation records and any surviving room-booking schedules. The manager agreed to search the facilities archive. The request was logged formally, and no one

was permitted to remove the old floor plan from the office without a receipt.

As Badu walked out, he considered how a person's influence could outlast the records of what that person had done. Ofori's name changed the tone of conversations, but that reaction could not connect him to a specific act. The investigation needed a particular action, a relevant record, or a reliable witness who could link the two.

The Locksmith's Limits

The locksmith returned with a short written report that separated his observations from his conclusions. He had tested a comparable lock and found that a duplicate key cut to the same pattern could operate it under certain conditions. The original lock was no longer available for a complete test.

Badu asked whether a person could have used such a key without leaving obvious marks. The locksmith said it was possible, but the test could not establish that it happened. Wear, maintenance and the condition of the mechanism would affect the result. He declined to estimate how many people might have possessed a duplicate because no reliable key register had been located.

The report was useful because it stated its limits. Badu attached it to the case file and noted that compatibility identified neither a key-holder nor anyone inside the room on the night of the murder.

Later, he reviewed the building access records with the same caution. An entry could show that a door had been opened, but not always who had opened it. A missing entry could reflect a failure to record, not necessarily an unauthorised visit. The lock remained one line of inquiry among several, not the centre of the case.

Ofori's Calendar — Independent Review

Badu asked for the calendar to be examined by someone who had not previously interviewed Ofori or reviewed the anonymous allegations. The independent reviewer began by listing the calendar's physical features: paper type, binding, pencil marks, and the places where entries had been added. The reviewer could not determine who wrote each note from appearance alone. The calendar had been used for several months after the events, and later annotations were possible.

The entry for the disputed afternoon placed Ofori in a meeting, but the room booking record showed that the meeting time had been changed. A staff member remembered the change because another department needed the room. The recollection was not precise about the date. Badu asked for the booking sheets from the surrounding weeks to see whether the same room was frequently reassigned. If the change was routine, it would reduce the calendar's value as proof of a particular movement.

A former assistant explained that Ofori often worked in his office during meetings that were listed elsewhere. He sometimes joined by telephone, sometimes arrived late, and sometimes sent a representative. The assistant could not say what happened on the disputed afternoon. Badu asked whether any minutes or attendance sheets survived. One set of minutes listed the names expected to attend but not who actually arrived. It was a record of the plan, not necessarily of the meeting as it occurred.

Mabel asked Ofori's former department for a written response to the specific records rather than the broader accusation that had circulated anonymously. The response denied that the calendar established any order to remove a document and requested that the investigation distinguish administrative authority from operational handling. Mabel included the response in her notes. A denial did not settle the question, but fairness required the team to record it alongside the evidence that had prompted the inquiry.

Badu assembled the calendar, room bookings, minutes, and assistant's statement into a single packet. He marked each item with its source and reliability. The calendar suggested a possible opportunity; the booking record complicated it; the witness memory remained general. Nothing established that Ofori had handled the fifth copy, and nothing in this group of records proved a role in the judge's murder. Badu

wrote those limits into the summary rather than leaving them for someone else to infer.

That evening, an anonymous message arrived claiming the calendar had been altered to give Ofori an alibi. Badu preserved it and asked the team to identify a testable feature. The message supplied no original, no witness, and no method for checking the claim. The calendar would be examined because the evidence warranted it, not because an unknown sender had instructed them to distrust it. That distinction kept the investigation from becoming a contest between anonymous voices.

Ofori’s Unlisted Appointment

Badu asked Ofori to review the calendar alongside the visitor register and explain a short period that appeared to be unaccounted for. Ofori said he had attended a meeting in the building, then remembered that he might have stopped at another office first. He did not change his account to fit the records; instead, he asked for time to check a personal diary kept by his late wife. Badu agreed, making clear that the diary would be examined only for entries relevant to the date.

The diary contained a note about collecting a repaired watch and a reminder to call a colleague. Neither entry placed Ofori at the disputed room. A separate line mentioned that he would be late for

supper, but it did not identify where he had been. The detail was ordinary and private, and Badu did not treat it as proof of anything beyond the fact that Ofori had expected a delayed evening.

When Ofori returned, he brought a copy of the page and explained that he had remembered the meeting because it had been moved, not because he recalled the exact time he arrived. The visitor register confirmed his entry to the building but did not show which room he entered afterward. Badu recorded the difference between the two sources and asked whether the meeting secretary might have kept a separate attendance sheet.

Ofori wanted to know whether the uncertainty made him a suspect. Badu replied that uncertainty was a reason to ask another question, not a finding against him. Ofori accepted the answer, though he remained visibly frustrated. The interview ended with an outstanding request rather than a confrontation. The calendar still did not prove where Ofori had been during every minute, but it no longer carried the false precision the team had first assigned to it.

The Witness Draws the Corridor

Mabel asked the witness to draw the corridor from memory before showing any photographs. The first sketch placed the doorway closer to the stairwell

than the building plan did. The witness studied the drawing and said the distance might have felt shorter because the light had flickered and another person had been standing near the wall. Mabel kept the first sketch and invited the witness to make a second version with corrections marked in another colour.

The two drawings differed in small but important ways. One showed the figure facing the office door; the other showed only a shoulder and part of the head. The witness explained that the second version reflected what they could honestly remember, not what they had seen more clearly since. Badu recorded the difference without choosing the drawing that best fit the working theory.

The exercise did not identify the figure. It did, however, show how later discussion could reshape spatial memory. The witness asked whether the correction would make them appear unreliable. Mabel said the record would include both drawings and the reason for the change. A witness who acknowledged uncertainty could still contribute useful evidence, provided the limits remained visible.

CHAPTER FIFTEEN — A SECOND ACCOUNT OF THE NIGHT

The restricted-return register was not where the archive catalogue said it should be. Badu learned that the following morning and resisted the temptation to call it a disappearance. The catalogue had been compiled years after the register was last used. It identified a shelf, not a verified location, and that shelf had since been reorganised twice.

“So it is missing?” the records officer asked, watching him make notes.

“It is not at the listed location,” Badu replied. “Those are different statements.”

The officer nodded, perhaps relieved that he would not be asked to explain a crime before anyone had established the facts. They checked the adjacent shelves, the transfer ledger, and a box of duplicate indexes filed under an obsolete department code. The register was not there. Instead, they found a small card indicating that several administrative books had been moved temporarily during a renovation. The destination field was blank.

Badu photographed the card where it lay and asked for the full box to be secured pending a proper inventory. A blank destination could mean a careless

clerk, an incomplete transfer, or something more deliberate. It did not tell him which.

At the station, he found Superintendent Asare waiting beside the conference-room door. Asare had read the morning's update and was unhappy that the inquiry seemed to be expanding faster than it was producing answers.

"We are investigating a murder," Asare said. "I do not want a whole government archive treated as a crime scene because an index is untidy."

"Neither do I," Badu said. "That is why I am documenting what is there and what is not. The register may tell us whether the restricted-return entry can be connected to a specific transfer. Until we find it, we cannot responsibly make that connection."

Asare looked at the photograph of the card. "And Ofori?"

"His authority is relevant. His guilt is not established by a memo copy or an absent register."

"You are careful with your words."

"I need to be."

Asare gave a short, tired nod. He had not ordered Badu to stop; he had reminded him that the murder investigation must remain anchored to evidence that could withstand scrutiny. Badu took the reminder seriously, though he suspected Asare also feared where the records trail might lead.

By midday, the liaison officer had confirmed that the date supplied by Mabel's anonymous source matched a date on a committee schedule. The schedule recorded a meeting about document retention and circulation. It did not record an instruction to remove anything, and the surviving minutes did not mention Room Four, Daniel Sarpong, or a fifth copy.

Badu read the schedule twice. The date was a lead, not a confession. A meeting about records could have been routine. A senior official's presence might explain access, but it did not establish what that official had done.

He sent the schedule for preservation and requested the attendance sheet, agenda attachments, and any circulation list maintained separately from the minutes. He also asked the liaison officer to establish whether the committee had authority to order a transfer or only to recommend one. The distinction could determine whether the anonymous allegation was even describing a power Ofori possessed.

Mabel arrived later with a different kind of document: a copy of a statement taken years earlier from a night security attendant at the building where the committee had met. She had obtained it through a lawful public-records request, she explained, and had not altered or annotated the copy. The attendant's name was partly redacted in the version she had received.

“This is not from my source,” she said. “I want that clear. It was released through the records office. The statement describes a person leaving after the meeting, carrying a flat envelope. It gives no name.”

Badu did not reach for it immediately. “Does the statement identify the building entrance or the time?”

“The service entrance. The time is written as approximately nine-forty, but the copy does not show who added the time.”

“And does it say the envelope came from Room Four?”

“No.”

“Does it say it contained a file?”

“No. It says an envelope.”

He placed the copy on a clean section of the table. “Then we should not make it say more than it does.”

Mabel’s expression tightened. “I know how this sounds. Every time a detail appears, there is a reason it proves less than we hoped.”

“That is not the same as proving nothing,” Badu said. “It gives us a witness statement to verify. We can ask for the unredacted original through the proper process, establish who recorded the time, and find out whether the attendant is alive and willing to speak. But the envelope cannot become the fifth copy just because we need it to be.”

She lowered her eyes to the paper. “I did not say it was.”

“No. But someone will, if we are careless.”

Mabel agreed to provide the release reference and the record-office correspondence. She would not disclose the identity of her confidential source, and Badu did not ask. The security statement stood on its own, separate from the anonymous allegation about Ofori. That separation mattered more than the apparent convenience of having both papers point in the same direction.

The records office supplied the reference number before the day ended. The original statement was still held in a personnel archive, but access required approval because the attendant’s employment file contained private information. Badu submitted the request and specified the limited information needed: the statement’s complete wording, its date, the author’s identity, and any notation explaining the time entry. He did not request unrelated personal details.

That evening, he returned to the murder file. The second account of the night had emerged from a different source, but it did not yet concern the night of Judge Agyeman’s death. The committee meeting and the murder were separated by questions that could not be bridged by atmosphere or coincidence. The attendant might have seen a routine departure years earlier. The document might have been included in

Mabel's research because it resembled the missing-file story. Neither possibility made it irrelevant, but neither made it proof.

He opened the scene chronology. The stopped clock remained unreliable as a time marker. The duplicate study key remained a possible means of access, not evidence of who had used it. The corridor mechanism could be operated from outside with a working duplicate, but the demonstration had established only that the mechanism was possible. No witness had yet placed Ofori at the study door at the relevant time.

Badu added a note beneath the chronology: "Do not use the committee departure statement to fill gaps in the murder timeline unless identity, date, location, and relevance are independently established."

A message arrived from the forensic liaison shortly before he left. The copied initials on the committee memorandum remained too degraded for a reliable comparison. The examiner would need the original or a demonstrably faithful high-quality reproduction. It was another delay, and another reason not to treat the memo as authenticated evidence.

Mabel called once more. "The anonymous sender has replied," she said. "They say the attendant was paid to keep quiet."

"Do they provide a receipt, a name, a date, anything we can check?"

"No. They say the payment was cash."

Badu closed his eyes for a moment. “That is an allegation about an allegation. We will record it, but we cannot treat it as established or use it to pressure the attendant.”

“I thought you would say that.”

“If the attendant is willing to speak, the interview must be voluntary. We will not tell them what the anonymous person claims. We will ask what they remember and preserve the answer, including uncertainty.”

After the call, Badu entered the new message in the source log. He marked the payment claim unverified and made no inference about the sender’s identity or motive. He then wrote two questions on separate sheets. The first concerned the murder: who had access to the judge’s study, and what evidence placed any person there at the relevant time? The second concerned the records: what happened to the restricted-return register, and did any official order a transfer of a specific file?

The questions might eventually intersect. For now, they remained separate. A second account of a night was not a second account of the murder. It was a record whose meaning depended on details still missing.

At the end of the session, Badu secured the new documents in separate sleeves, recorded each handler and time, and signed the transfer log. On the board, he

added one line under the records inquiry: SECURITY STATEMENT — ORIGINAL REQUESTED; ENVELOPE CONTENT UNKNOWN. Under the murder inquiry, he added nothing.

The blank space was not a failure. It was a boundary.

Daniel Writes Two Timelines

Daniel spread two sheets of paper across his kitchen table. On the first he wrote what he remembered from childhood: the envelope with brown tape, the adults speaking in another room, the instruction about school papers, the warning not to repeat certain names. On the second he wrote what he had learned later: the conflicting names in the records, the disputed reference number, the alleged fifth line, and the anonymous messages.

He kept the pages apart. Ms. Boateng had suggested the exercise because Daniel had begun to repeat information he had read in documents as though he had always remembered it. That did not mean his childhood memories were false. It meant he needed a way to distinguish the source of each detail.

When he finished, he called Mabel and asked whether she would look at the timelines before they were shared with Badu. She agreed, but told him she would not edit the memories to make them fit the records. The aim was to preserve his account, not improve its usefulness to the investigation.

They met the following afternoon. Mabel read each page and asked him to mark any memory he could date only by season, school term, or family event. Daniel did so. Several details shifted from a firm year to a broad period. He looked uncomfortable as he changed them, as though he were surrendering something.

“You are not losing the memory,” Mabel said. “You are recording how certain you are about its date.”

“I thought being precise meant being helpful.”

“Being accurate is more helpful than sounding precise.”

Daniel added a third mark beside statements he had heard from other people. He identified who had told him where he could, and wrote “source uncertain” when he could not. One detail about the envelope came from his aunt; another came from a conversation he remembered only vaguely. The two had blended over time.

Mabel asked permission to give the timelines to Badu. Daniel agreed, with the condition that the original sheets remain his and that any copies be logged. He wanted the record to show that he was participating, but he did not want his personal history treated as a public exhibit.

When Badu reviewed the pages, he found no instant answer. He did find a clear separation between memories, later knowledge, and hearsay. That

separation would help the team test each statement against other evidence without accusing Daniel of inconsistency every time he corrected a date.

That evening, Daniel put the original sheets in a folder of his own. For the first time, the investigation had given him a task that did not require him to guess who he had been. He had written down what he knew, what he thought, and what he could not yet tell apart.

The Corridor Light — Maintenance Note

The building electrician inspected the corridor circuit after reading the witness's revised statement. He found a maintenance note showing that the light had flickered during the week in question. The note did not identify the exact evening, and the repair had been scheduled rather than completed immediately. The electrician could not say whether the corridor was dark at the time the witness heard the noise.

Badu asked him to explain how the fault would have appeared to someone passing through. The electrician described several possibilities: a brief flicker, a complete outage, or a light that worked when the circuit was cool and failed after use. He refused to choose among them without a contemporaneous report. The explanation helped the team understand the witness's conditions of observation but did not confirm the memory.

Mabel asked the witness whether the darkness had made them more certain or less certain about what

they saw. The witness admitted that, over time, the mind had supplied a clearer outline than the original view could have provided. They remembered a shape crossing the far end of the corridor, not a face. The correction was added to the statement, with the earlier version retained for comparison.

The revised account weakened any claim that the witness had identified a particular person. It strengthened the reliability of the witness's description of their own limits. Badu instructed the team to use the account only for what it supported: a movement may have occurred in the corridor, under poor lighting, at an uncertain time. The identity of the person remained unproved.

The Night Shift's Routine

To understand the disputed night, Badu asked the building's former night supervisor to describe the routine without being shown the investigators' theory. The man, Mr Addo, had retired and now lived outside the city. He agreed to speak at the station but insisted that he wanted the questions read aloud before giving his account.

Addo explained that the night shift recorded visitors, checked doors, and responded to maintenance calls. The record was not a minute-by-minute account of every corridor. If a staff member moved between two areas without passing the main desk, the log might

show no entry. A door could be unlocked for cleaning or repair and later secured by another employee.

Badu asked whether a person could have entered the judge’s corridor without being logged. Addo said it was possible under some circumstances, but he could not say that it had happened on the night in question. The access rules had changed over the years, and he did not remember every detail of the old arrangement.

“Did you see anyone carrying a box or packet?” Badu asked.

“I saw people carrying things in the building. I cannot attach a particular object to that night without a record or a clear memory.”

Addo remembered a maintenance call in the general period, but the date on his personal calendar was not exact. The maintenance book listed several calls to different floors. None identified the judge’s study, and the technician’s name appeared in two spellings. Badu requested the contractor’s surviving work orders before drawing any connection.

The interview lasted nearly two hours. Addo corrected the officer twice when the questions suggested that the log was complete. He had not kept it to conceal events, he said; he had kept it because it was required. The difference mattered to Badu. A routine record could be incomplete without being false.

After the statement was signed, Badu wrote a new question for the timeline: what independent source

could establish the exact movement of people through the corridor? The answer would not come from asking the night supervisor to remember what the log could not show.

The Corridor Light — Circuit Review

The electrician returned with the maintenance book and a diagram showing the corridor circuit, the switch points, and the emergency lights. He explained that the fault could make the far end of the corridor dim without leaving the whole passage dark. A person standing near one doorway might see a silhouette but not a face. Someone farther away might see the light differently. The diagram gave the investigators a better account of the conditions, but it could not reconstruct exactly what any witness had perceived.

Badu asked the electrician to identify which statements were consistent with the fault and which could not be evaluated. The electrician refused to rank witnesses. He had not been present on the night in question and could not say whether the same fault existed then. The maintenance entry was dated within the broader period, not at a precise hour. A later repair could explain the present condition without proving the earlier one.

The witness was interviewed again, this time with no photograph or suggested name on the table. They described a person moving near the corridor's end and a light changing as a door opened. The witness could

not identify the person’s face. Their earlier certainty had come partly from assuming that only a small number of staff could have been in the building. Badu asked them to separate what they saw from what they concluded afterwards. The revised statement was less dramatic and more reliable.

Afterwards, the witness asked whether changing an answer made them look dishonest. Badu said that correcting an overstatement was preferable to defending it. People often became more certain about a memory when they repeated it, especially when others supplied a name or an explanation. The team would preserve the original statement and the revision so that the change remained visible. The purpose was not to erase inconsistency but to understand how it had developed.

Mabel considered whether the revised account weakened the case. It weakened one claim: that a witness had identified a particular person in the corridor. It did not answer who had been present, whether the door had been opened, or how the maintenance fault related to the event. She wrote to her editor that the statement had been clarified and that investigators were reviewing the lighting conditions. She refused to publish a suspect’s name based on the earlier version.

On his way out, Badu stood at the corridor’s far end while the electrician demonstrated the switch. The light dipped, then returned. The effect was subtle

enough to be remembered differently by two people. Badu wrote down the time and position of the demonstration, then reminded himself that the test was not a recreation of the night. It showed what the system could do, not what had happened. The distinction was now part of the case file.

The Electrician’s Demonstration

The electrician returned after the building manager located a replacement note for the corridor light. He brought a portable lamp and showed how a failing connection could flicker when the circuit warmed, then work normally after a short rest. He did not reproduce the exact condition of the old installation; the demonstration illustrated a mechanism, not a historical event. Badu asked him to state that distinction in his report.

The witness who had described seeing a figure in the corridor watched the demonstration from the far end of the passage. At that distance, the lamp’s change in brightness made clothing colours harder to distinguish, but it did not make every feature invisible. The witness said the demonstration resembled what they remembered, though they could not say it was identical. Mabel recorded the response without asking the witness to identify a person from a photograph.

The electrician explained that the original fault might have behaved differently depending on temperature, load, and the age of the connection. The replacement note showed that a repair had been requested, but the completion time was missing. That gap prevented the team from determining whether the light had been stable on the night in question. The witness's account could describe a figure, but the light could not validate the identity.

Badu amended the timeline to show the range of possible lighting conditions rather than a single assumed state. It was less tidy than the earlier version, but it reflected the limits of the records. The witness signed the revised statement and thanked the team for not pressing for a certainty they did not have. The corridor remained a location in the inquiry, not a reliable means of naming the person who had passed through it.

The Key's Custody Review

Before the duplicate key could be examined again, the evidence officer reviewed the custody form from the moment it had been collected. The exhibit number was present on every transfer, but one handover time had been entered in a different ink. The officer checked the duty log and found that the time had been copied from the shift sheet after the

officer returned to the station. The explanation was plausible, yet it had to be documented rather than assumed.

Badu asked whether the late entry affected the integrity of the key. The evidence officer said the form showed a clerical correction, not evidence that the item had been substituted. The photographs taken at collection matched the key's visible features, and the seal number remained consistent. Still, the team recorded the correction and ensured that any report described the custody history accurately.

The review did not make the key more incriminating or less incriminating. It made the record of its handling more complete. Badu added the custody note to the file and reminded the team that the key's ability to operate a test cylinder did not prove it had opened the building's lock on the night in question.

PART FOUR — WHAT THE RECORDS CAN PROVE

CHAPTER SIXTEEN — THE DUPLICATE KEY

The locksmith arrived at the station carrying a narrow case and the careful expression of a man who had already been warned not to solve a mystery for the convenience of the people asking questions. Badu welcomed that expression. It suggested the man understood the difference between demonstrating a possibility and identifying a culprit.

They met in the evidence room, where the study-door photographs had been enlarged and pinned beside the floor plan. The original lock had been removed months earlier during repairs, but the police had retained it under seal. The duplicate key recovered during the inquiry was stored separately, its envelope signed across the flap and its movements recorded. No one would test it until the locksmith confirmed the seal and Badu documented the purpose of the examination.

“I can tell you whether this key operates this lock,” the locksmith said. “I cannot tell you who held it on the night the judge died.”

“That is exactly the distinction I need in the report,” Badu replied.

The seal was intact. The evidence officer read the number aloud while Badu compared it with the register. The locksmith watched without impatience. When the envelope was opened, the key was placed on

a clean tray beside the lock. He examined the cuts under a magnifier, then measured them against a reference blank. He worked slowly, explaining each step for the record.

The key entered the cylinder. It turned, but not smoothly. The locksmith stopped, withdrew it, and examined the lock again. He did not force the mechanism. A second attempt produced the same resistance. He noted that the key appeared compatible but that wear and the condition of the cylinder affected the result. Compatibility was not the same as proof that it had been used on the relevant night.

“Could it have opened the study door before the repairs?” Badu asked.

“Possibly. The lock has changed condition since then, and I have no reliable record of its exact condition at the time of the incident. I can describe what I observe today. I will not pretend the present test reconstructs every past circumstance.”

The answer frustrated the younger officer observing from the doorway. “But it works, doesn’t it?” he asked.

“Not consistently,” the locksmith said. “And even if it worked perfectly, the result would establish only that the key could operate the lock. It would not establish who possessed it, when they possessed it, or whether they entered the room.”

Badu asked the officer to record the question and answer verbatim. The case had suffered enough from

people turning careful statements into stronger claims. A report confirming that the duplicate key opened the study could become, by evening, a story that it had opened the study on the night of the murder. The distinction could vanish in a headline, then return later as an apparent fact repeated by people who had never read the report.

They moved to a demonstration door fitted with a comparable latch and cylinder. The locksmith showed how a door could be secured from the corridor when a compatible key was available. He repeated the demonstration with the latch in different positions and explained the limits of the comparison. It was a practical illustration of a mechanism, not a recreation of the crime scene. The demonstration lock was not the judge's lock, and the exercise could not establish the actual sequence of events in the study.

Badu watched the latch settle. The old theory had depended on the belief that a locked door meant the person responsible must have been inside when it was secured. The demonstration showed that the mechanism allowed more than one possibility. It did not choose among them.

"So the locked door tells us less than we thought," the younger officer said.

"It tells us what state the door was found in," Badu answered. "The rest depends on the lock, the key, the scene evidence, and the people who had access. We do

not get to fill the gaps because one explanation is neat.”

The locksmith prepared his preliminary note. He described the test conditions, the observed resistance, the compatibility of the key, and the limitations created by the lock’s later repair and uncertain wear. He refused to use the phrase “murder key.” Badu approved. The phrase belonged to a newspaper headline, not a laboratory record.

After the examination, Badu reviewed the access list for the study. Several people had legitimate reasons to enter the judge’s office during the preceding week. Some had used the main key under ordinary procedures. Others had been admitted by staff. The duplicate key’s origin remained uncertain, and its existence did not automatically place it in Ofori’s hand. It could have passed through an office, been copied for a routine reason, or entered the evidence trail through a route not yet documented. Every possibility required testing rather than selection by instinct.

Asare came in while Badu was checking the access list. “Have we found the key that locked the door?”

“We have a key that may operate the lock. The test is limited. We have not established who had it or whether it was used that night.”

“The public will hear that a duplicate key exists.”

“Then our statement must be accurate. We should say an examination is under way and that no conclusion about possession or use has been reached.”

Asare rubbed his forehead. “You know how unsatisfying that sounds.”

“Unsatisfying is not the same as unimportant. If we say more than we can prove, we risk damaging the case and giving the person responsible a reason to challenge everything else.”

The superintendent studied the photographs, then nodded. He had spent enough years in the service to know that the strongest case was not the one with the most dramatic explanation. It was the one that survived every reasonable question.

At noon, the evidence officer reported a small discrepancy in an old key register. The entry for the study’s spare key had been written in a different ink from the surrounding entries. No correction mark accompanied it, and the handwriting was too brief for a meaningful comparison. The register had been handled by several departments over many years. The discrepancy might reflect an ordinary later annotation. It might matter. At that stage, it proved neither.

Badu asked for the original register to be photographed in place, page by page, and for the records custodian to provide a statement explaining how the book had been stored and accessed. He

instructed the team not to remove the page or separate it from the binding. A cropped photograph would lose the surrounding entries; a detached page would lose part of its history. Context was evidence too.

Mabel arrived with the release number for the security attendant's statement. She had obtained the number through the public-records process, and the correspondence showed the route by which the copy had been issued. It did not identify the confidential source who had first drawn her attention to the record. Badu did not ask her to name that person.

"The statement could be from another night," Mabel said. "The date is missing from the copy."

"Then we need the original and the file history."

"If the original gives us a date, will you compare it with the murder?"

"If the date, location and description make that comparison relevant. We will not force it to fit."

She looked toward the photographs of the lock. "Everyone wants one object to answer the whole case. First the clock, then the key, now the envelope."

"Objects answer the questions they are capable of answering," Badu said. "The clock can tell us its condition. The key can tell us about a lock. The envelope may tell us what a witness saw. None of them can testify to a person's intention without evidence connecting the object to that person."

Mabel wrote the sentence in her notebook, then crossed it out. “That sounds like you,” she said. “It would make a poor headline.”

“Good. It is an instruction, not a headline.”

Before she left, she asked whether the anonymous allegation against Ofori had been verified. Badu said the date had been matched to a committee schedule, but the alleged instruction had not been found. The schedule established that a meeting occurred; it did not establish what was said in the room. He would not allow the existence of a meeting to become proof of a secret order.

That afternoon, the locksmith signed his report and watched the evidence officer reseal the key and lock. Every transfer was recorded. Badu read the report once for technical accuracy and again for the limits it set out. Those limits were not defects to be hidden. They were the edges of what the examination could support.

He returned to the board and placed a note beneath the duplicate-key photograph: COMPATIBILITY TEST INCONCLUSIVE IN PART; POSSESSION AND USE NOT ESTABLISHED. Under the records inquiry, he added the discrepancy in the key register as a separate lead. He kept the two columns visually distinct but did not rule out a connection.

A final message from the archive arrived shortly before closing. The custodian had located a box-

transfer sheet from the year the study lock was replaced. The sheet referred to a set of spare keys but gave no individual numbers. One signature was legible; the other was not. The transfer might explain how duplicates were stored, but without the inventory it could not identify the key in police custody.

Badu requested the linked inventory and the names of the staff responsible for the transfer. He also asked that the sheet be preserved in its original folder, with adjacent pages photographed before handling. The trail was becoming wider, not clearer. Yet each verified detail narrowed the range of claims they could responsibly make.

As evening settled over the station, Badu reread the locksmith's final paragraph. A compatible key did not identify who had held it. A locked door did not make entry impossible. A discrepancy in a register did not, by itself, show that anyone had tampered with it. The case would not yield its truth simply because the pieces could be arranged into a satisfying picture.

He shut the file and looked at the two headings on his board. THE MURDER. THE RECORDS. The duplicate key belonged in the first investigation as a possible means of access. The old register belonged in the second as a record requiring explanation. Whether the two tracks would meet remained an open question.

He left the note in place and turned off the light. The key had opened a possibility, not a conclusion.

The Repair Log

The building's maintenance office occupied a converted storeroom at the back of the administrative block. Its files were arranged by year, then by type of work, though several labels had been rewritten so often that the original categories had become guesswork. The facilities manager, Mr. Nartey, apologised for the delay before Badu had even asked a question.

"The lock was changed during repairs," Nartey said. "That is what the job sheet says. I can show you the job sheet."

"Who requested the repair?"

"The office that occupied the room."

"Which person?"

Nartey turned pages in a ledger. "The request was submitted under the office name. The individual field is blank."

"Was that normal?"

"Not ideal. It happened when requests were bundled by the administrative clerk."

He found a carbon copy bearing a date and a work-order number. The description said the lock had been sticking and the cylinder was to be replaced. There was a signature in the authorisation box, but the surname was too faint to read with confidence. Nartey offered to arrange a certified scan.

Badu asked whether the removed cylinder had been retained. Nartey said the contractor usually returned old parts only when the work order specifically required it. The job sheet did not. He could not remember the contractor, though a payment ledger might identify the company.

“So the repair record doesn’t tell us who used a key afterward,” Badu said.

“No. It tells you what work was ordered and charged for, if the entries are accurate.”

“And the blank requester field?”

“It tells you the form was incomplete.”

Nartey did not seem defensive. He seemed tired of being asked to turn a routine maintenance process into a witness statement about events he had never seen. Badu thanked him and asked that the original ledger remain untouched until the scan was made under the office’s normal procedure.

Outside, Badu wrote three separate items in his notebook: repair authorised under office name; individual requester not recorded; old cylinder retention not specified. Each might matter. None established that the duplicate key had been used on the night of the judge’s death. He had to resist the appeal of a neat mechanism. A lock could be changed for an ordinary reason, a key could exist without being used, and a missing name could be the product of

careless administration rather than deliberate concealment.

Adwoa's Box of Letters

Adwoa Sarpong kept the letters in a biscuit tin wrapped in a faded cloth. She had brought it to the meeting only after Daniel agreed that the contents could be reviewed with a neutral witness present. The tin had spent years at the back of a wardrobe, moved from one house to another without anyone making an inventory. It contained school notices, receipts, two birthday cards, and a bundle of letters tied with thread.

Badu asked Adwoa to identify each item before it was opened. She did so slowly, sometimes turning a letter over and studying the handwriting before giving a name. Where she was uncertain, she said so. Mabel wrote the descriptions on a separate sheet while the evidence officer photographed the tin and its contents as they were found.

One envelope had a strip of brown tape across its flap. Daniel leaned forward, then stopped himself from touching it.

"That looks like the one I remember," he said.

"Looks like," Adwoa repeated. "You were a child. There were many envelopes in the house."

"I remember the tape."

“And I remember keeping papers together because the roof leaked. That does not tell us which paper you saw.”

Neither spoke angrily. Their disagreement was older than the investigation, and both appeared relieved that someone had finally allowed them to disagree without insisting one memory must defeat the other.

The envelope was not opened immediately. The evidence officer photographed the front, back, edges, and tape, then checked whether it showed any sign of having been opened and resealed. No reliable conclusion could be drawn from the tape alone. With Adwoa’s permission, the team documented the envelope’s location in the tin and prepared a plan for a controlled opening if it became necessary.

The other letters offered fragments of ordinary life: a request for school fees, a reminder about a clinic appointment, a note thanking a relative for transport money. None named the missing schedule or the fifth copy. One letter mentioned that a document had been placed “with the school papers,” but the date was incomplete and the writer did not specify which document.

Adwoa sat back when the inventory was finished. “You see? A family keeps things because they may be useful one day. Not because every paper is a secret.”

Badu agreed. “The collection helps us understand what was stored together. It does not prove that every item belongs to the same event.”

Daniel asked his aunt why she had never told him about the tin. Adwoa said she had mentioned it more than once, but he had been young and uninterested in old papers. Daniel said he remembered being told not to ask about certain names. She replied that she remembered telling him not to repeat gossip he heard from adults. Neither could establish that the two memories referred to the same conversation.

Mabel saw Daniel’s face tighten, not with anger exactly, but with the effort of holding two possible histories in his mind. She asked if they wanted to stop for the day. Adwoa said yes. Daniel hesitated, then agreed.

Before they left, the evidence officer returned the letters to the tin in the order recorded on the inventory, except for the taped envelope, which was placed in a separate protective sleeve with Adwoa’s consent. Every transfer was signed. The family retained ownership of the collection; the investigation had not taken possession of it merely because it might matter.

Outside, Daniel asked Badu whether the envelope could finally explain his childhood.

“It may help us test one part of it,” Badu said. “It cannot carry the whole burden of your life.”

Daniel looked toward Adwoa, who was waiting by the gate. “I know,” he said. “I’m trying to learn that.”

The Attachment Number

The corrected attachment number was checked against every available version of the register. In one copy, the correction appeared in blue ink; in another, the number was reproduced as a faint mark. The copies were not independent originals, and Badu warned the team not to count them as separate confirmation.

A retired clerk recalled being told that an attachment was pending, but could not identify the subject. His typed inventory had no date and no signature. He agreed to provide it for comparison, while acknowledging that he might have prepared it after the events, when people were already discussing missing papers.

The investigators searched the file index for titles that could match the blank description. Several possibilities emerged, including routine schedules and a supplementary list. None could be connected conclusively to Room Four, Daniel or the murder.

Badu ordered the possibilities kept in a separate working table with columns for supporting evidence, contrary evidence and missing checks. The table was less dramatic than a suspect board, but it prevented the team from allowing one plausible interpretation to erase the others.

The Custody Interview

The staff members who had moved the carton were interviewed separately about the retrieval. Their accounts agreed on the broad sequence: authorisation, collection, transport, seal check and receipt at the records unit. They differed on a minor detail about who had held the trolley at a corridor turn.

Badu did not treat the difference as deception. People often remembered the task's purpose better than the exact movement of their hands. The transport log and security camera stills were reviewed alongside the statements, but the camera angle did not show every part of the corridor.

The green receipt book was photographed in its original position before it was removed from the carton. Its binding was intact, and the entry under review appeared on a page with several ordinary transactions. The reference number could be read only in part. A specialist suggested two possible readings and declined to choose between them.

The custody sequence from retrieval onward was now well documented. The book's earlier history was not. Badu marked that difference in the report so that a sound modern chain of custody would not be mistaken for proof of what had happened decades earlier.

The Locksmith's Limit

The locksmith's report included a diagram of the test cylinder and a note explaining that the duplicate key's

performance could vary with the lock's condition. Badu asked whether the key showed wear consistent with repeated use. The locksmith said that the marks were compatible with use, but they could not determine how often it had been used or which lock it had operated. Similar marks could arise from handling, storage, or use in more than one cylinder.

The team compared the key's exhibit number with the original collection form. The numbers matched, but a description of the key's ring had been abbreviated. The collecting officer confirmed that the ring had been photographed at the scene and that the photograph showed the same arrangement. The clarification was added as a signed supplement rather than a change to the original form.

Badu asked the locksmith to state the strongest conclusion the test could support. The locksmith answered that the duplicate could operate the test cylinder under some conditions. He could not say that it had opened the judge's study on the night of the murder. That would require evidence connecting this key to that lock and to the relevant time.

The answer disappointed the investigators who wanted a direct route from object to suspect. It also prevented the test from becoming a false certainty. Badu asked for the report to be summarised in plain language for the prosecution team, with the failed attempt included alongside the successful ones. The

key remained significant, but its significance was bounded by what the test had actually shown.

The Key on the Workbench

The locksmith asked Badu to bring the original lock and the duplicate key to his workshop, where he could test them on a padded bench under controlled conditions. The evidence officer sealed both items in separate containers and documented the handover. The locksmith signed for them, then waited until the officer had photographed the seals before opening either one.

The test showed that the duplicate key could turn the cylinder when held at a particular angle. It required more pressure than the working key, but it did operate the mechanism. The locksmith repeated the test several times, then asked another technician to try without being told what result was expected.

“That establishes compatibility,” the locksmith said. “It does not establish who made the key, who possessed it, or whether it was used on the night of the murder.”

The second technician obtained the same result but noticed that the lock’s wear pattern made the test less exact than it would have been on a new mechanism. The lock had been removed and stored for months. Its present condition could not recreate every condition at the scene.

Badu asked whether the key could have been copied from a different lock of the same type. The locksmith

said that possibility could not be excluded without records of the original key and the lock's installation. The duplicate's cut pattern was consistent with the cylinder, but consistency was not a history of ownership.

The evidence officer resealed the items and logged the time. Badu thanked the locksmith for refusing to turn a mechanical result into a personal identification. On the drive back, his colleague remarked that the test had at least shown the key was not useless.

"Yes," Badu said. "It answers one question. We should not make it answer six."

The report would go into the murder file, separate from the records inquiry. If later evidence linked the key to a particular person or event, the team could assess that connection then. For now, the lock had demonstrated what it could do, not who had used it.

The Second Key Test

The second review was requested because the preliminary note had described the demonstration too broadly. Rather than treating it as a new test, the locksmith and an independent technician compared the original observations with the written report and identified precisely which attempts had succeeded, which had failed, and under what conditions. The duplicate had turned the comparable cylinder only when held at a slight angle; wear in the original lock limited how confidently the result could be

generalised. Neither examiner described the key as a murder weapon or attributed it to a particular person.

The evidence officer checked the exhibit label against the original collection form. The key’s number matched, but an early description called the ring brass while a later note called it bronze-coloured metal. The difference might reflect lighting or an imprecise description. The team photographed the ring under neutral light and asked the examiner to record the material only if it could be determined without damaging the item. A minor discrepancy was not ignored, but neither was it inflated into proof of tampering.

Adwoa brought a small box of household keys that had belonged to a relative who once worked in the building. She offered it voluntarily after learning that the team was testing the duplicate key. Badu did not allow the box to be searched casually. Each item was listed, photographed, and discussed with her before any comparison was made. None matched the exhibit closely enough to establish a connection. The box nevertheless helped document the family’s habit of keeping old keys long after their locks had been changed.

The locksmith’s final report separated direct observations from general possibilities and attached the second technician’s review as an independent check on the wording. Neither examiner claimed to know who had possessed the key. Badu placed the

report and its supplement in the murder file, not in the records inquiry. The two investigations might eventually intersect, but the current evidence did not justify merging them. A key that could operate a lock was not proof that it had been used on the night of the judge’s death.

On the way back to the station, an officer said the review had given them nothing new. Badu disagreed. It had narrowed the language the team could responsibly use and identified what comparison material would be needed before any stronger conclusion could be drawn. “A result that narrows a claim is still a result,” he said. “Our job is not to make the evidence more exciting. It is to make the account more accurate.”

The Receiving Clerk’s Inventory

The receiving clerk took Badu through the inventory process before allowing the team to open the relevant storage box. Each box had to be checked against a list, and any mismatch had to be documented before the lid was lifted. The clerk explained that an unlabelled box could not be treated as empty merely because its contents were not visible in the index. It might contain mixed records, duplicates, or papers awaiting classification.

Inside the first box, the team found several unrelated files and a packet of blank forms. The

second contained correspondence from a later period. The third had a damaged label whose final digit was difficult to read. None contained the missing page. Badu asked that the boxes be resealed and returned to their recorded positions, and the clerk signed the inventory showing exactly what had been examined.

Mabel asked whether the damaged label could have been misread in the earlier index. The clerk said it was possible, but the index had been created by a different team and could not be corrected without a documented review. They photographed the label and submitted a request for the original accession sheet. The work added another step to the inquiry, yet it also prevented the team from assuming that a similar number meant the right file.

Before the storage room was locked, the clerk pointed out a shelf reserved for uncatalogued transfers. It had been used during a period of staffing shortages, but no surviving record showed whether the disputed bundle had ever been placed there. Badu asked for a controlled search of that shelf at the next scheduled inventory. They left with no missing page, but with a documented account of the boxes checked and a precise next step.

CHAPTER SEVENTEEN — THE MISSING ATTACHMENT

The register did not say what had been taken. That was the first fact Kwame Badu wrote at the top of his notebook, and the one he repeated whenever the investigation drifted toward a satisfying answer. The absence of an attachment did not establish that a document had been stolen; an empty space did not establish that the fifth copy had ever been there. The distinction was frustrating, but frustration had never been evidence.

The restricted-return register arrived at the station in a sealed records pouch shortly after ten. The archives officer, Mr Koomson, watched Badu compare the seal number with the transfer form before signing. He seemed relieved by the formality. The register had been kept in a locked cabinet at the records office, but the cabinet's history was incomplete. One key had been replaced, a second was shared between two desks, and the old key-control book stopped several years before the period under review.

"I can confirm the register came from our cabinet," the archives officer said. "I cannot confirm every person who had access to the cabinet over the years."

"That is the answer I need," Badu replied. "Not a better answer than the records can support."

The relevant page contained a sequence of entries in faded blue ink. One entry referred to a committee file returned under a restricted code. A second line, written in a different hand, recorded an attachment number. The number had been crossed out and replaced. There was no explanatory initial beside the correction, and the register did not identify the attachment by title.

Badu asked the document examiner to photograph the page under ordinary and angled light. He requested no conclusion about authorship until the ink, paper, and correction could be assessed. The examiner warned that the age and quality of the register might limit what could be learned. A photograph could preserve the visible marks; it could not conjure the missing context.

Mabel Owusu arrived after lunch carrying her own notes from the committee inquiry. She had found a typed inventory in a retired clerk’s papers. Its final line listed “attachment pending” beside the same broad file reference. The sheet had no official stamp, and the clerk could not remember whether it had been a working draft or a copy made for personal reference.

“It fits the register,” Mabel said.

“It may fit it,” Badu answered. “That is not the same as confirming it.”

They placed the inventory beside the register photograph. The reference codes were similar but not

identical. One could be an earlier format; it could also refer to a neighbouring file. The inventory did not name Room Four, Daniel, the murder, or a fifth copy. Its importance was narrower: someone had recorded an attachment as pending, and the final destination of that attachment remained unclear.

Mabel did not argue. The temptation to make the papers speak more plainly than they did was familiar to her. She had watched a tentative recollection harden into a confident statement because a summary removed the words “I think”. She would not repeat that mistake simply because the weaker version made a better headline.

Badu requested the original inventory from the clerk’s family, with consent, and arranged for its receipt to be documented. He also asked the records office for the relevant file’s movement slips, dispatch book, and any surviving list of attachments. Each request was limited to the record series and date range that could reasonably contain the material. He would not let the search expand into an indiscriminate trawl merely because the case had become politically uncomfortable.

By late afternoon, the first response arrived: the dispatch book for the relevant month had a gap. Two pages were missing from the bound volume, but the binding showed no clear sign of recent removal. The office had no reliable inventory from the time the book was transferred between departments. The gap might

have been old, administrative, or deliberate. On the evidence available, it could not yet be called an act of concealment.

“Everyone sees a gap and wants to put a person inside it,” Badu told his team. “We first establish when the gap appeared, who had access, and whether another copy exists.”

A junior investigator reported that the anonymous sender had contacted Mabel again. This time the message included a photograph of a torn corner of paper bearing the words “…attachment to follow”. No date, file number, signature, or surrounding page was visible. The sender claimed it proved that Ofori had ordered the attachment removed.

Badu studied the image without touching the keyboard. It could be a genuine fragment, a fragment from another file, or a piece selected to encourage a particular conclusion. Even if genuine, the words did not identify who had written them or why the attachment had not followed. He instructed the team to preserve the message and metadata, seek the original through a documented channel, and avoid forwarding the image beyond those who needed to examine it.

Mabel asked whether the fragment should be published. Badu said the decision was hers, but the investigative facts were clear: publication could not turn an anonymous assertion into authentication. She

chose to describe the broader question of missing public records without naming a person on the strength of the image. She would wait for evidence that could withstand scrutiny.

That evening, the examiner returned a preliminary note. The correction in the register was visible, but there was insufficient basis to attribute it to Ofori or to any other named person. The examiner also cautioned that the photographed fragment could not be matched to the register from the image alone. The findings were modest. They were also useful because they closed off an easy but unsupported claim.

Badu added a new line to the board: ATTACHMENT — EXISTENCE INDICATED, CONTENT AND DESTINATION UNKNOWN. Under it he listed the register entry, the unverified inventory, the dispatch-book gap, and the anonymous fragment as separate items. None was allowed to stand in for another.

The murder board remained on the opposite wall. Ofori's influence over restricted circulation was a legitimate line of inquiry, but it did not prove that he removed this attachment, altered the register, or killed Judge Agyeman. The duplicate study key established a possible method of access, not the identity of the person who used it. The fifth copy remained unlocated, and even its precise relationship to the missing attachment was not established.

Before departing, Badu called the archives officer once more. He asked whether any transfer receipt had ever been kept separately from the register. Koomson paused, then remembered a small receipt book used during a later office reorganisation. He could not promise it covered the right year. It was stored in an off-site carton whose catalogue described it only as “miscellaneous returns”.

Badu wrote down the carton number and arranged a witnessed retrieval for the following morning. A lead, not a solution. A record to check, not a verdict. For the first time that day, the next step was concrete enough to follow without pretending the destination was already known.

The Enclosure Table

The evidence team set up a temporary examination table in a room with controlled access. The task was modest: compare the enclosure counts on three surviving forms with the count recorded in the accession ledger. No one expected the exercise to identify the fifth copy, but the team needed to know whether the numbers had been copied consistently from one form to another.

A records analyst named Owusu placed each form beneath a clear protective sheet and read the fields aloud. The first form listed three enclosures. The second listed a packet and an attachment but left the total blank. The third carried a handwritten four that

might have been changed from another digit. None named the missing schedule.

Badu asked the analyst to distinguish the original marks from later annotations. Owusu explained that some differences could be due to separate clerks completing separate forms, while others might reflect a correction. The paper did not reveal the reason for every change.

They compared the reference numbers. Two shared a prefix and a date, but the final characters differed. One could have been transcribed incorrectly; the other could have belonged to a related file. The team could not choose between those possibilities without a register that linked the references.

Mabel, observing from the marked line, asked whether the discrepancy itself was unusual. Owusu said that incomplete fields occurred in the surviving records, but the sample was too small to estimate how common the problem had been across the entire office. A handful of forms could show that a discrepancy existed; they could not establish a pattern by themselves.

The analyst completed a comparison sheet with three columns: matching features, differing features, and unresolved questions. He signed it and attached photographs of the forms. Badu asked him not to write “missing enclosure” where the document only showed an empty count field. The difference mattered: an

empty field might mean a count was not entered, not that something had been removed.

When the session ended, the forms were resealed. The team had established that the paperwork was inconsistent. It had not established whether the inconsistency resulted from error, a later amendment, or deliberate action. The next step was to find an independent record of the packet’s contents at the moment it was first sealed. If that record no longer existed, the limit would have to remain part of the conclusion.

Desk C at Closing Time

Mrs. Tetteh took Badu to Registry Desk C near the end of the working day. The counter had been replaced, but the room’s layout still allowed several departments to submit incoming packets through the same point. A clerk could receive an item, stamp its arrival and route it onward without knowing its full contents.

They reviewed the intake procedure with two current employees. Both explained that the destination field could be filled in by the sending office or completed after triage, depending on the paperwork. The old entry contained no initials clear enough to identify the person who completed it.

Badu asked whether the reference number might have been reused. The employees said duplicate or similar references were possible when departments used

different numbering systems. They could not determine whether that had happened in this case.

The visit made Desk C more important as a place to investigate, but not as a place to assign blame. Badu requested examples of neighbouring entries and the applicable procedure manual. He left with a better understanding of the intake process and no new certainty about the packet's contents.

The Receiving Office — Initial Index

The receiving office responded to Badu's request with a partial index and a note that several older boxes had not yet been catalogued. The reference number appeared once, but the description beside it was abbreviated to "review papers". There was no attached list of contents and no sign-out record for the particular day the investigators were interested in.

Badu requested access to the box under the office's normal procedure. He did not ask staff to search for "the fifth copy", because that phrase might lead them to interpret unrelated material through the investigation's theory. Instead, he supplied the reference number, the date range, and the originating unit. The office agreed to arrange a supervised search when the storage team became available.

Mabel asked whether the partial index proved that a bundle had reached the receiving office. Badu said it supported the existence of a reference in the index, but the missing sign-out record meant the actual

contents and movement still required verification. A catalogue entry could survive after a file had been moved, split, or misdescribed.

The request gave the team a new location to examine, but it also introduced a delay. The storage staff had other work, and the old boxes could not be opened without an inventory. Badu accepted the timetable and recorded the request formally. The delay was frustrating, yet it preserved the integrity of the search. A hurried inspection that disturbed the boxes or lost their order could destroy the very context they hoped to recover.

The Clerk's Copy of the Inventory

The retired clerk arrived carrying a folder that had been kept in a drawer at home. He did not claim that it contained the missing attachment. He said only that it included a typed inventory he had prepared during a handover, and that one line had bothered him for years because the reference was never completed.

Badu asked him to leave the folder closed until the evidence officer could photograph its condition and record how it had been brought to the station. The clerk agreed, although he looked impatient with the formality. “I have waited long enough to show somebody,” he said.

The inventory listed routine files, several boxes of returned material, and one item marked “attachment pending.” No title, author, or destination accompanied

the entry. The paper bore no official stamp, and the clerk could not recall whether he had typed it before or after the handover meeting.

“Why keep it?” Mabel asked.

“Because it was my copy of work I had done. I kept other lists too. I did not think it would matter to anyone.”

Badu asked whether the phrase referred to a document that had not arrived, an attachment not yet counted, or an item awaiting approval. The clerk said all three uses were possible in his experience. He had not been told what the attachment was, and he did not want to supply a meaning from hindsight.

The team compared the inventory’s date range with the surviving dispatch book. The dates were compatible, but not close enough to prove that the two documents described the same transaction. The clerk’s copy would be retained as a lead, with its provenance limitations attached to every future reference.

When he left, the clerk asked whether he had helped. Badu told him the document had given them a testable lead. “That is different from an answer,” the clerk said.

“It is,” Badu replied. “But a testable lead is more useful than a confident guess.”

The Receiving Office — Supervised Carton Examination

The receiving office supplied a partial index and authorised a supervised examination of the relevant

carton. Staff photographed the label and shelf position before opening it. Inside lay routine correspondence, transfer slips, and a small bundle of forms tied with cotton tape. Nothing was labelled the fifth copy. Badu asked the archivist to preserve the bundle's order while the team recorded each document in place.

One receipt referred to an attachment that had not been counted at intake. The entry was written in a hand different from the main form, but the difference could reflect a second clerk completing the count. A nearby page recorded the arrival of another packet with a similar reference number. The two entries might be related, or the code might have been reused. The team photographed both and requested the codebook in force at the time.

The archivist explained that receiving staff sometimes recorded a packet before checking each enclosure. A later count could correct the first entry, and the correction might appear in a separate book. If the separate book had not survived, the first record could look inconsistent. This was a plausible explanation for the discrepancy, not a finding about this particular packet. Badu asked for examples of corrected counts from unrelated files to test whether the same pattern existed.

Mabel noticed a note that read “return to origin after review”. The phrase did not name the origin, identify the reviewer, or state whether the return had occurred. She asked the archivist to explain how such

notes were usually completed. The archivist showed her examples with a destination stamp and a second receipt. The disputed entry lacked those details. Its incompleteness was now specific, but its cause remained unknown.

The team found a transfer sheet bearing the initials of a desk officer whose appointment dates could be verified. The initials looked similar to those on the disputed page, but the examiner cautioned that a short mark was not enough for attribution. Badu requested more known samples and instructed the team not to ask the officer to explain the entry before the independent comparison was complete. A premature interview might shape the officer’s memory or alert other witnesses to the exact question.

Before the carton was closed, the archivist read the inventory aloud while the evidence officer checked each item against the photographs. The process took longer than expected, but the final count matched the recorded count for the current examination. That established the custody of the material from this point onward. It did not reconstruct every earlier movement. Badu signed the receipt and added one more question to the case plan: where, if anywhere, was the second count recorded?

CHAPTER EIGHTEEN — THE CHAIN OF CUSTODY

The carton arrived at the records unit just after ten, carried by two staff members who had signed the retrieval form before leaving the off-site store. It was not the sort of box that announced a revelation. Its cardboard had softened at the corners, and an old strip of tape crossed the lid beneath a newer inventory label. The catalogue described it as miscellaneous returns, administrative reorganisation, year uncertain.

Badu watched the seal being photographed before anyone touched it. The store supervisor read the carton number aloud, checked it against the retrieval authorisation, and signed beside the time. A records officer who had not taken part in the search witnessed the opening. The procedure was deliberately slow. Haste rarely drew criticism until someone asked where an item had been, who had handled it, or whether the object under examination was the one first recovered.

Inside were bundles of receipts, a cracked stapler, two blank forms, and a narrow book with a green cover. Its label had faded to a few surviving letters. The records officer photographed the contents in place, then lifted each bundle separately. The green book was not immediately called the receipt book they wanted. It

was described, measured, and entered as an item requiring examination.

“If it is the right book, we can say it was in this carton when the carton was opened,” Badu said. “We cannot yet say it was kept there continuously, or that it contains the transaction we are looking for.”

Waiting beyond the authorised work area, Mabel recorded the distinction. The investigation had taught her a difficult lesson: an authentic document did not automatically prove the claim attached to it. A record could be incomplete; a copy could preserve the words while leaving the circumstances of their creation unknown. A missing item could matter without being the one everyone hoped to find.

The green book contained dated entries, though several dates were difficult to read. Some receipts had been torn from the binding. Others remained, their carbon impressions faint but visible under angled light. The records officer did not let Badu turn the pages freely. They worked through them one at a time, noting the page number, condition, and any apparent gap. A conservator would be consulted before anything was flattened or separated.

At first the entries were routine: stationery, transport, file transfers, replacement folders. Then, on a page near the end of a quarter, one line recorded a sealed packet delivered to the central registry. The description was abbreviated. Its destination code could

be compared with other entries, but it did not identify Room Four or name a person. In the margin, a reference number had been crossed out and rewritten. The second hand looked different, though the records officer warned that appearance alone could not establish authorship.

Badu felt no triumph. A small fact could become a large story long before it earned that status. He requested a photograph, a transcription that marked every uncertainty, and an independent comparison with the surviving dispatch register. He also asked for an examination of possible later additions. The request did not presume fraud; the date and integrity of the entry simply mattered.

The reference number resembled the one in the unauthenticated inventory, but resemblance was not identity. One digit could be a seven or a one. The entry fell within a broad period of administrative movement, not on a proven date of removal. Its destination code referred to a department whose records had since been reorganised twice. The limitations did not make the entry useless. They set the boundary of what the team could responsibly infer.

“Could this be the fifth copy?” Mabel asked when Badu briefed her later, in a room where the documents remained out of sight and the notes were kept in a controlled file.

“It may refer to a packet. We don’t know what it contained, whether the number denotes a copy, a bundle, or an internal sequence, or whether this entry has any connection to the fifth copy.”

“But it is the first record that may show a transfer.”

“It is a record of an entry that may show a transfer. That wording matters.”

Mabel looked at her notes. She had once thought the most important part of reporting was finding the sentence that made the pieces fall into place. Now she understood how easily a sentence could force separate facts into a pattern that did not exist. The public deserved more than a compelling theory; it deserved to know which parts had survived contact with the evidence.

The document examiner arrived that afternoon and reviewed the photographs and original under controlled lighting. The differences between the crossed-out reference and its replacement might reflect separate pens, varying pressure, or writing done at different times. Appearance alone could not identify either writer. Ink analysis might show whether the marks were consistent with the book’s age; even then, it would not establish authorship or motive.

The examiner noted that the book’s present location did not settle its earlier history. The carton inventory was incomplete, and no full item-by-item schedule

survived for its transfer to off-site storage. Handling had been documented from that morning onward; the earlier chain could be reconstructed only in part. Badu asked that the report state both limits clearly.

A second comparison yielded a limited but useful result. The surviving dispatch register used the same destination code in other entries from the period. The code led to a registry desk, not directly to a room or an individual. The entry supported the possibility that a packet had been logged for transfer. It did not establish its contents, confirm its arrival, or identify anyone who handled it afterward.

Badu added a sheet to the records board: POSSIBLE TRANSFER ENTRY — CONTENT AND FINAL DESTINATION UNCONFIRMED. Beneath it he listed the green receipt book, the dispatch-register comparison, the incomplete storage inventory, and the unauthenticated typed note. The overlap justified further searching, not a conclusion.

Ofori's name remained on a separate page. His influence over restricted circulation still warranted investigation, but nothing in the green book identified him as the person who logged, carried, altered, or received the packet. The study-key inquiry remained separate too. A possible route into the judge's study could not identify the person who used it, just as a possible transfer record could not identify the packet's contents.

That evening, the anonymous sender contacted Mabel again. The message contained no new document, only a sentence: “The book proves the fifth copy was taken.” Mabel did not publish it. She preserved the original message, recorded its arrival time, and forwarded it with its available metadata through the agreed reporting channel. The sender’s certainty exceeded the evidence they had examined, which gave Mabel another reason to treat the claim cautiously.

Badu authorised the next step: trace the destination code through the registry’s surviving accession books and identify whether any related receiving ledger existed. The request would be narrow, with the reference number recorded as uncertain. He also asked the examiner to retain the original photographs and issue a report that separated direct observations from interpretations.

As the office emptied, Badu stood before the board. For weeks, each gap had seemed to point towards a hidden hand. The gaps remained, but their limits were clearer: a missing attachment, an incomplete storage inventory, an uncertain number in a receipt book. They might connect. They might not.

He wrote one final line beneath the new sheet: CHAIN DOCUMENTED FROM RETRIEVAL; EARLIER CUSTODY INCOMPLETE. It was not the answer he wanted. It was the answer the evidence could bear.

They had not found the fifth copy, assuming it existed in the form they imagined. For the first time, however, the team had an administrative trail it could test—and a clear account of what the trail could not establish.

The Sealed Table

By the time the archive supervisor arrived, Badu had asked for the records room to be cleared of everyone who had no assigned role in the examination. The request irritated two senior clerks, who had expected the inquiry to be a brief formality. He explained that a chain of custody was not a ceremony performed after a document became important. It was the ordinary discipline that made the document worth trusting.

The packet lay inside a transparent evidence sleeve. Everyone present signed the access log before the seal was checked against the photographs taken at collection. The number matched, and the sleeve's corners showed no obvious damage. The check documented the packet's condition when it entered their custody; it could not establish whether the papers had always been complete.

The archive supervisor placed the transfer sheet beside the packet without allowing the two to touch. "This records what the office says it transferred," she said. "It does not prove what the box contained on the day it was first packed."

"And the person who received it?" Badu asked.

“They can confirm receipt of a box and the contents listed on the form. If the list was already wrong when the box left the first office, the receiving signature cannot correct it.”

Mabel watched the exchange from behind the marked line on the floor. The answer was unsatisfying, but it was precise. The investigation had reached the point where a signature could no longer be treated as a magic stamp that made every earlier step true.

An assistant examiner photographed the packet from several angles, then recorded the visible marks on each sheet. A faint impression on the reverse of one page resembled the tail of a numeral. Under magnification it remained a partial mark, consistent with more than one character. The examiner refused to call it a five.

Badu recorded the result in his notebook: “Impression present; reading indeterminate.” He underlined indeterminate. It solved nothing, but it made the limit difficult to overlook.

A Quiet Visit to the Former Driver

Yaw Ofori agreed to meet Badu at a community centre rather than at the station. He arrived with a folder of medical appointments and old employment papers, and he asked at once whether the interview concerned the judge’s murder or the missing records. Badu told him that the questions would remain separate unless evidence established a connection.

“People have already joined them,” Ofori said. “They say I moved papers, therefore I know about the judge. They say I knew the judge, therefore every missing paper is mine.”

“That is why we are asking you questions rather than repeating the claims.”

Ofori opened his folder and produced an employment card showing that he had worked as a driver for a government office during part of the relevant period. The card was worn and the photograph had faded, but the dates were legible enough to guide a request for the personnel file. It did not show which journeys he had made or what he had carried.

He remembered being asked to deliver sealed packets between buildings. Sometimes he was given a receipt to sign; sometimes the receiving clerk signed a trip sheet later. He could not recall every delivery. He said the vehicles were shared and the route could change if a road was blocked or a senior officer requested another stop.

“Do you remember Registry Desk C?” Badu asked.

“I remember the desk code. I don’t remember a packet with your reference number.”

“Do you remember Room Four?”

“I remember a room number, but I can’t swear it was the same Room Four. Offices change their numbering.”

Ofori described one day when a clerk refused to accept a packet because the enclosure count on the cover did not match the count on the receipt. The driver had waited while the paperwork was corrected. He could not give a date or identify the packet. The memory might explain why he had become careful about receipts, but it did not identify the item under investigation.

Mabel asked whether he had kept any personal notes of deliveries. Ofori said he had a small notebook from his final year, but it mostly contained fuel totals and mileage. He had not brought it because he did not want to hand over private financial information without understanding the request. Badu told him the team could issue a narrow written request, identify the relevant date range, and discuss redactions with him before copying unrelated pages.

Ofori seemed surprised by the offer. “You are not going to take the whole book?”

“Not unless there is a lawful reason and the scope is properly authorised. We should ask for what we need.”

He agreed to consider the request and said he would speak with his adviser. Before leaving, he made one final point: a driver could carry a sealed packet without knowing its contents, and a signature might prove delivery without proving what had been placed inside.

Badu treated the point as a description of the procedure and a reminder of its limits. Ofori's account neither cleared him of every possible role nor established wrongdoing. It identified records the team could seek: the personnel file, trip sheets, fuel logs, and—if Ofori chose to provide it under agreed terms—the notebook.

On the way back to the station, Mabel asked whether Ofori had been evasive.

"He was careful," Badu said. "That may be self-protection. It may be ordinary caution. We should not confuse the two until we have something to compare."

They had gained neither a confession nor a name. They had gained a route through the paperwork, and a witness who had a reason to cooperate without being promised an outcome.

The Second Witness to the Seal

After the green receipt book had been examined, Badu asked the records unit to locate the employee who had witnessed the carton's sealing before it was moved to the off-site store. The employee, now a supervisor in another department, remembered the process only in outline. She had checked the carton number and signed a transfer sheet, but she could not recall its contents.

The transfer sheet survived in a separate administrative file. Its seal number matched the number recorded at retrieval. That supported the

conclusion that the carton delivered to the evidence room was the carton listed on the form. It did not establish that every item inside had remained in the same position throughout the years in storage.

“Was the carton opened at any time?” Badu asked.

“Not while I was responsible for it. I cannot speak for the period before it reached my section.”

The supervisor explained that older cartons had sometimes been moved between stores during renovations. Each move should have generated a transfer note, but she could not guarantee that every note had survived. She gave the team the location of a second ledger that might record the move, then signed a statement distinguishing what she had personally witnessed from what the paperwork suggested.

Badu compared the seal record with the store’s annual inventory. The numbers aligned for two years, then the inventory switched to a grouped reference. The change might have been a routine system update. It created a gap in the item-level trail, but no evidence showed that the carton had been opened during that interval.

Mabel asked whether the receipt book could now be described as authentic. The evidence officer said its physical existence and retrieval history were documented, but its earlier custody remained incomplete. The book could be studied; each entry still needed to be assessed on its own merits.

Keeping those limits explicit would make the final report longer and less dramatic. Badu considered that a fair price for accuracy.

The Second Truth, Not the Last

The specialist's report arrived with images, scale references and a list of limitations. The faint impressions on the circular could be described, but the missing letters could not be restored with confidence. A phrase that looked like a reference to an attachment under one light became an indistinct series of strokes under another.

Badu read the report twice before taking it to the team. He wanted them to understand the difference between an image that had been enhanced and a message that had been recovered. Enhancement made existing marks easier to see; it did not supply letters that were no longer present.

Mabel asked whether the report changed what she could responsibly publish. Badu said it supported a narrow statement: an earlier sheet had left impressions on the circular. It did not support naming the document, the author or the person who had handled it.

That evening, Badu removed the most dramatic hypothesis from the board and replaced it with three smaller questions: What kind of sheet had rested on the circular? When had the impression been made? Could any independent record identify the paper? The

case had moved forward, but not toward a final accusation. It had moved toward a more precise question.

The Prosecution Conference's Objection

The prosecutor asked the investigators to present the strongest alternative explanation for every major item in the case. Badu began with the duplicate key: it could operate the test cylinder, but the test did not establish that it had opened the relevant door. Mabel described the corridor witness: the person had seen a figure under uncertain lighting, but could not identify the face. The prosecutor listened and asked what evidence would remain if both items were removed from the argument.

Badu listed the records, the timeline, the statements, and the unresolved gaps. Some entries supported the existence of an administrative process; others showed only that a person had been present in the building. The prosecutor said a coherent narrative could not be built by treating every ambiguous detail as a brick pointing in the same direction. Each item needed a clear purpose and a fair description of its limits.

They reviewed the anonymous message next. Its content had guided the search, but its author was unknown and its claims had not been

independently verified. Mabel argued that the message could explain why the team examined a particular reference, but it could not be used as proof that the reference was genuine. The prosecutor agreed and asked that the case chronology distinguish leads from evidence.

The meeting ended without a charging recommendation. Badu was frustrated by the unanswered questions, but the prosecutor's challenge had exposed where the investigation relied on implication. The team left with specific tasks: confirm the receiving-office index, seek the original attendance sheet, and establish independent provenance for any copy that surfaced. Refusing premature certainty had not weakened the case. It had defined what a defensible case would require.

The Question of What Could Be Said

The prosecutor asked Mabel to draft two short summaries: one for investigators and one that could safely be shared publicly if a later announcement became necessary. The first could describe unresolved leads in detail; the second had to avoid identifying people through implication or overstating the strength of the documents. Mabel found the second version harder because every

sentence had to survive being read without the context of the full file.

She removed a phrase that described the ledger as a likely link and replaced it with wording that stated only that the ledger was under examination. She also removed a sentence that placed Ofori at a specific point in the building when the visitor register confirmed only his arrival. The edits made the summary less exciting, but they prevented the public account from becoming more definite than the evidence.

The prosecutor reviewed the revised wording and asked that the same discipline be applied internally. Working theories could guide searches, but they should be labelled as theories wherever they appeared in the case file. Mabel added a note identifying which statements were confirmed, which were reported by others, and which remained hypotheses. The exercise gave the team a shared language for uncertainty at the moment when pressure to announce progress was increasing.

The Initial Prosecution Conference

At the prosecution conference, Badu separated the material into three groups: the murder inquiry, the records inquiry, and possible points of intersection. The prosecutor asked him to distinguish

independently supported facts from hypotheses. Badu set out the envelope's route, the disputed register entries, the key test, and the limits of the witness statements. He did not imply that several uncertain pieces became conclusive simply by being placed together.

The prosecutor challenged the team on the phrase "fifth copy". Was there proof that five copies had existed, or was the phrase a label used by the anonymous sender? Badu acknowledged that the number had not been independently verified. The case file contained references that might point toward an additional copy, but the original source and meaning were unresolved.

They then reviewed the murder timeline. The stopped clock could not establish the time of death, and the duplicate key test did not identify who entered the study. The prosecutor asked what evidence tied Ofori specifically to the killing. The answer was that his account and some administrative actions required further checking, but the current record did not justify treating suspicion as proof.

The conference ended with a revised work plan. The prosecutor requested the original records, a clearer timeline for the final hours, and a written explanation of each witness's opportunity to observe. Badu left with fewer dramatic claims and more precise tasks. The case had not been weakened by the questions. It

had been given a clearer standard against which the next discoveries would be judged.

The Leading Theory Under Challenge

The prosecutor asked the team to present the strongest case against its own leading theory before presenting the evidence that supported it. Badu began with the calendar and the disputed transfer, then listed the limitations: no authenticated order, no proven link between the packet and the fifth copy, and no established connection to the murder timeline. The prosecutor listened without interruption and asked the team to explain what would change their view. The question forced them to identify evidence they had not yet obtained.

One investigator argued that the combination of irregular records and Ofori's authority was too striking to be coincidence. The prosecutor asked whether authority established handling, whether handling established intent, and whether intent concerning records established responsibility for the judge's death. Each question required a separate answer. The investigator eventually acknowledged that the chain had gaps. Badu recorded the concession as a useful correction rather than a defeat.

The prosecutor returned to the proposed connection between the records and the killing. No evidence yet placed the key, the missing attachment, and Ofori in the same event. The team would continue each line of

inquiry while looking for a reliable point of connection, rather than treating proximity in the case file as proof of relationship.

Mabel was invited to explain what had been published and what remained withheld. She said the newsroom had reported the existence of an alleged archival copy and the fact that its provenance was under examination. It had not named a fifth child, declared a cover-up, or accused a person of murder. The prosecutor noted that careful reporting could protect the investigation, but reminded her that even a restrained article could influence witnesses if it revealed too much about the evidence.

The conference produced a revised task list: obtain the original accession ledger, verify the receiving-office initials, seek independent analysis of the overwritten count, and locate the missing schedule if it still existed. The prosecutor also required a written account of every proposed link between the records inquiry and the murder. Each link had to state its source, the inference drawn, and a plausible alternative. Any theory that failed that test would remain unproven.

After the meeting, Badu stayed behind to read the revised plan. He felt the familiar pressure to return to the team with a clear direction and a decisive suspect. Instead, he carried out a plan with more questions than answers. The prosecutor had not dismissed the case; she had required it to become more exact. Badu folded the pages and returned to the station,

determined that the next step should produce a verifiable fact, even if that fact complicated the story.

The Question Before the Answer

Late in the afternoon, Badu received a call from a number that had appeared once before in the case log. The caller did not identify himself and did not repeat the earlier message. He said only that the team was asking the wrong question about the fifth copy. Badu asked what question they should be asking instead. The caller paused, then said, “Who needed it to exist?” before ending the call.

Badu treated the sentence as a lead, not a revelation. He preserved the call details, requested subscriber information through the lawful process, and recorded the words without attaching a theory to them. The phrase might describe an official need, a private motive, or an attempt to divert the inquiry. The caller might have direct knowledge or merely be following public reports. Its value would depend on whether it led to independently verifiable facts.

Mabel was told only what the team could responsibly share. She asked whether the call changed the story. Badu said it changed the questions on the board, not the evidence. They discussed the difference between a document’s intended function and the reason someone later wanted it preserved. A copy could be made for routine administration, protection against a lost original, or an improper purpose. The same physical

act could serve different motives, and motive could not be established from the existence of the copy alone.

The team reviewed known distribution procedures and identified several roles that might have had reason to keep an extra copy. A supervisor might retain an instruction; a receiving office might protect itself against a disputed transfer; a clerk might keep a reminder of unfinished work. These explanations were not necessarily equally likely, but the evidence did not yet justify ranking them. Badu asked the team to determine which could be tested against surviving schedules, approvals, or receipt books.

One officer proposed interviewing Ofori again about the anonymous call. Badu declined to use an unauthenticated message as the basis for a confrontational interview. They would first seek the original distribution schedule and compare it with verified records. If those checks produced a specific discrepancy, Ofori could be asked about that discrepancy and given a fair opportunity to respond. The sequence was slower than a direct accusation, but it reduced the risk that the investigation would become a reaction to the sender’s chosen words.

That night, Badu returned to the case board and wrote the caller’s question in a separate colour, labelled “unverified lead”. Beneath it he wrote three practical tasks: identify the authorised recipients, establish whether an extra copy was permitted, and locate independent evidence of the copy’s later movement.

He left the space for a name empty. The caller had offered a sentence designed to sound like an answer. Badu would accept it only if the records could turn it into a question with a verifiable result.

CHAPTER NINETEEN — THE ORDER BEHIND FIVE

The accession books were kept in a cabinet that had outlived three office renovations and at least two attempts to modernise the registry. Its drawers carried labels in different handwriting, and the newest index referred to a shelf that no longer existed. Badu had asked for the books by destination code, not by the phrase fifth copy. The phrase had become too powerful in too many mouths; it could direct a search before anyone had established what it meant.

The registry supervisor, Mrs. Tetteh, placed four ledgers on the table and explained that the books had been transferred during a reorganisation. Two were complete. One had a missing section. The fourth was a working index compiled later from records that survived. She signed the retrieval form and watched the evidence officer photograph each cover, spine, and page before examination began.

“If the code appears here, what does that give us?” Badu asked.

“A receiving point recorded under that code,” Tetteh said. “Not necessarily the individual who accepted a packet. Some desks logged items collectively. A clerk might enter a delivery on behalf of a unit.”

“And if it does not appear?”

“It could mean the packet never arrived. It could mean the relevant page is missing. It could mean the code was copied incorrectly. Absence from an incomplete book is not a complete history.”

Badu nodded. He had begun to value answers that narrowed a question without pretending to finish it.

The code appeared in the second ledger, in a column headed RECEIVED FROM. The entry was dated two days after the date recorded in the green receipt book. The reference numbers were similar, but not identical; in the later index, one character had been transcribed as a letter. The destination was Registry Desk C. The initials in the receiving column were too cramped to identify confidently.

The evidence officer photographed the page and prepared a measured transcription. Tetteh checked the notation against the registry's old practice manual. Desk C had served as a shared intake point for sealed administrative packets. It was neither Room Four nor a personal office. The entry supported the possibility that a packet had arrived at the desk; it did not establish the packet's contents or what happened after intake.

Mabel waited until Badu had confirmed that the documents could be discussed in general terms. She had learned not to ask for a conclusion while a record was still being handled. "Does this move us closer to the fifth copy?" she asked.

"It moves us closer to understanding the route of a packet," he replied. "The fifth copy is still a label attached to a theory. We need a record that connects the packet to a particular document, or a witness who can identify it from direct knowledge."

"Someone keeps insisting there was an order."

"An order should leave a trail: who issued it, who received it, what authority it claimed, and what action followed. We have not found that trail."

The anonymous sender's latest message had arrived before dawn: FIND THE ORDER BEHIND FIVE. No signature, no

supporting attachment, no explanation of how the sender knew an order existed. Mabel had passed it to Badu with the original timestamp and preserved the message on her device. It was a lead only in the limited sense that it suggested a question. It could not supply the answer.

Badu asked the records unit to search the circular register and the restricted-circulation log for orders issued during the relevant period. The request named the date range and the desk code. It did not name Ofori as the presumed author. He wanted the search broad enough to find an unexpected name and narrow enough to be auditable.

The first register contained routine instructions about sealed envelopes, temporary storage, and who could sign for materials after hours. Several entries used the phrase restricted circulation, but none referred to the fifth copy. One circular authorised a temporary hold on a group of committee papers pending review. The signatory’s name was legible, but the schedule identifying the papers was missing from the bound volume.

“Could that be it?” the junior investigator asked.

“It could be relevant,” Badu said. “That is not the same as being it.”

They ordered a preservation copy and began looking for the missing schedule in duplicate circular files. The signature on the circular was not Ofori’s. It belonged to an acting administrator who had since died. That fact did not clear Ofori of other conduct, but it prevented the team from forcing this particular order into a theory that did not fit the page.

In the afternoon, the acting administrator’s old assistant agreed to speak. She remembered that temporary holds were sometimes used when

committee papers contained personal information or when a review had not concluded. She did not remember this packet, this code, or a request from Ofori. Her recollection helped explain the procedure but could not identify a person or document. Badu recorded both its value and its limits.

Mabel returned to her newsroom with a story that was harder to headline than a secret order. A sealed packet might have reached a shared registry desk. A later circular had authorised a temporary hold on some committee papers, but its schedule was missing and its signatory was someone else. The two records might belong to the same administrative chain, or they might not. She wrote the facts, the gaps, and the questions still open. Her editor asked whether she could say the fifth copy had been deliberately hidden.

“Not honestly,” she said. “We can say the records are incomplete and that we are tracing a possible transfer. We cannot say the missing item was the fifth copy, or that anyone ordered it hidden.”

Her editor leaned back, disappointed but not dismissive. “Then make the uncertainty clear. Show readers what we know and what we don’t.”

That evening, Badu reviewed the two boards. Under THE MURDER, Ofori remained a person whose access, influence, and conduct required scrutiny in relation to Judge Agyeman’s death. Under THE RECORDS, the new evidence showed a possible route for a sealed packet, a receiving desk, and an incomplete schedule. There was still no reliable link between that packet and the murder scene, Daniel’s identity, Room Four, or the missing fifth copy.

He left the boards unconnected. Instead, he added a note beneath the registry entry: POSSIBLE ADMINISTRATIVE ROUTE; DOCUMENT IDENTITY UNPROVEN. Beneath the circular, he wrote: TEMPORARY HOLD ORDER; SCHEDULE MISSING; CONNECTION TO PACKET UNCONFIRMED.

A call came from the evidence officer. The preservation copy of the circular had revealed a faint impression on the reverse page, likely transferred from a sheet that had once rested against it. The impression was too incomplete to read, but its layout suggested a numbered attachment. They would need specialist imaging and a comparison with the surviving duplicate files before saying more.

Badu noted the next task and confirmed that the original page was back in its protective sleeve. The order behind five might exist. It might also be a story assembled from a number, a missing schedule, and an anonymous person’s insistence. Until the record could support more, he would not let the phrase become a verdict.

Outside, the city moved through its evening traffic, indifferent to the difference between a missing paper and a proven conspiracy. Badu switched off the office light, leaving the boards visible in the corridor glow. One investigation was still trying to establish who had killed a judge. The other was trying to establish where a packet had gone. He would not make either mystery easier by pretending they were the same.

The Clerk Who Kept a Diary

The retired clerk lived in a narrow house behind a row of shops, where traffic noise rose and fell through the

afternoon. She received Badu and Mabel at a small table and placed a worn diary between them. She had mentioned it during the first interview but had not brought it forward, explaining that it contained personal notes rather than official records.

“I wrote down things I was afraid I would forget,” she said. “Not everything. Not every day.”

Badu asked permission to examine only the dates relevant to the temporary-hold order. She agreed, but insisted that the diary remain in her possession while they made a supervised copy of the relevant pages. He accepted. The inquiry could not demand more than it had authority to take, and pressure would only make a cautious witness less reliable.

The entry for the date in question described a late instruction, a queue of files, and a disagreement about whether an enclosure list should travel with a packet. It named no document as the fifth copy. It did not mention Room Four. A short note at the bottom read: “Desk C — send back for proper count.”

Mabel read the line twice. “That could explain the overwritten number.”

“It could,” Badu said. “It could also describe a routine correction on another file.”

The clerk remembered being frustrated because the office was short-staffed. She could not recall who had given the instruction or whether the count had been corrected before the packet moved. She was certain

only that she had written the note herself, although even that would require comparison with other dated entries before a document examiner could offer an opinion.

When the interview ended, she asked whether her diary would be used to accuse someone. Badu told her the team would report what it showed and what it did not. He would not promise that no one would be questioned, but he could promise that an ambiguous note would not be presented as a confession.

Outside, Mabel said the diary gave them a human scene behind the bureaucracy: a tired clerk, a crowded desk, an instruction whose context had vanished. “It makes the gap understandable,” she said.

“Understanding why a gap might occur is not the same as proving that this is how it occurred,” Badu replied. “We can investigate both possibilities without choosing one early.”

The Copying Machine

The records office had retained a maintenance folder for its old photocopier, though no one could say whether the machine itself had survived the final relocation. The folder was kept among equipment invoices and service slips. Badu requested it after the document examiner explained that a paper’s appearance might be consistent with a process without revealing when or where the page had been produced.

The first technician who reviewed the folder was not the person who had serviced the machine. He was a facilities officer asked to help interpret the maintenance codes. He warned them that the entries were incomplete and that parts had been replaced over the years. A note marked “feed fault” could describe a jam, a worn roller, or a sensor problem; it did not establish that a particular sheet had passed through the machine.

Mabel read the entries aloud while the officer followed the dates. One service visit recorded that the copier had been moved from a public counter to a restricted room during renovation. The receiving signature was partly obscured by a stamp. Another entry noted a replacement drum, but the serial number was not included. There was no job log listing the documents copied on those dates.

“Could this prove the alleged fifth copy was printed here?” Mabel asked.

“No,” the officer said. “It proves that a copier was maintained and moved. It may help you understand what equipment was available, but there is no link to that page.”

Badu asked whether the maintenance folder could be compared with the renovation records and room plans. The officer said it could, although the old plans used different room names. They arranged for copies

to be made under supervision, keeping the original folder in the records office.

While the copies were being prepared, Mabel noticed a small note in the margin of a service sheet: “test pages retained.” The words were followed by a date and a set of initials. She pointed them out, but the officer could not say what the test pages were or whether they had been kept. A routine test might have involved blank sheets, alignment patterns, or a sample page supplied by the manufacturer.

Badu requested the relevant disposal records and any inventory of retained test sheets. He did not label the note as evidence of the fifth copy. It was a lead about a possible category of material, nothing more.

The office manager, who had been listening from the doorway, said the old copier had been used by several departments. “If you find a test sheet, it may have nothing to do with your case.”

“That is why we want the inventory,” Badu replied.

When the team left, Mabel carried the authorised copies in a sealed folder. She had expected the maintenance file to provide a technical shortcut. Instead, it had given them a history of equipment use, a missing inventory, and another question about how ordinary records were preserved or discarded.

“Every path takes us to another shelf,” she said.

“Then we document the shelf,” Badu answered. “If it leads nowhere, we say so. If it leads somewhere, we still test what we find.”

At the station, the team added the copier records to the records inquiry, not the murder timeline. Until a reliable connection emerged, the two boards would remain separate.

Desk C's Former Clerk

The former clerk who had worked at Registry Desk C was found through a staff association rather than the old telephone list. She agreed to an interview after receiving a written explanation of the inquiry. Her name was Mrs Naa Tetteh, and she brought a notebook in which she had recorded several procedural reminders from her final year at the desk.

She confirmed that Desk C had served as a shared intake point. Packets arrived from different offices and were sorted before being sent to the proper registry or returned for correction. The desk did not decide the contents of a packet, and its staff did not always know whether an envelope contained a single document or several attachments.

Badu showed her the accession entry without suggesting what it meant. Tetteh read the reference, then asked to see the page before and the page after it. The surrounding entries showed that the desk used similar abbreviations for unrelated transfers. The disputed entry could fit the routine pattern, although

its overwritten count was unusual enough to justify closer examination.

“Do you remember this packet?” Badu asked.

“No. I remember the desk. I remember the procedure. I cannot turn that into a memory of one envelope.”

She explained that a count might be changed when a packet was opened for an authorised check and found to contain fewer sheets than expected. It could also be changed when an intake clerk corrected a counting error. Either practice should have left a notation or initials, but the surviving copy did not show enough detail to establish what had happened here.

Tetteh offered to identify the handwriting used by the desk’s staff in routine entries, provided the team supplied verified samples and the comparison was handled by a qualified examiner. Badu accepted the offer as a possible next step, not as an informal identification.

The interview gave them a better understanding of the desk, but no knowledge of the packet’s contents. Badu added a question to the plan: locate the original accession ledger or a verified copy that preserved the overwritten count. Until then, Desk C remained a point in a process, not a destination proven to contain the fifth copy.

The Copyist’s Memory Exercise

The retired copyist returned with a box of blank practice sheets and demonstrated the sequence he had used when producing office duplicates. He asked the investigators not to treat his demonstration as a recreation of the disputed document. The equipment was not the same, and the paper differed. His purpose was to show how pressure, alignment, and repeated copying could alter the appearance of a page over time.

On the first sheet, the typed text appeared crisp. On the second generation, the letters softened and the signature block lost some definition. By the third, a faint shadow appeared near the lower margin. The copyist said the shadow could be caused by a mark on the glass, a folded corner, or a feature on the source page. The demonstration showed that a soft signature block was compatible with several processes and could not identify the person who signed.

Mabel asked how an extra copy might be stored if it had not been assigned its own catalogue number. The copyist described temporary folders, supervisor trays, and bundles held until a file was closed. He stressed that practices varied between offices and years. Badu asked whether he could identify the practice used for the disputed circular. The copyist

said he could not do so without a contemporary instruction or a record from that office.

The investigators documented the demonstration and kept the practice sheets separate from the evidence. The copyist's account gave them a plausible explanation for the appearance of a copy, but it did not prove that the circular was the fifth copy or that it had been deliberately withheld. That caution became more important as the investigation progressed: each new explanation expanded the range of possibilities, and each possibility had to be tested rather than adopted.

The Copyist's Account of Office Practice

At the follow-up appointment, the retired copyist described how duplicate requests had been handled in the offices where he worked. Carbon sheets, stencil duplicators, and later photocopiers were used at different times, sometimes under different rules. The process depended on the office, the volume of work, and the document's classification. He could describe the practices he remembered, but he could not establish which method had produced the disputed circular.

An additional sheet might be requested by a supervisor or receiving office, or kept temporarily while a file remained active. In some offices, the extra sheet travelled with a note; in others, it stayed in a working folder until the file was closed. The procedure varied by department and year, and he recalled no

universal rule that every file had to contain exactly four copies. The phrase “fifth copy” could therefore be a local label or a later description, but its meaning in this case remained unknown.

Badu asked whether the copyist could identify the practice used for the disputed circular. He said that would require contemporary instructions, a reliable production record, or physical examination of the original. A photograph could guide an examination, but it could not substitute for the document itself. He was willing to provide a statement about general office practice, provided it did not present his recollection as authentication.

Mabel recorded the limits of his account alongside the useful details. The interview had shown how an unlisted duplicate might arise in ordinary administration; it had not established that this circular was such a duplicate, that it was the fifth in a sequence, or that anyone had deliberately withheld it. The team added a search for contemporary production and distribution records to its plan.

The Junior Clerk’s Question

The junior clerk, Lydia Asare, had been waiting outside the registry supervisor’s office for nearly an hour when Badu asked whether she had time to speak. She said yes, then immediately asked if she should have brought her union representative. Badu told her she could request one at any point and that he wanted

to understand a process, not pressure her into an allegation.

Lydia explained that the accession book was often updated after boxes arrived, not while they were being unloaded. The staff member receiving a carton wrote the temporary location on a slip; another clerk later entered the permanent reference into the ledger. When the office was busy, the two steps could be separated by days.

“Could a box be moved before the ledger was updated?” Badu asked.

“Yes. If the temporary location changed, the slip should follow it. Sometimes it was pinned to the movement form. Sometimes it was put in the tray for the clerk doing the entry.”

“What happened if the slip went missing?”

“You searched. You asked the store. You checked the movement forms. If you couldn’t reconcile it, you wrote a note for the supervisor.”

“Was that always done?”

Lydia looked down at her hands. “I can’t say always.”

She remembered one occasion when a carton had been listed under a temporary code that no longer appeared on the wall map. The carton was found in a different room after a routine reorganisation. She did not know whether it contained restricted records, and she did not remember its exact number. She had never

reported it as missing because it had been located before the end of the shift.

Badu asked whether she would be willing to identify the old code on the map if shown a copy. She agreed, with the qualification that she might be mistaken after so many years.

“That’s fine,” he said. “We’ll record your uncertainty as carefully as your memory.”

Lydia looked surprised. “Most people want me to be certain.”

“Certainty isn’t a service you owe us.”

After she left, Badu requested the relevant movement forms and the version history of the room map. The conversation had provided a plausible administrative route for a delayed entry, but not an explanation for the particular discrepancy under investigation. It was another path to test, and another reminder that a badly kept record could conceal wrongdoing, imitate wrongdoing, or simply record an office that had been overwhelmed by its own procedures.

A Message at the Door

The message arrived as a paper slip pushed beneath the station’s public entrance door after the reception desk had closed. The security officer found it during a routine corridor check and did not open it. He called the duty supervisor, who photographed the slip where

it lay and followed the station's evidence-handling procedure.

The note contained one sentence: "You are searching the copies because the original was never meant to return." There was no signature, no date written by the sender, and no reference number. The paper was ordinary, and the writing did not immediately match any known sample.

Badu read the sentence once, then asked for the envelope or wrapper, if any, and a record of the location where the slip had been found. There was no envelope. The security camera showed a person approaching the entrance during a period when the public counter was closed, but the image did not provide a reliable identification. The person had not entered the building, and the camera angle did not clearly show the face.

Mabel was informed only after the note had been logged. She asked whether the wording changed the direction of the case.

"It gives us a new claim to assess," Badu said. "It does not tell us whether an original existed, what it contained, or whether the sender knows anything about it."

The team compared the wording with earlier messages. Some used the language of copies; others referred to orders and returns. There were similarities in tone, but no expert had established common

authorship. The phrase “never meant to return” could have been a deliberate clue, a guess based on public reporting, or an attempt to make the team pursue an attractive theory.

Badu ordered the note preserved and requested the available camera footage through the proper process. He did not send a reply or arrange a public challenge. Any response might encourage further messages without improving the evidence.

That night, he returned to the two case boards. He filed the note under “anonymous communications—unverified” on the records board and made no addition to the murder board. Until another fact connected the message to the killing, it belonged only on the records board.

The wording lingered in his mind, but he resisted turning it into a scene of its own. A message could be written to create an image in the reader’s head. The investigator’s job was to find out whether anything existed beyond the image.

The Copyist’s Practice — Comparing the Samples

The retired copyist brought a small sample book showing the different ways his office had produced duplicates. Some pages were carbon copies; others were photocopies; a few had been typed again from an earlier sheet. He warned that the samples demonstrated technique, not the origin of the disputed page. Badu asked him to describe the sequence of

work in each example, including the moments when a clerk might have produced an extra copy without changing the main register.

The copyist said an additional copy might be requested by a supervisor, a receiving office, or a clerk preparing for a review. Sometimes the extra sheet was retained until a file closed; sometimes it travelled separately with a note explaining its purpose. He could not recall a standard rule that limited every file to four copies. The phrase “fifth copy” might have been a local label, a later description, or a deliberate attempt to make the document sound unique.

He examined the alleged copy through a clear sleeve and pointed out that the signature block appeared softer than the typed text. That difference might reflect a copy made from an already signed page, a separate reproduction step, or the quality of the original. The appearance alone could not establish alteration. The copyist asked to see the original sheet and known examples before offering a more precise opinion. Badu thanked him and made clear that no one expected him to authenticate a document from a photograph alone.

The team compared the copyist’s examples with the alleged fifth copy’s layout. Several features were common to the department’s forms: the spacing of the heading, the order of the columns, and the placement of the reference number. Those features showed that the page could have been modelled on an authentic form. They did not show that it had been created by

the department or that its contents were accurate. The examiner would need to assess the physical and technical features separately.

Mabel asked the copyist whether staff ever made copies for personal protection. He said some employees kept notes of their own work because files moved between offices and responsibility could become disputed. That practice was not necessarily authorised, and he would not say how often it happened. A personal copy could preserve information, but it could also omit context or contain later annotations. The possibility widened the range of explanations without identifying a person who had acted in this case.

Before leaving, the copyist signed a statement limited to his experience and the general practices he remembered. He refused to sign a sentence that said the fifth copy was authentic. Badu approved the refusal. The investigation now had a better account of how duplicates might have been produced, but the origin of the disputed page remained open. The next task was to compare the physical object with a securely dated sample and establish whether any detail was genuinely distinctive.

The Ledger in Storage: Full Examination

At the scheduled inventory, the storage team opened the uncatalogued-transfer shelf under supervision. The boxes were arranged by arrival

period, not by department, and several labels had been rewritten after water damage. Badu asked the clerk to read each label aloud before moving the boxes, while another officer recorded the original shelf position. They were careful not to rearrange the sequence, because the placement itself might later help explain how the records had been stored.

Halfway through the shelf, they found a thin ledger wrapped in brown paper. Its title was incomplete, and the first visible page belonged to a different administrative series. The clerk did not call it the missing book. She assigned a temporary inventory number and asked that the ledger be examined at a clear table. Mabel photographed the wrapping before it was removed, including a small tear that might have predated the storage period.

The ledger contained a series of receipt numbers, several crossed out and rewritten. One number resembled the reference under investigation, but the final digit was damaged. The specialist warned that a resemblance could result from similar handwriting or a worn impression. Badu ordered a high-resolution image and requested the accession sheet before drawing any connection. No one was allowed to describe the find to colleagues as the fifth copy.

When the box was closed, the team signed the inventory and recorded the ledger's temporary location. The discovery changed the next stage of the inquiry, but not its conclusion. They had found a new object whose history needed to be established. Badu told Mabel that the most important question was not whether the ledger looked like the answer, but whether its provenance and contents could independently connect it to the disputed records.

The Question That Remained

After the dawn review, Badu returned alone to the evidence room and read the timeline from the beginning. He had expected the final review to reveal a single missing connection, but the record still contained several explanations that could fit the known facts. The discipline of the investigation required him to accept that a gap was not an invitation to invent what belonged inside it.

He wrote one question at the top of a fresh page: what independent record could connect the disputed circular to the ledger in storage? Beneath it he listed the receiving index, the accession sheet, and any duplicate retained by another office. He did not write a suspect's name. The next step had to begin with a document whose history could be checked, not with a person whose behaviour could be interpreted in several ways.

When he closed the folder, the fifth copy remained a possibility, not an established finding. The investigation had gained detail without reaching a resolution. Any account of the murder would have to rest on evidence specific to the death, not on an attempt to fold every administrative irregularity into the same story. The inquiries would remain separate unless evidence connected them.

CHAPTER TWENTY — THE SECOND TRUTH

The specialist refused to call it a signature, a name, or an order. It was an impression, he said, repeating the word before Badu could press him for anything more definite.

Under angled light, the reverse of the temporary-hold circular revealed the edge of a ruled table and fragments of three typed lines. Imaging improved the contrast, but it could not restore what the surface no longer preserved. No complete sentence was legible. One fragment resembled “...attachment five”; another might have been a date, though its final digit remained uncertain.

“Can you certify that it says attachment five?” Badu asked.

“No. I can certify that the image contains marks consistent with those characters. The surface does not preserve enough information for a reliable reading.”

The answer frustrated Badu, but it gave him a reliable limit. He asked that the images, method, and limitations appear together in the report. Removing the cautions would not strengthen the finding; it would misrepresent it.

Tetteh compared the table layout with surviving duplicate circular files. One form used the same columns: reference, description, number of

enclosures, destination. It was a common administrative template used by several offices for years. The impression might have come from a schedule, a receipt, or an unrelated sheet. “Attachment five” remained a possibility, not a finding.

They found a duplicate circular in a separate bound register before noon. Its wording matched the temporary-hold order, but the schedule was absent there too. The duplicate confirmed that the order had circulated. It did not identify which papers had been held. A note in the margin directed staff to consult an enclosure list maintained by the registry clerk.

That list had not been destroyed, according to the archive catalogue. It had been transferred during a reorganisation and given a new box number. The first box contained routine correspondence. The second contained lists of documents temporarily held for review. Some entries were complete; others had been crossed out and rewritten. The paper was old, but the ink varied. No one would decide from appearance alone whether the changes were improper.

The relevant date appeared on a single line. The description was abbreviated, the destination code was Desk C, and the enclosure count had been overwritten. The original number could not be read with confidence. Beside it, someone had written “return to origin after review.” No origin was named.

Badu studied the page without touching it. It offered their clearest documented route so far, yet left the contents of the transfer unidentified. The entry might concern the committee papers or another file processed that day. It named neither the “fifth copy” nor Room Four, Daniel, or Judge Agyeman.

“We can establish that a temporary-hold process operated,” he told the team. “We can establish that this entry belongs to the same date range and desk code. We cannot establish that it describes our missing document.”

A junior officer asked whether the overwritten enclosure count suggested tampering.

“It suggests a correction. We need to establish who made it, when, and under what procedure. A correction can be legitimate. Until we know more, an unexplained correction is a question, not an answer.”

The archive supervisor located the transfer sheet for the enclosure list. It bore two signatures: one from the clerk who packed the box and another from the officer who received it years later. The second was clear; the first was not. The dates matched the catalogue history. Nothing on the sheet proved that a page had been removed during transfer, but it could not establish that every page had been present when the box was packed.

Mabel came to the station late in the afternoon. She had received a new message from the anonymous

sender, this time with no demand attached. It read: “You have the route. You still don’t have the contents.”

Badu read it twice. “That is either a warning or a statement of the obvious.”

“Or someone wants us to believe they know what is in the archive,” Mabel said. “They may have seen the records, or they may be guessing from what we have reported. We can’t tell yet.”

She had not published the exact desk code or the wording of the enclosure list. The sender might have another source, or might simply be reacting to the public account of the search. Badu asked her to preserve the original message and not reply. The sender’s claimed knowledge remained unverified.

For the first time in weeks, Mabel considered that the fifth copy might never have existed as one finished document. The phrase could refer to a fifth duplicate, a fifth item in a sequence, or an informal label passed from one person to another until it acquired the weight of fact. He could not choose among those possibilities merely because one made the story neat.

“If we say the archive proves the fifth copy was hidden, we will be building a conclusion out of gaps,” she said. “But if we say nothing, the gaps will remain invisible.”

“Report the gaps,” Badu answered. “Report who was responsible for preserving the records, what the procedure required, and which questions remain

unanswered. Let the evidence be as incomplete as it is."

Her story described the temporary-hold order, the missing enclosure schedule, the later list, and the ambiguous Desk C entry. It explained how the archive could confirm a process without identifying the document involved. She did not allege that the acting administrator had concealed evidence or attribute an order to Ofori when someone else had signed it.

Her editor asked whether the story had resolved the mystery.

"It has changed the question," Mabel said. "We thought we were looking for a paper someone had taken. Now we have to ask whether anyone can identify that paper reliably in the first place."

Badu reviewed the case boards one last time. Under THE MURDER, he kept the evidence relevant to the judge's death: access, opportunity, the corridor-locking mechanism, and statements still requiring tests. Ofori's influence remained important, but the archive route neither placed him at the scene nor proved that he had ordered a file removed.

Under THE RECORDS, he listed the findings without overstating them: a temporary-hold order existed; its enclosure schedule was missing; a related registry list contained an ambiguous Desk C entry; and the packet's original contents remained unknown. The fifth copy

had not been located, and the fifth child had not been identified. Neither absence proved the other.

He removed a red thread that someone had drawn between the enclosure entry and Daniel's altered school form. Someone had placed it there as a reminder to investigate, yet its colour made the relationship look established. He replaced it with a plain note: POSSIBLE LEAD — NO DIRECT LINK ESTABLISHED.

The change was small but important. The board now separated what the team knew from what it suspected.

As the meeting concluded, Badu asked that the archive list be preserved, that a qualified document specialist examine the overwritten count, and that former registry staff be interviewed separately. He wanted to avoid a group recollection in which one person's theory might become another person's memory. He also asked the team to return to the murder evidence without letting the records inquiry dictate its conclusions.

That evening, Mabel opened her notebook to the page where she had first written "the fifth copy". Beneath it, she added: "A number is not an identity." She thought of Daniel, whose life had been pulled between names by official-looking documents and by people who treated official paper as though it could settle a human truth. The records mattered. So did the limits of what they could say.

She had no final name to publish and no complete document to photograph. She had a route, a procedure, a missing schedule, and an entry whose meaning remained uncertain. The story was not finished, but it had reached a more honest beginning.

Badu switched off the office lights. On one board, the question remained who had killed Judge Kweku Agyeman. On the other, the question was what had happened to a record that no surviving page could yet identify. They might eventually intersect. They might not. He would not decide in advance.

His phone vibrated once more. The message came from an unknown number, without the familiar insistence of the earlier notes. “The second truth is not the same as the first.”

Badu saved the message, logged its arrival, and placed the phone face down. It proved only that someone had sent those words. Tomorrow, they would return to the records, witnesses, and evidence they could test. For tonight, the two mysteries remained separate; any next conclusion would have to earn its place.

The Two Boards

Near midnight, Badu returned to the station after the archive team had gone home. The latest anonymous message had been logged, and he wanted to ensure that it changed neither inquiry’s handling. Under separate desk lamps, the two case boards remained as he had left them. He checked the evidence register

against the exhibits listed on each board, looking for anything moved without a corresponding record.

The murder board held the study-access records, the duplicate key's tested operation, accounts from people present that evening, and time limits supported by independent records. The records board held the temporary-hold order, the incomplete schedule, the transfer list, and the uncertain identity of the missing item. Where a name appeared in both inquiries, its source and relevance had to be documented separately.

He removed the handwritten note "Ofori — fifth copy?" because it tied a suspect's name to an unverified theory. Instead, he entered two separate tasks in the action log: determine what evidence, if any, connected Ofori to the judge's death; and identify, if possible, the document missing from the registry trail. Each task would have its own exhibits, witness interviews, and review date.

Mabel arrived to collect the public-records summary. She noticed the revised board and asked whether the team had changed its view of Ofori.

"We have changed the way we record the question," Badu said. "Our view must follow the evidence, not the other way around."

Before she left, Mabel's phone lit with another message from the unknown sender: "You have separated the questions. Someone will try to join them

for you.” She showed Badu the screen. He recorded the time, number displayed, and exact wording, then asked her to preserve the original message and avoid replying.

They did not treat the message as proof of a threat or as evidence that the sender knew the team’s internal decisions. Badu requested a documented assessment of what could lawfully be learned from its technical details. He also compared its wording with earlier messages, without assuming they came from the same author.

After Mabel left, Badu confirmed that the archive requests and murder-evidence tasks had been assigned separately wherever practical. A later finding might connect the inquiries, but a shared name or code would not be enough. Each lead had to be tested on its own evidence.

The Briefing Before the Prosecutor

At the next briefing, Badu asked each investigator to identify the strongest source for a proposed conclusion and the most serious limitation of that source. He wanted every claim traced to a document, a direct observation, or a test with a recorded method and known limitations.

One draft said the temporary-hold circular proved that a schedule had been concealed. Another said the duplicate key placed Ofori at the judge’s door. A third treated Daniel’s school form as proof that his identity

had been deliberately changed. Badu set each draft beside its supporting material and challenged the team to identify what additional fact would be needed to justify the wording.

The revisions were specific. The circular showed that an order had circulated, but not what its absent schedule contained. The key had operated the test cylinder, but no evidence identified its user or established when it had been used. The school form carried an annotation whose author and date remained uncertain. The summary now distinguished established facts from competing explanations and the evidence still needed to test them.

Mabel read the revised summary. “It sounds less conclusive than the version we started with.”

“Because the evidence is less conclusive than the version we started with,” Badu said. “Our job is to make the report accurate, not satisfying.”

They set out the next actions in order: retrieve the original accession ledger; obtain an independent examination of the overwritten enclosure count; trace the missing schedule through each recorded transfer; and continue testing the evidence specific to the judge’s death. Each action included a responsible officer and a record of what result would count as confirmation, contradiction, or no answer.

Badu replaced the old summary with the action list and review dates. He left disputed links on the board

as questions, removing the arrows that made them look established. The case remained difficult, but the next steps could now be tracked and assessed.

As the team dispersed, Mabel returned to her desk to prepare the public-records summary. The anonymous sender might know more than the messages revealed, or might simply be exploiting information already public. She recorded both possibilities without choosing between them. The next request went to the archive, not to the suspect.

The Ledger in Storage — Examining the Transfer Trail

The archive supervisor called before the team's morning briefing. A transfer ledger had been found in a carton whose number differed from the current catalogue. The discovery was not announced as a breakthrough. Badu asked the supervisor to leave the carton where it was until the evidence officer could photograph the label, shelf, neighbouring boxes, and the condition of the seal. A ledger discovered in storage could be important, but its history from the time of storage to the present had to be documented first.

The team opened the carton under observation and compared the contents with the relocation sheet. The ledger contained transfer entries from several departments, including a month that overlapped with the disputed records. One afternoon's page was present, but its count column had been overwritten.

The original figure could not be read clearly without specialist examination. The destination field contained a short code that might correspond to Desk C, although the codebook was still needed to confirm the interpretation.

Badu asked the archive supervisor to describe how the carton had been stored and whether it had been moved since the catalogue changed. The supervisor produced a relocation list showing two movements, one of them recorded only by an abbreviated signature. The signature could not yet be attributed. The team photographed the list and requested staff samples through the formal process. They did not treat the abbreviated mark as evidence of wrongdoing; it was another part of the ledger's custody history that needed explanation.

Mabel read the entries surrounding the disputed page. They concerned ordinary transfers, returns, and corrections. The presence of routine business was important because it showed the ledger was not a single-purpose document created around the case. It also meant that a suspicious-looking entry had to be assessed within the normal pattern of the office. She noted the neighbouring records and asked for the same level of scrutiny to be applied to entries that appeared unremarkable.

The ledger clarified part of the enclosure list's route, but it could not show that every page had travelled with it. A transfer entry might describe a bundle

without itemising its contents; the missing schedule might have been attached, filed separately, or omitted from the beginning. Badu placed the ledger beside the receiving-office receipt. The team marked each detail as corroborated or tentative. The finding was limited, but it was more useful than a theory built around a single document.

At day's end, the team agreed that the discovery had advanced the records inquiry without resolving the murder. Independent evidence was still needed to account for the judge's final hours. The fifth child's identity, meanwhile, remained unconfirmed. Badu watched the ledger being resealed. Its survival through years in storage explained nothing by itself. The entries might yet reveal the route they needed; for now, they offered a sharper question, not a final answer.

The Timeline Check Before Dawn

Before sunrise, Badu convened a short review focused on dates rather than theories. The team placed the independently logged records in chronological order and marked the source for each date. Extracts without their source pages were set aside, as were handwritten summaries whose wording could not be traced to a contemporaneous record.

The specialist arranged the circular, dispatch references, and images of the pressure marks in separate groups. The recovered ledger remained

sealed while its custody history was checked. Mabel read the timeline aloud, stopping at every point where a date depended on recollection rather than a dated record. One witness's remembered date differed from the registry entry by a day; the discrepancy was recorded, not silently corrected.

The prosecutor asked what changed if the anonymous messages were excluded from the analysis. Badu removed them from the timeline. The documentary sequence still showed a temporary-hold process and an incomplete record of enclosures, but it no longer appeared to indicate that the sender had guided the team toward a particular interpretation. The messages would remain a separate line of inquiry until their source and knowledge could be assessed.

Daniel arrived with a note from his aunt correcting a date she had previously supplied. The correction did not settle the question of his early records, but it explained why two family accounts had appeared to conflict. Mabel added the note to the chronology, preserved the earlier version, and marked the point as amended on the strength of the new account rather than erasing the discrepancy.

Badu asked the team to check whether any conclusion depended on the disputed date. One proposed sequence did; when the date was treated as uncertain, the sequence could no longer establish that the registry movement and Daniel's school record belonged to the same chain of events. The team

revised the timeline and added a request for independent corroboration. No one treated the correction as proof for or against a connection.

By the end of the review, the chronology was less tidy but more reliable. Mabel closed the folders after confirming that the original entries, the correction, and the reason for the change had all been preserved. Progress depended on obtaining the missing source records and testing the remaining dates, not on making the timeline look complete.

A MYSTERY OF HIDDEN RECORDS, BURIED TRUTHS, AND THE PRICE OF SILENCE

When a respected judge is found dead under suspicious circumstances, Mabel Owusu and Detective Kwame Badu are drawn into a web of hidden records, anonymous messages, and a mysterious duplicate key.

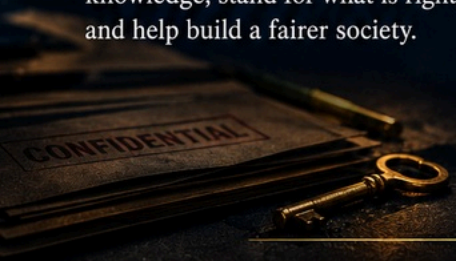
As the investigation deepens, a missing packet and a numbered copy raise questions that reach far beyond one crime. Each discovery brings them closer to a truth someone has worked hard to keep buried.

In *The Fifth Copy*, justice depends not on the loudest accusation, but on the evidence that survives scrutiny.

ABOUT THE AUTHOR



Emmanuel Osei Ninsin is an educator, student leader, and aspiring lawyer with a strong interest in education, leadership, and justice. Through his studies and writing, he hopes to encourage young people to pursue knowledge, stand for what is right, and help build a fairer society.



A STORY OF TRUTH, JUSTICE AND HOPE.